

The Machinery of Manipulation

Illicit Election Manipulation and Authoritarian Regime Resilience

Cole J. Harvey

2026-03-17

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Author Information

Email: cole.j.harvey@okstate.edu

Affiliation: Oklahoma State University

Website: <https://colejharvey.github.io/>

Note: Finished early draft; please do not circulate.

Chapter 1

Introduction

Two small, individual stories illustrate the central aims of this book. The first of these stories concerns Marina Tarakanova, who served as deputy chair of a precinct election commission in the seaside city of Gelendzhik (Krasnodar Krai) in 2022. Tarakanova was helping to oversee the voting for the regional legislature in her precinct; she was confronted (and filmed) by Ilona Grachevskaya, a candidate for office from the Communist Party of the Russian Federation. The video shows Grachevskaya accusing Tarakanova of hiding pre-filled ballots. Seated comfortably, Tarakanova refuses to move until Grachevskaya, the candidate, successfully gets the police involved.

Upon instructions from an officer, Tarakanova stands, revealing the stack of ballots upon which she has been sitting; the officer rifles through the stack, showing that each has been pre-marked in favor of United Russia (“Administration of Gelendzhik: Get your butt off of our elections!” 2023). The video drew widespread publicity, to the extent that the Central Election Commission felt compelled address the issue in a televised session. The Chair of the Commission, Ella Pamfilova, scolded officials, noting that the ambitions of any party, candidate, or official are not worth the risk to the individual contemplating fraud. “It is not worth it, for this pretty young woman Tarakanova to risk her own personal reputation, along with the reputations of the election commission and the whole electoral system,” Pamfilova said. Speaking to regional election officials, Pamfilova said “I want you to carefully examine why she did this. What motivated her? (Anton Voloschenko 2022)”

In the case of Marina Tarakanova, the chair of the CEC need not have troubled herself overmuch to find a plausible explanation. According to public records, Tarakanova’s occupation was ‘main specialist’ in the department of mobilization work (i.e. the department which manages public resources for civil defense; Krasnodar Krai is a border region). For this work, her declared income in 2021 was 2,900,000 rubles: a very handsome sum for a civil servant in a region where the average yearly income was only 590,000 rubles. Her husband declared an additional income of 646,000 rubles (Maria Gridina 2022). Despite their large joint income, the couple declared renting only a small

flat along with ownership of two modest vehicles (Maria Gridina 2022), though it is not unheard of for officials to omit luxury assets from such declarations (Szakonyi 2025). As a municipal employee, Tarakanova's lucrative position—and possible future opportunities for enrichment that may exist in the civil defense sector—may have hinged on delivering satisfactory electoral results for United Russia, which dominates the regional legislature.

Whether she was indeed motivated by such patronage concerns will not be known, since—despite appeals to law enforcement by election observers, the KPRF, and even (tepidly) the ruling party (Anton Voloschenko 2022)—there has been no public investigation of the case. The chair of the regional election commission asserted that law enforcement was investigating the incident just days later (Anton Voloschenko 2022), however, no charges appear to have ever been brought against Tarakanova. Even before the incident, election monitors have for years complained to the courts in Krasnodar Krai that the regional Investigative Committee (i.e. the state organ responsible for criminal investigations) has been quashing complaints of electoral crimes in the region (“Court in Gelendzhik Tires of the Inactivity of the Investigative Committee” 2021).

Other individuals, operating in different regions and perhaps lacking important connections, have not fared so well in the Russian legal system. In 2012, former precinct election chair Tatiana Arkhipova was convicted in court of stuffing 150 ballots in favor of United Russia's mayoral candidate into the ballot box, while destroying 150 opposition ballots. For this, and the subsequent forgery of the election protocol, she was fined 100,000 rubles.¹ In 2023, two teachers from Orenburg were convicted of falsifying votes and fined over 260,000 rubles—about six months' average annual wage for the region. Each year in Russia, a small number of election commissioners are convicted of falsification (Torochashnikova 2021), while many more are convicted of lesser administrative violations of electoral procedure. While real jail time is almost unheard of (Torochashnikova 2021), those who are convicted regularly receive substantial fines and/or suspended prison sentences.²

Even when convicted individuals face light sentences, there are considerable downsides to becoming a convicted criminal in Russia. For instance, Article 351.1 of Russia's Labor Code prohibits those who “have or *have had* a criminal record, *are subject to or have been subject to* criminal prosecution” (emphasis added) for a variety of crimes from working in the field of education broadly; the listed crimes include crimes ‘against freedom of the individual’, a heading in the Russian criminal code which includes electoral manipulation. Since many of those who are pressured into manipulating elections are precinct election commissioners are teachers (Forrat 2018), exposure to the legal system also exposes these individuals to the possible loss of their career. Indeed, the

¹ It is perhaps important to note that Arkhipova's case coincided with considerable turnover in the mayor's office; before her conviction, the candidate on whose behalf Arkhipova had tampered with the election was himself convicted of bribery, removed from office, and issued a fine of 18 million rubles. Three new mayors had since served in rapid succession (“Head of Moscow-area election commission fined for falsification of votes” 2012). To foreshadow the argument to come, such disruption in the local patronage structure may have altered United Russia's willingness or ability to protect some local agents from legal consequences.

² This is a status similar to probation; the convicted person must regularly check in with a probationary officer and avoid committing any other infractions during the period of a suspended sentence.

law requires educational institutions to suspend teachers from work for the duration of legal proceedings (“Criminals allowed to work with children” 2015), depriving individuals of income for weeks or months.

These examples are, of course, peculiarities of the Russian legal system. But they serve to highlight the intertwined complexities that can arise out of a criminal prosecution or conviction (Kirk & Wakefield 2018; Pager 2003); these consequences can be expected to arise in authoritarian regimes, where courts often perform their ordinary functions outside of political cases (Ginsburg & Moustafa 2008; Shen-Bayh 2022) while serving to uphold regime legitimacy through law and order (Cheesman 2015; Whiting 2017). Front-line election actors, who are typically placed fairly low in their patronage network, expose themselves to these kinds of risks and consequences when they participate in ballot stuffing, election fraud, and other forms of illegal electoral manipulation. Such exposure is not purely theoretical, as the examples from Russia—a relatively closed electoral authoritarian regime—demonstrate.

Stories like those of the two teachers who were fined a quarter of a million rubles each largely go unremarked upon, outside of the local press and the websites of determined election monitors. Among scholars of electoral manipulation and authoritarian stability, they have likewise received little attention. Instead, researchers have often—understandably—focused on mass protest as a downstream consequence of rigged elections. Such events are hard to ignore; they often involve great physical courage and resilience on the part of the protesters, provide compelling images for national and international media, and occasionally result in the downfall of authoritarian governments. Events like the 1986 People Power Revolution in the Philippines, Ukraine’s 2004 Orange Revolution, or the 2005 Tulip Revolution in Kyrgyzstan have taken a central place in theories of electoral manipulation.

The dramatic and consequential events highlighted for many observers the considerable risk that incumbents entertain when they manipulate elections. The cost of such manipulation is paid in lost popular legitimacy (Birch 2011); when an election appears sufficiently fraudulent, costly and potentially destabilizing citizen resistance can occur. Or, as others framed it, the use of election manipulation *reveals* the regime’s existing lack of popular legitimacy, making opposition parties more confident in their chances of successfully ousting the incumbent through protest (Fearon 2011; Little 2012; Little *et al.* 2015a; Magaloni 2010). Qualitative studies further developed the importance of opposition parties and civil society organizations in detecting and publicizing evidence of manipulation, in order to improve the likelihood of protest success (Bunce & Wolchik 2006). This overall approach, in which electoral manipulation imposes a cost on manipulators in the form of costly risk to their tenure in office, has become a commonplace assumption in the literature on election manipulation.

In this book, I offer significant challenges to this assumption, which I describe as the *regime-weakness model of electoral manipulation*. Instead, building on work by Simpser (Simpser 2013), Rundlett and Svolik (Rundlett & Svolik 2016), and myself (Harvey 2016, 2019, 2022a), I develop a *regime-strength* model of electoral manipulation in non-democracies, grounded in the principal-agent dynamics between political leaders and election-rigging subordinates. The regime-strength model address several

questions that are puzzling under the regime-weakness framework: why does election manipulation persist in places where protest risk is high (as evidenced by the Color Revolutions themselves)? Why do incumbents often claim unbelievably high electoral results (like Belarusian president Aleksandr Lukashenko's ostensible 81 percent vote-share—with 84 percent turnout!—in 2020), if election manipulation is cheap talk that is likely to prompt costly protest? More pragmatically, it points toward alternative measures of improving electoral integrity, beyond reliance on the public to act as a sort of natural immune system against rigged elections (Fearon 2011). To effectively improve electoral integrity, reformers and opposition actors must interrupt the machinery of manipulation by breaking the links between political principals and election-rigging agents.

The regime-strength model of electoral manipulation offers a pessimistic prognosis: the authoritarian incumbents who are best at rigging elections are also likely to be the best at surviving protest movements. The capacities and resources that authoritarian leaders need to engage the machinery of manipulation are some of the same capacities needed to control society more broadly: extensive patronage networks, pliant judiciaries, and cooperative security services. Moreover, the more incumbents face a credible opposition threat, the *more* incentivized they are to build those capacities. As a result, the regime-strength model makes predictions that are diametrically opposed to those of the standard model; namely, electoral manipulation is likely to be more severe when protest risk is higher, and (if protests do occur), more manipulation is likely to be associated with quicker defeat for protest movements.

Multiparty elections are a fundamental component of post-Cold War authoritarian politics (Donno 2013; Gandhi & Lust-Okar 2009; Magaloni & Kricheli 2010). Elections have been found to have multiple benefits for authoritarian regime survival, including through the co-optation of certain electoral blocs (Gandhi & Przeworski 2006; Gandhi & Przeworski 2007; Reuter & Robertson 2015), the recruitment of effective politicians and agents (Greene 2007; Lust-Okar 2006), the revelation of information about political actors (Miller 2013; Simpser 2013), and the promotion of domestic and international legitimacy (Isiksel & Pepinsky 2025; Levitsky & Way 2010). Election manipulation is at the core of this process in authoritarian regimes. Authoritarian leaders use of a suite of tools (Schedler 2002a) to manage the uncertainty inherent in elections, which, after all, provide a focal point for opposition activity (Knutsen *et al.* 2017). To reduce the risk of electoral loss at the outset, authoritarian incumbents often deploy pre-election restrictions (Bækken 2015; Popova 2012; Szakonyi 2021), repression (Bhasin & Gandhi 2013), favorable institutional frameworks (Birch 2007; Golosov 2017; Ong 2018; Tan 2013).

However, these tools alone are often insufficient to achieve incumbents' aims. Electoral institutions that were fit for purpose years ago may no longer serve the regime's needs. An unexpectedly popular challenger may emerge. Economic conditions can deteriorate, damaging the incumbent's popularity. Even when pre-election rigging is working as expected, incumbents still need a mechanism to drive high turnout in uncompetitive elections. Finally, incumbents can use their control over resources and ability to break the rules to send signals of dominance that make other actors in society

more apt to cooperate (Gehlbach & Simpser 2015; Simpser 2013). To accomplish these goals, incumbents frequently turn to illegal forms of manipulation occur on or just before election day: vote-buying, voter pressure, ballot-stuffing, and outright falsification of results.

Consequently, the findings of this book improve our understanding of more than electoral manipulation alone. By identifying when electoral manipulation efforts are likely to succeed or fail, and what kinds of regimes are most likely to succeed, this book sheds light on major theoretical issues in comparative politics. These include, most directly, the stability of authoritarian regimes and the likelihood of further autocratization. They also provide insights into the role elections play in democratization, and they have some implications for democratic backsliding.

1.1 Existing explanations of electoral manipulation, and their limitations

Election manipulation has long been understood to impose costs on incumbents in the form of lost legitimacy. In an early influential study of historical electoral manipulation in Costa Rica, Lehoucq and Molina argue that the shift to more coercive and illegitimate forms of electoral manipulation “scandalized major sectors of the public,” contributing to anti-government insurrections in the 1940s (Lehoucq & Molina 2002). The concept of the ‘legitimacy cost’ of manipulation (in contrast to its organizational resource cost) was developed at length by Birch (2011), who argues that “feared loss of legitimacy—domestic and international—is the most significant deterrent to electoral manipulation” (p. 56). Drawing on World Values Survey data, Norris (2014) finds some empirical evidence of legitimacy costs along several dimensions.

As the literature developed, events like the Color Revolutions figured prominently in theories of election manipulation and how it might be restrained. The role of legitimacy loss—and protest risk in particular—in preventing electoral manipulation has become especially influential in the formal modeling tradition. In some models, use of electoral manipulation is itself a signal of low incumbent legitimacy. According to this logic, fearing the potential costs of mass protests, some incumbents may instead opt to hold relatively fair elections. This approach carries a normatively hopeful message: strong opposition movements—those that are well-organized, well-funded, and enjoy broad public support—can effectively discourage incumbents from manipulating elections. As a result, the chances of democratic transition and consolidation increase. I refer to this as the “regime-weakness model” of manipulation.

There are, generally speaking, two versions of the regime-weakness model. These are illustrated in Figure 1.1. In both versions, weaker incumbents are defined by their low popularity and low likelihood of winning a clean election. This gives them an incentive to produce more electoral manipulation, to overcome their electoral weakness. However, doing so also creates risks. In the first, depicted in Panel A, awareness of electoral manipulation induces a loss of legitimacy among the public (Birch 2011); in other words, people are upset at violations of procedural justice (Cho & Kim 2016),

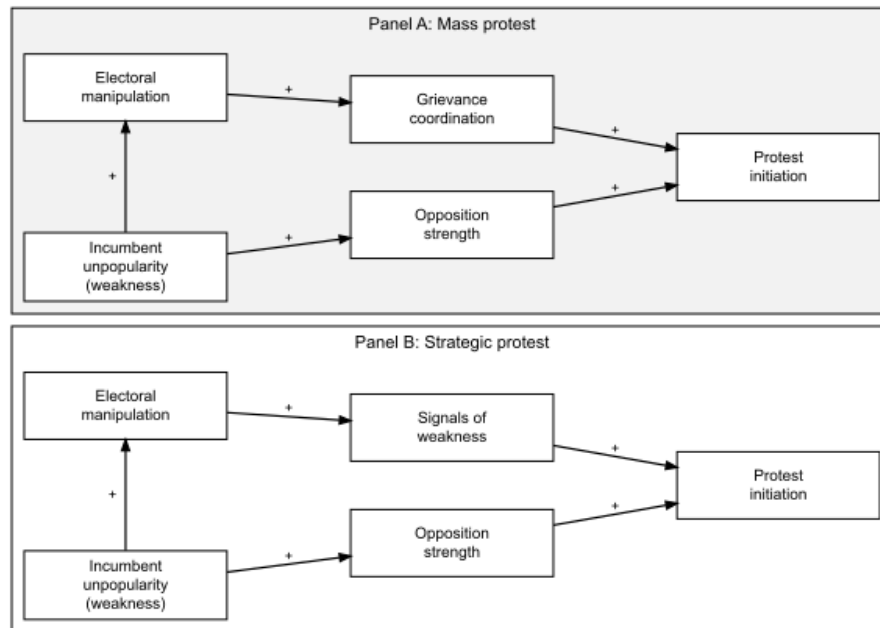


Figure 1.1: Regime-weakness models of electoral manipulation and opposition protest

and especially incensed if they believe the election was ‘stolen’ (Kuntz & Thompson 2009; Tucker 2007). The focal point of the election allows individuals with diverse grievances to overcome their collective action problems and mobilize against the incumbent (Tucker 2007). The more costly the expected protest, the more an incumbent is disincentivized to rely on extensive electoral manipulation.

In the second approach, incumbent weakness is formally built into models of electoral manipulation. In this approach, electoral protest is modeled as a strategic decision by a rational opposition actor. The incumbent’s likelihood of defeating the protest movement is typically assumed to be equivalent to its popularity. Election fraud is a tool that allows unpopular incumbents to win elections; thus, when the opposition detects fraud it revises its belief about the incumbent’s popularity downward. Election fraud can get the incumbent across the finish line in the election, but at the risk of signaling weakness to the opposition and prompting a costly protest response. This type of model predicts that opposition parties that are more capable of mobilizing protest, as well as institutional and contextual features that expose manipulation efforts, help deter election manipulation (Chernykh & Svolik 2015; Little 2012; Luo & Rozenas 2020). Figure 1.1 illustrates this logic in Panel B. As the figure shows, both versions of the regime-weakness model imply that weaker incumbents face some baseline risk of protest due to their weakness / unpopularity, but that incumbents increase the risk of mass protest the more they rely on electoral manipulation (Beaulieu 2014; Little 2012; Little *et al.* 2015b; Luo & Rozenas 2017; Schedler 2002b). By the same token, they can reduce the

risk of protest by holding cleaner elections.³

The regime-weakness model produces some conceptual puzzles. Why, for instance, do incumbents claim excessive margins of victory (indicating massive falsification), if falsification is a signal of weakness? Under the regime-weakness model, the occurrence of post-election protest is *the* sign that informal negotiations between the incumbent and the opposition have broken down (Beaulieu 2014); the incumbent has manipulated ‘too much’ given the opposition’s strength. Given that the incumbent can choose how much election fraud to implement, why do we observe protest—what prevents incumbents from ‘correctly’ targeting the level of election fraud? And, perhaps most puzzling, why is it that most electoral protests fail to oust incumbents?

Scholars have, of course, advanced answers to these questions. Incumbents may claim unbelievably large margins of victory because that is what the opposition expects; perhaps it is the deviation from this expectation that triggers protest (Little 2012). Manipulated elections that trigger protest may occur due to incomplete information, as both sides overestimate their chances of success in a post-election conflict (Smyth 2020). Likewise, over-optimistic opposition actors may produce the surfeit of unsuccessful protests that we observe.

Alternative answers to these questions are proposed in Simpser’s (2013) model of electoral manipulation as a costly signal of incumbents’ resources and capacities, which in turn influence other actors’ expectations of the likelihood the incumbent will remain in office. Incumbents who blatantly or excessively manipulate elections demonstrate they have deep financial and organizational resources, and a willingness to break the law. In turn, elites, political parties, bureaucrats, and ordinary citizens expect the incumbent to remain in office in the future; these expectations lead to cooperative behavior with the incumbent, helping entrench their rule (Simpser 2013). According to this view, manipulation does not (merely) reveal a lack of popularity, but may also highlight other forms of resilience that can offset low public approval. A simplified illustration of Simpser’s approach is presented in Figure 1.2.

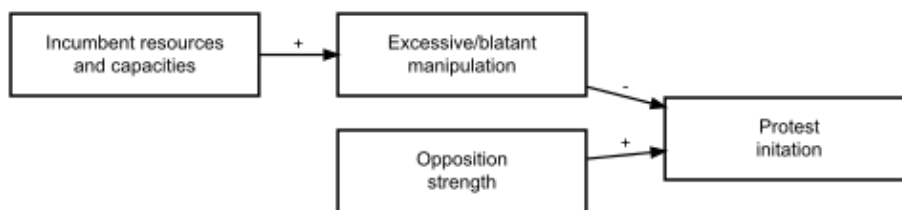


Figure 1.2: Simpser’s model of electoral manipulation and opposition protest

As Figures 1.1 and 1.2 show, it should in principle be straightforward to distinguish be-

³Readers who are familiar with the directed acyclic graph notation for causal relationships will also note that incumbent unpopularity / weakness is positioned as a confounder of the relationship between election manipulation and protest initiation. Since it is difficult for even incumbents in authoritarian regimes to gauge their true popularity (much less outside analysts), it is difficult to close this ‘backdoor path’ and assess the validity of this model.

tween these two models empirically. In the regime-weakness model, electoral manipulation increases the risk of post-election protest; in the Simpson model, manipulation reduces the likelihood of protest (so long as it is excessive and/or blatant). However, empirical studies have not been able to conclusively settle this debate. Some studies have found that increased manipulation is associated with greater likelihood of protest, as the regime-weakness model would predict, while others have found no effect (Ananyev & Poyker 2022; Daxecker 2012; Hafner-Burton *et al.* 2016; Hyde & Marinov 2014b; Lankina & Skovoroda 2017). A straightforward selection between the competing models of electoral manipulation has eluded the field, as a result.

1.2 Theory in brief

In this book, I propose an alternative conceptualization of how electoral manipulation relates to authoritarian regime resilience and protest, by integrating Simpson’s argument with more recent work uncovering the principal-agent relationships inherent in electoral manipulation efforts. I call this the regime-strength model of electoral manipulation, and argue that it best explains the use and consequences of electoral manipulation techniques. Figure 1.3 illustrates the regime-strength model.

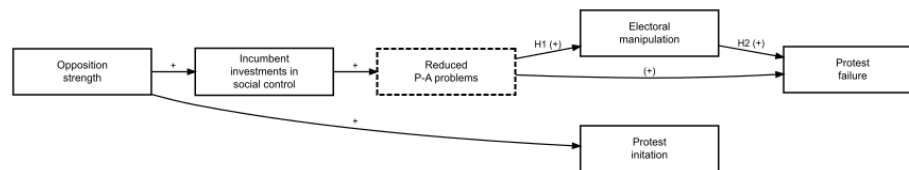


Figure 1.3: A regime-strength model of electoral manipulation and opposition protest

Incumbents in authoritarian regimes face the risk of revolutionary uprising as well as the risk of insider defection (Svolik 2012). These risks can be intertwined (Sato & Wahman 2019), as mass protest can spark elite defections (Río 2022), and elites who split from the ruling coalition can use their own resources to stoke mass protest (Robertson 2010). When faced with relatively greater dangers to their position, whether it be mass- or elite-driven, incumbents in authoritarian regimes invest in various means of social control. To reduce the risk of being ousted, leaders will adjust institutions, attempt to purge elites or reduce their influence, shower benefits on cronies, and engage in repressive measures (Bueno de Mesquita *et al.* 2005). They build parties of power that channel patronage resources and elite ambitions (Greene 2007; Magaloni 2008; Reuter 2010; Reuter & Remington 2009), and co-opt their rivals using access to rents (Blaydes 2011; Gandhi 2008; Reuter & Robertson 2015). They censor traditional and social media in order to control the flow of information (Geddes & Zaller 1989; King *et al.* 2013; Lankina *et al.* 2020). They fine-tune the independence of courts in order to optimize both political control and perceived legitimacy (Ginsburg & Moustafa 2008). And they build, deploy, and take pains to coup-proof the security forces to manage threats (Bhasin & Gandhi 2013; Davenport 1995; Makara 2013). The greater the threats faced by incumbents, the more they are motivated to develop these tools of control in order to retain their position

(Svolik 2012), all the more so, since loss of incumbency in an authoritarian regime often comes with steep personal penalties (e.g. loss of assets, imprisonment, exile, or death).

In their efforts to govern and remain in power, authoritarian leaders must also contend with substantial principal-agent problems. Not even the most powerful dictator can rule alone. They require the cooperation of a vast network of actors, ranging from their immediate subordinates to mid-level bureaucrats and elites, all the way down to ordinary citizens. At every stage, a subordinate's goals may diverge from those of the leader. The leader's closest allies are often the very ones who oust him; the very repressive forces which the dictator relies on to defend the regime from mass uprising may use their resources to topple him (Chin *et al.* 2023; Svolik 2012).

To keep the repressive apparatus loyal, the dictator must offer them spoils—but not too much, lest they use their resources to overthrow the boss (Dragu & Przeworski 2019). Likewise, the incumbent may tolerate some level of corruption among his subordinates, but excessive corruption threatens mass unrest and also deprives the leader himself of some sources of rents; on the other hand, individuals have strong incentives to extract as much as they can from their positions of power. The incumbent may wish for judges to rule in his favor, but those judges may be eyeing the possibility that the opposition will take power, and hedge their bets (Helmke 2012; Hilbink 2007; Popova 2012). Finally, the individuals charged with manipulating an election on the leader's behalf may have their own incentives to shirk, either to pocket their payments or to avoid exposure (Harvey 2019; Rundlett & Svolik 2016).

Incumbents can mitigate these principal-agent problems through monitoring and punishing defection (Ginsburg 2008), though this can be difficult given the opaque information environment and agents' incentives to misrepresent their behavior (Boix & Svolik 2013; Tutumlu & Rustemov 2021). Loyalty can be assured through shared characteristics between leader and agent (Svolik 2009), like extended family ties, or shared revolutionary experience (Levitsky & Way 2012). More generally, incumbents work to ensure that their subordinates' incentives are aligned with their own; that is, that they will be genuinely loyal out of self-interest (Egorov & Sonin 2011). A fundamental key to maintaining agents' loyalty is the power of expectations (Hale 2014). If I expect the incumbent to be in power tomorrow, with the attendant ability to reward and punish, I am more incentivized to work on his behalf today. This, of course, becomes a self-fulfilling prophecy: the more agents are incentivized to work on the incumbent's behalf today, the more likely he is to remain in office tomorrow.

In electoral authoritarian regimes, election manipulation has a central role in this dynamic. On one hand, successful election manipulation is essential for setting up the expectation that the incumbent's time in office will continue indefinitely. On the other hand, as with other aspects of authoritarian politics, the likelihood of 'successful' manipulation is itself subject to principal-agent problems (Harvey 2019; Rundlett & Svolik 2016). This means that, as incumbents respond to threats to their power by investing in the repressive apparatus, installing loyalists in key positions, centralizing control over patronage resources, and so on, they also reduce agency loss among election-manipulating agents. When those agents' incentives are more closely aligned with the leader's, because of the leader's increasingly well-developed tools of social control, it

is more likely that they will carry out their duties. In particular, as developed in more detail in the next chapter, I argue that centralize control over patronage networks and minimizing personal risks to agents (especially through compliant police and courts) reduces agency loss among election manipulating agents.

This theory produces two direct hypotheses, and one indirect implication. First, it holds that electoral manipulation should increase in severity with opposition strength and with indicators of social control (i.e. low risk to agents, high resource control by the incumbent). Second, it predicts that increased electoral manipulation will be associated with a greater risk of *protest failure*—that is, with the likelihood that incumbents will defeat protest movements. Part of this effect, I argue, is directly attributable to manipulation itself. The more intensively an incumbent is able to manipulate the election, the more he signals that he has overcome a variety of principal-agent problems. This complements Simpser's view that excessive manipulation transmits information about the regime's capabilities. The more severely the election is manipulated, the more confident other regime actors will feel in the likelihood that the regime will survive the protest threat. In turn, they are more motivated to support the incumbent and deprive the opposition of support. Part of the relationship, however, is not causal—incumbents who are good at manipulating elections are also good at social control generally, making them more likely to defeat challengers.

This theory also offers an explanation for the mixed relationship between manipulation and protest that has been observed in the data. In this model, contrary to both the regime-weakness and Simpser approaches, there is no direct linkage between the degree of electoral manipulation and protest initiation. Instead, the occurrence of electoral protest is driven by the existence of the election and opposition strength, not by the degree to which the election has been rigged. Elections, at any level of integrity, create opportunities for contestation. The stronger an opposition group is—i.e. the more popular, unified, and well-resourced it is—the more likely it is to stage post-election protest. Whether electoral manipulation is associated with high or low levels of manipulation is contingent on the degree to which the incumbent has developed tools of social control. Where such tools are well developed in response to opposition strength, we should expect to see severe manipulation and a high likelihood of protest. However, when the incumbent has been less successful in developing tools of control, we are likely to observe protest in the context of a weakly manipulated election. The relationship that scholars find in their work, thus, hinges on case selection.

The mechanism posited in this theory—specifically, that risks to agents exacerbate principal-agent problems inherent in election manipulation—also offers testable implications. I argue that local agents are sensitive to the risk of exposure and punishment, even if the top patron(s) are likely to remain in office after the election. This has implications for the type of electoral manipulation that incumbents will be able to induce agents to generate. When the risk of exposure and punishment is high, agents will be less willing to carry out the forms of manipulation which are most easily attributable to specific individuals. In particular, in higher-risk contexts (for agents), it will become increasingly difficult for patrons to induce election officials to engage in fraud, falsification, and ballot-stuffing. This is because such activities are easy attributable

to the perpetrator: known individuals whose electoral malfeasance occurs at a fixed place and time. When they have the resources to do so, incumbents will compensate for this by recruiting different agents to engage in less attributable forms of manipulation: multiple voting, vote-buying, and voter-pressure. Such techniques are most less cost-effective for patrons, and—by directly involving voters—generate legitimacy costs. Nevertheless, incumbents are forced to rely on such techniques when election officials are unwilling to participate in fraud schemes.

Lastly, the claim that agents face criminal-legal risks, and respond to it, is itself testable. By comparing court records with election-forensic analysis of subsequent elections, it is possible to demonstrate that electoral manipulation appears to decrease after a local agent faces harsh punishment in the courts for electoral malfeasance (but *increases* when agents are let off easy).

1.3 Plan of the book

Chapter 2 develops the regime-strength model of manipulation in more detail; subsequent chapters explore empirical implications of the model. Chapter 3 tests the three main hypotheses of the book on a cross-national dataset of electoral authoritarian regimes from 1989 to 2012. Combining data from NELDA (Hyde & Marinov 2012), V-Dem version 15 (Coppedge *et al.* 2025b), and the Electoral Contention and Violence dataset (Daxecker *et al.* 2019), the quantitative analysis shows that 1) electoral protest is more likely to occur when elections are highly manipulated but oppositions are strong, but not when elections are highly manipulated and oppositions are weak, 2) that protest movements are defeated more quickly in cases where the incumbent manipulated more extensively, and 3) that incumbents facing a greater risk of protest tend to manipulate *more* than those facing a low risk of protest.

Subsequent chapters test the mechanisms of the theory. Chapter 4 uses precinct-level election data from ten Russian national elections from 2001 to 2021. Each election produces data from roughly 100,000 precincts, amounting to a total of approximately one million data points. These results are nested within Russia's regions. This allows for a comparative analysis of election outcomes across regions, while holding the national-level political context constant each election year. I use election forensic techniques to estimate the degree of election fraud and vote-buying / ballot-stuffing in each region-year. Taking these estimates as dependent variables shows that increasing local risk of exposure leads to reduced election falsification, but *increased* ballot-stuffing and vote-buying. This result supports the principal-agent mechanism of the regime-strength model, showing that incumbents still desire rigged elections when risk of exposure is high, but agents are less willing to put themselves at risk.

Chapter 5 applies similar election-forensic techniques to evaluate the theory in the context of Ukrainian elections, from 2002 to 2014. In comparison with the Russian case, Ukraine allows for a test of the theory in a more competitive, more democratic environment where patronage networks and weak rule of law are nevertheless present. The results are informative, especially in comparison with those in Russia. In Ukraine, where

the risk of exposure is higher than in Russia, falsification by election officials is rare.

Chapter 6 uses original data from the Russian court system to show how electoral crimes are handled in a highly authoritarian context, and how legal penalties for agents in one election reverberate to the next. To construct this original dataset, I scraped the Russian legal database sudact.ru for election-related court outcomes. Of the several thousand such cases, I hand-coded the outcome for perpetrators in the few hundred cases that relate to election falsification. I then match these outcomes to subsequent election results in the region; the statistical analysis shows that when agents face stiff penalties (i.e. large fines or jail time), subsequent election fraud in the region declines significantly. Light penalties, on the other hand, are associated with subsequent increases in fraud.

The debate over the nature of electoral manipulation—as an indicator of political strength or weakness—has significant theoretical stakes for major questions of democratization and autocratization. The regime-weakness model of manipulation is optimistic; incumbents who wish to avoid revealing their weakness to strategic protesters may reduce or even eschew manipulation—an auspicious prediction that under-pins the idea of ‘self-enforcing’ democracy (Fearon 2011). However, if manipulation can indicate regime resilience, incumbents have incentives to both develop and deploy the machinery of manipulation—a gloomy prediction for democratization and democratic resilience.

Chapter 2

Theory: A regime-strength model of electoral manipulation

This book has two principal aims. First, as detailed in Chapter 3, it aims to demonstrate that protest risk is insufficient to restrain election manipulation, a proposition that goes against a substantial body of prior work and has normatively pessimistic implications for democratization. Second, it articulates an alternative theory of electoral manipulation and protest, which explains how manipulation efforts are constructed and how they can be dismantled. This theory is developed in this chapter. To put this discussion on firm footing, it is first necessary to pin down the concept of electoral manipulation.

Over time, scholars have advanced four approaches toward the definition of electoral manipulation. Two of these are rooted in local understandings of election integrity, and two appeal to broader standards (Birch 2011). The first, and simplest, definition of electoral manipulation focuses on whether particular actions are violations of local electoral law. This, of course, poses two difficulties: what is legal in one context may be illegal in another, and—even more problematic—laws themselves may be structured to advantage one party over others. A second approach focuses on local norms, rather than (or in addition to) local legal conditions. Electoral behaviors that may be considered unacceptable in some contexts, may be broadly acceptable in others. This possibility has been especially important in studies of vote-buying, where some scholars have emphasized the coerciveness of the practice (e.g. with monitoring and punishment for defection), while others have emphasized cultures of reciprocity and mutual support which can underpin the vote-buying relationship and lead recipients to view such ‘gifts’ as legitimate (Greene 2024; Lawson & Greene 2014; Nichter 2018).

These local approaches to election integrity have, however, largely given way to approaches that make claims at universality. The third school grounds its understanding of electoral manipulation in international law—in particular the Universal Declaration of Human Rights and the UN International Covenant for Civil and Political Rights (Norris 2013)—and the subsequent development of global norms for election management and

election monitoring (Hyde 2011a; Kelley 2008). Lastly, a fourth approach is grounded in democratic theory; it begins by identifying the elements that are necessary for a democratic election to take place, and defines election manipulation as institutions and behaviors which obstruct those elements.

Though this last school of thought is founded upon democratic theory espoused by Dahl (1971), among others, it has perhaps been most clearly articulated in Andreas Schedler's (2002a) "menu of manipulation." In it, Schedler identifies seven requirements for a democratic election to succeed, ranging from the delegation of power to elected positions (i.e. elected officials must hold real power, rather than ceremonial or ineffective positions) to the irreversibility of electoral outcomes. Other essential features of a democratic election include freedom to form parties and compete in elections, voting eligibility for all full members of the community, free formation and expression of preferences, and fair aggregation of preferences under the principle of 'one person, one vote.'

Here, I follow this latter school of thought for a broad definition of electoral manipulation. To paraphrase Schedler (2013 p. 83), electoral manipulation in general refers to any and all techniques that limit the choices of political authorities among a community of free and equal citizens. The focus of this book, however, is on a subset of violations of the 'chain of democratic choice;' those tactics which are procedurally illegitimate and *carried out by individuals*. I refer to this class of manipulative tactics as *illicit, individual manipulation*. Election manipulation techniques are procedurally illegitimate when they break the established rules for allocating power (Beetham 2013).

Illicit, individual manipulation excludes most examples of formal electoral manipulation identified by Schedler (2002a), such as the creation of biased electoral rules or longstanding disenfranchisement of groups of citizens. So long as these tactics are procedurally legitimate—insofar as they are adopted according to the law—they do not expose their perpetrators to personal legal risk. Legislators who approve gerrymandered maps, for instance, may expose themselves to some political risks if the decision proves unpopular. But they are unlikely to be charged with a crime for doing so.

On the other hand, a wide variety of procedurally illegitimate forms of electoral manipulation are enacted by individuals around election time. These include—at minimum—vote-buying, voter pressure, ballot-stuffing, multiple voting, and falsification. This framing includes economic electoral intimidation (Frye *et al.* 2025b) and non-state forms of electoral violence, but would likely exclude officially state-sanctioned electoral violence like police disruption of opposition gatherings (Birch 2020).

Do illicit, individual forms of manipulation merit book-length investigation? It is a well-developed position in the literature that incumbents should prefer to rely on exactly the opposite kind of manipulation (i.e. formal techniques), which tend to be less visible and thus less damaging to incumbents' legitimacy, and can also be highly reliable (Birch 2011; Norris 2013; Szakonyi 2021). Nevertheless, there are several reasons for scholars to focus on illicit forms of manipulation.

First, it is this kind of manipulation—falsification, ballot-stuffing, vote-buying, and the like—which forms the backstop to other, more predictable forms of institutional

manipulation. Gerrymandered districts and biased electoral systems can backfire when incumbent popularity is low. Even when the genuine opposition has been excluded from the ballot, and there is thus no risk of incumbent defeat, incumbents still often turn to deliberate, personal forms of electoral manipulation; uncompetitive elections tend to depress turnout, which incumbents must compensate for in order to maintain an image of electoral strength.

Moreover, these techniques are theoretically important as the kind that is most likely to spark protest (due to procedural injustice and revealed information about incumbent), *and* as the most likely to be called out by observers. Because procedurally illegitimate forms of manipulation break the rules, they simultaneously increase protest risk (i.e. incur legitimacy costs) and produce individual risk for the perpetrator. The importance of this latter factor, however, has not previously been developed.

2.1 Leader-oriented theories of manipulation

Until relatively recently, most scholarship on election manipulation focused on the costs and benefits that accrue to the leaders who order it. Most basically, of course, political leaders seek to manipulate elections in order to ensure victory. Simpson (2013 p. 61) calls this the ‘first conventional wisdom’ of research on election manipulation: that its main goal is to ensure that a particular party or candidate wins the election at hand. The competitiveness of the election and stakes of losing power are the main drivers of manipulation in this tradition. Incumbents have more to gain from election rigging when they are likely to narrowly lose the election without it (Birch 2007; Fukumoto & Horiuchi 2011; Kam 2017; Lehoucq & Molina 2002; Nyblade & Reed 2008), and when the prospect of losing carries significant costs (Acemoglu & Robinson 2005; Baturo 2014; Horz 2021; Schedler 2013; Ziblatt 2009). Subsequent research has identified broader benefits of rigged elections for leaders; by communicating information about the strength and durability of the regime, manipulation can lead other actors in society to comply with the incumbent (Gehlbach & Simpson 2015; Simpson 2013).

Against these benefits, political leaders are expected to weigh the costs of manipulating elections. Election rigging has unavoidable material and organizational costs. More significant to leader-oriented theories, however, is the notion of legitimacy costs (Birch 2011). Scholars often understand legitimacy as individuals’ subjective sense that authorities have the right to rule, even if the individual may object to authorities’ particular decisions (Lipset 1960). Legitimacy, in turn, makes it more likely that individuals will comply with authorities’ demands (Levi & Sacks 2009).

The legitimacy cost of electoral manipulation, then, is both psychological and potentially behavioral. A reduction in individuals’ subjective evaluation that elected authorities have the right to govern can be associated with reduced willingness to obey the government (Schedler 2013). Birch (2011) cites protest risk to the cost of manipulation explicitly, saying legitimacy costs “...can be understood in terms of the proportion of the population that can be expected to acquiesce to having their contribution to public choice taken from them or distorted. As a result, she writes,”The capacity for popular

mobilization and protest ought to be negatively correlated with electoral malpractice” (p. 58). Schedler (2013) has further usefully defined legitimacy costs as a function of the severity and visibility of the manipulation employed (p. 274).

This understanding of the cost of electoral manipulation—as a reduction in legitimacy and associated increase in the risk of mass protest—has been widespread in the literature. It has been especially foundational to formal models of electoral manipulation, where loss of support and/or protest risk often stand as the main downside for incumbents (Chernykh & Svolik 2015; Little *et al.* 2015a; Little 2015). For instance, Magaloni (2010) writes that, “The legitimacy loss of fraud can be conceived as the costs to the autocrat of damaging its reputation before its own supporters and/or before the international community.”

Protest risk as the cost of manipulation also figures in less formal theory. It is central to the literature on election monitoring (Hyde & Marinov 2012; Kelley 2012). Manipulated elections can serve as a focal point for citizens’ diverse grievances, raising the likelihood of protest (Higashijima 2022; Tucker 2007). And, by the same token, election fraud figures prominently in general theories of electoral protest. Higashijima (2022) writes that elections can destabilize authoritarian rule when “a dictator engages in excessive electoral manipulation to such a degree that it... makes it difficult for opposition leaders to correctly estimate the dictator’s true strength and makes it easy to capitalize on popular grievance, provoking popular protest” (p. 10). His analysis shows that excessive electoral fraud makes popular protest initiation more likely (Higashijima 2022).

However, as discussed in the following chapter, the overall empirical record on the relationship between election manipulation and protest is mixed. Such theories also elide the fact that a large-scale election manipulation operation requires the willing cooperation of large numbers of middlemen, brokers, supervisors, and front-line agents (Forrat 2018; Larreguy *et al.* 2016a; Saikkonen 2021; Szwarcberg 2015; Zarazaga 2014). Scholars have come to recognize the importance of these networks of agents in limiting or permitting large-scale manipulation (Cho & Park 2025; Harvey 2019; Rundlett & Svolik 2016). Yet scholars have largely focused on agents’ incentives to participate in manipulation efforts, and largely assumed away the idea that participation may carry risks for agents.

A more complete picture of agents’ behavior will emerge when risks, as well as benefits, are theorized. In turn, this will enable us to develop a more comprehensive theory of electoral manipulation, with significant implications for authoritarianism and democracy. Before describing the theory in detail, I take a brief detour into history to highlight the rise and fall of election manipulation in the world’s oldest electoral democracies, the United Kingdom and the United States. Lessons from this sketch will help illuminate the twinned roles of patronage and personal risk in enabling and constraining election manipulation.

2.2 A brief historical sketch: The rise and fall of election manipulation in Britain and United States

Naturally, the earliest entrepreneurs of election manipulation are to be found in the oldest democracies. For instance, 19th century British elections (after the expansion of the franchise to larger classes of people) were characterized by widespread voter pressure, vote-buying, ‘treating,’ and ‘personation.’¹ Just like their modern descendants, those who sought to manipulate early democratic elections were embedded in hierarchical patronage networks. Laborers in the more agricultural counties often faced pressure from large landowners, via the tenant farmers who rented the land. In the boroughs, vote-buying was so common as to appear to many voters a normal part of the electoral process (Hoppen 1996); candidates relied on diverse agents to monitor local communities, distribute largess throughout the constituency, and mobilize voters (Camp *et al.* 2014).

Throughout the kingdom, candidates hired ‘roughs’ to blockade polling places, intimidate and harass opposing voters, interrupt opponents’ meetings, and to defend themselves from the opposing side (Blaxill *et al.* 2025). Candidates relied on extensive networks to engage such workers, for two reasons. First, gentlemanly candidates might lack direct connections to the rougher sort of citizen. In the city of Norwich, candidates relied on publicans “who were well-known for their experience in this kind of business,” to furnish roughs (Blaxill *et al.* 2025). Second, extended recruitment networks helped protect the candidates from liability for violence. As Blaxill *et al.* (2025) write, “roughs were hired by sub-agents, committee members or general prominent party supporters, thus providing a firebreak to the chief agent or candidate if the roughs themselves talked, freely or under detention” (Blaxill *et al.* 2025 p. 191).

Such activities persisted unabated after the the passage of the Corrupt Practices Act of 1854 (Hoppen 1996), which defined various electoral offenses but was largely toothless. Under the act, vote buyers—well-resourced politicians—faced the prospect of forfeiting 100 pounds, while vote sellers could forfeit ten. To initiate these proceedings against a lawbreaker anywhere in England, however, private citizens would have to sue in court in London (“An Act to consolidate and amend the Laws relating to Bribery, Treating, and undue Influence at Elections of Members of Parliament.” 1854); this could entail a journey of several days.

Only with the passage of the Illegal Practices Prevention Act of 1883 did these practices begin to diminish (Hoppen 1996). The 1883 Act put prosecution in the hands of the state, rather than individual citizens, allowed trials to be held in any relevant court, and increased the penalties for various electoral crimes (“Illegal Practices Prevention Act 1883” n.d.). Under the new law, those found guilty of bribery, treating, abduction of voters, undue influence, personation, or filing false campaign expenditure statements could face up to one year in prison (possibly to include hard labor), a 200-pound fine, the loss of voting rights, and the loss of the right to stand for election (O’Leary 1962).

¹‘Treating’ refers to the practice of plying voters with food and fortifying beverage before and after the vote; ‘personation’ refers to ineligible voters casting ballots on behalf of someone else.

The Act also sought to break up politicians' patronage networks by limiting the number of electoral agents they could field and the maximum campaign expenses they could lawfully spend (O'Leary 1962). This, in combination with the fact that candidates could be held criminally liable for the misbehavior of their agents, helped lead to the decline of 'roughs' in British politics; increasingly large and professional police forces also helped (Blaxill *et al.* 2025). Parties and candidates went to great lengths to warn their agents to obey the law. "This Act is not to be trifled with," wrote one Conservative journal in 1896. "Its penalties amount to social ruin, and will, without doubt, be strictly enforced" (Rix 2008). The effect of the law "was to transform the whole character of British electioneering within a generation" (O'Leary 1962).

American elections in the 1800s also frequently featured 'treating,' ineligible or multiple voting, voter intimidation, ballot-stuffing, 'colonizing',² 'cooping',³ and outright fraud (Argersinger 1985; Argersinger 2024; Bense 2004; Cox & Kousser 1981; Foley 2024; Reynolds 1993; Summers 2004)—to say nothing of the systematic restrictions and repression aimed at Black citizens (Epperly *et al.* 2020). These types of manipulation reached their apex in the United States' urban political machines, which sustained themselves through a mutually reinforcing cycle: election manipulation enabled the capture of political office, which allowed politicians to direct patronage resources (i.e. jobs, contracts), which in turn fueled further manipulation.

Patronage—the funneling of jobs, contracts, and opportunities for graft to supporters—was essential to the operation of New York City's Tammany Hall machine, which dominated city politics for much of the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries. At its peak, the machine had the ability to distribute patronage on a massive scale, having allies in the governor, the mayor, the city comptroller, and more. Its most famous leader, William "Boss" Tweed, kept plum sources of jobs for himself as Commissioner of Public Works and executive roles in a variety of industries (Callow 1972). "Control of patronage enabled Tweed to become New York's first absolute boss," Callow (1972 p. 117) writes in his deep history of the Tammany machine. "From the ward leader down to the precinct captain, power depended on the ability to supply patronage to the faithful. ...through patronage alone [the machine] employed at least 12,000 people [and] 33 per cent of the money supplied to the city departments was stolen, in the sense that it went to men listed on the payrolls who did no work, or to payroll names which were fictitious." These men, in turn, were expected to deliver votes for the Tammany machine at election time.

American political machines were early pioneers in the use of what observers of post-Soviet politics would call "administrative resources" to control clients and influence elections (Allina-Pisano 2010). Large corporations were extorted with the threat of tougher regulatory legislation. But small businesses—the merchant, innkeeper, stable owner, etc.—were extorted through the selective 'enforcement' of city ordinances. "...the bible of graft was the bulky volume of over 900 pages of city ordinances. The Ring used it to harass, blackmail, and demand illegitimate fees" (Callow 1972 p. 190).

²Importing voters from a neighboring district.

³The act of kidnapping and drugging individuals, and compelling them to vote (often more than once). See Bense (2004) for examples.

Small businessmen who failed to pay the machine's fees or to turn out votes on election day faced the prospect of fines, closure, water shut-off, and other obstacles (Callow 1972 pp. 190–197).⁴

Yet the success of Tammany Hall depended just as much on managing legal risks to its network of agents as it did on patronage resources. Indeed, control of patronage and control of the legal system each depended on the other, with election manipulation as the link. The Tammany machine owed its dominant position to the ability of its clients to deliver votes on election day. While many of these votes were honest—or at least not directly purchased or coerced—manipulation was an essential ingredient. Gangs of toughs were dispatched to drive away reformist voters, intimidate election judges, attack opposition toughs⁵, and to exercise their own franchise as often as they could. Pliant judges naturalized immigrants en masse, creating new voters sometimes at the pace of thousands a day. Voter registration lists were padded with the names of deceased and fictitious individuals. Tammany allies serving as election judges adjusted the results as needed. Votes were bought in cash, food, or liquor (Callow 1972 p. 207–213).

All of these activities required that Tammany Hall be able to protect its agents from legal consequences. One of the machine's first orders of business was to secure the loyalty of the police, to install friendly judges in office, and to ensure that machine allies served as District Attorney. Friendly police officers, lawyers, and judges could help the alleged offender at any stage of the judicial process. One Tammany-affiliated prosecutor (who would later become mayor) was said to have prosecuted over 12,000 cases, but to have quashed 10,000 more (Callow 1972 p. 39). The *Times* complained of this practice, writing that rather than bring indictments, the District Attorney “waits year after year for the benign influences of our Christian civilization to soften [suspects'] hearts. They naturally feel grateful for this forbearance...and testify their gratitude by working for him at elections” (Callow 1972 p. 148). Well-connected lawyers worked hard on election day, getting those repeaters who were caught out of custody and back to work (Callow 1972 p. 150).

Despite these formidable resources, it could still be wise for front-line agents to take precautions to avoid detection. Disguises and costume changes were common. One Tammany Hall tough would rotate his gang of bearded repeaters through barbershops in between casting ballots (Callow 1972 p. 210):

When you've voted 'em with their whiskers on, you take 'em to a barber and scrape off the chin fringe. Then you vote 'em again with the side lilacs and a mustache. Then to a barber again, off comes the sides and you vote 'em a third time with the mustache. If that ain't enough and the box can stand a few more ballots, clean off the mustache and vote 'em plain face.

⁴In this approach, the Tweed machine anticipated the tactics of bureaucratic extortion in the post-Soviet space (Madlovics & Magyar 2021; Vasileva 2018).

⁵Reflecting later on this bygone era of politics, one politician lamented: “Nobody gets killed any more and the ambulances and patrol wagons stay in their garages.... It was wonderful to see my men slug the opposition to preserve the sanctity of the ballot...” (Callow 1972 p. 209).

As Callow writes (1972 pp. 150–151):

The Tweed Ring, then, in consolidating its power, seized the legal machinery of New York to make it the backbone of its organization. Without it other operations like election fraud were in danger of exposure and prosecution. Thus the Ring helped to establish one of the classic patterns of a corrupt political machine. Its alliance with venal judges, the underworld, the police, and shyster lawyers kept the machine moving, providing not only patronage, jobs, and graft, but also the means to protect and control organized crime. Fundamentally, however, it provided security and safety the legal obstructions to obscure public plunder.

Though the political machines had formidable resources to deploy at election time, there were nevertheless large constituencies dissatisfied with their rule—these might include supporters of the local opposition party, those who resented the inefficiency and corruption of machine government, and professionals and corporations who desired a more regular legal environment (Summers 2004 p. 230). At times of significant discontent, these constituencies could bring reformers to power. Reformers sought to break the power of the machine along both fronts that sustained it: by limiting politicians' freedom to distribute jobs (and the attendant opportunities for graft) to their clients, and by increasing the costliness of rigging elections. Civil service reform was the primary tool for constraining patronage and its influence on elections. Writing in 1919, a prominent reformer and Indiana politician argued that, just as the introduction of the Australian ballot removed the temptation to buy or coerce votes (by concealing whether the voter had in fact complied), the Pendleton Act of 1883 removed the incentive to "that kind of corruption which is nourished by the hope of office" (Foulke 1919 p. 10).

The Pendleton Act granted protections from dismissal to certain classes of federal employees, established the Civil Service Commission, and mandated merit-based examinations for appointments to civil service jobs. In so doing it, limited the ability of incoming administrations to remove incumbents and open up jobs to their clients; it also limited their ability to reward influential clients with lucrative federal employment. While this directly cut down on federal patronage opportunities, it also indirectly cut into political machine's campaign war chests."At the heart of party finance," Summers writes, "was the principle of assessment on officeholders.... In return for being rewarded an office, the loyal partisan was expected to pay some of his or her salary to campaign funds" (2004 p. 150). The more lucrative the office, the larger the expected donation by the officeholder; those who failed to repay their patron's generosity could be dismissed in favor of someone more loyal.

The federal patronage system was the center of gravity for affiliated local machines; senators, representatives, and local bosses all had claims on the president's appointments within their domains (Foulke 1919). Federal civil service reform removed some of the choicest patronage prizes from the game, reducing the incentive to rig elections. Reformers pushed for similar changes at the municipal level, which naturally faced stiff resistance from the machines (Summers 2004).

Control over police departments and prosecutor's offices was an especially important

battleground. Patronage-based police forces not only protected the machine's agents on election day, but also paid into the machine's coffers a share of the bribes and payoffs the department collected (Summers 2004 p. 155). In one example of contestation over the police, the rivals of the Tammany machine, state-level Republicans, capitalized on public discontent to launch a state Senate investigation of the New York City police in 1893. The Lexow Committee report, containing over 1,000 pages of testimony of police interference with elections, concluded that "almost every conceivable crime against the elective franchise was either committed or permitted by the police," in the interests of Tammany Hall (Berman 1980--1981).

The committee's recommendations for police reform include a bipartisan supervisory board, and the creation of a civil service merit system for hiring and promotion of officers; these changes were incorporated into the reformed Greater New York charter of 1898 (New York (City) 1897), weakening partisan control over the police. While reformers and traditionalists would trade power over the years in New York and elsewhere (Berman 1980--1981; Walker 1980), these changes helped foster norms of professionalism and impartiality that would become enshrined in US Supreme Court doctrine, the manuals of the Department of Justice, and the guidelines of the American Bar Association (Green & Roiphe 2020). The norm of professional prosecution, "without fear or favor," helped uproot a long American tradition of election manipulation during the 20th century.

The mutually reinforcing loss of patronage resources and diminution of legal impunity intensified principal-agent problems within the machines. Even when machines were working properly, principal-agent problems abounded. Agents tasked with delivering votes could steal from the machine at a prodigious pace. One Pittsburgh boss dispatched two agents with \$40,000 for 'election-day expenses' to an allied machine in Indianapolis; the men arrived, but the cash never did (Summers 2004 p. 11). Disputes over finite patronage opportunities could fracture the machines. "The Ring and the Boss," wrote one observer of the machine era, "command an army composed of elements as dangerous as those which make up the crew of a pirate ship. The instant the slightest sign of weakness is shown, each man aspires to be commander, and is willing to sink the ship and all on board rather than to forego his own ambitious schemes" (Shapley & Nast 1889). Indeed, the beginning of the end of Tweed era of Tammany Hall came when a highly-placed client, disgruntled over unpaid claims by the machine, leaked a trove of incriminating accounts to the *New York Times* (Callow 1972 pp. 259--260). The Pendleton Act itself was passed, in part, due to the assassination of President Garfield by a disappointed office-seeker.

To summarize, election manipulation in the early days of mass suffrage in the United Kingdom and United States bears a strong resemblance to the techniques we see in modern electoral authoritarian and electoral democratic regimes. Economic intimidation, vote-buying, violence, and falsification abounded, producing locally dominant political party machines. These efforts were organized along the lines of patronage networks, stretching from politicians and wealthy elites at the top down to the ordinary voter at the bottom. Rigged elections flourished when control over patronage also enabled legal impunity for election-manipulating agents. Reformers targeted both aspects

of the machine in order to hold cleaner elections and capture power: the restrictions of patronage resources and the reduction of political control over police, prosecutors, and courts.

2.3 An agent-risk model of electoral manipulation

The foregoing historical sketch, and much modern research, show that incumbents who wish to manipulate elections extensively need a large network of subordinates willing to expend resources and undertake personal risks. The earliest generation of modern research on electoral manipulation often assumed, for the sake of parsimony, that whatever level of manipulation the incumbent ordered was smoothly carried out. A subsequent generation of research on authoritarian politics has emphasized the risks incumbents face from their subordinates (Magaloni 2008; Svolik 2009; Svolik 2012), the abundance of principal-agent problems in such environments (Harvey 2019; Rundlett & Svolik 2016; Tyson 2018), and the difficulty of monitoring low-level agents (Boix & Svolik 2013; Larreguy *et al.* 2016b). It is, consequently, no small feat to mobilize thousands or tens of thousands of individuals to stuff ballot boxes, bribe voters, or falsify election returns.

Doing so requires that the incumbent have considerable influence over high-level actors like political party leaders, regional governors, big business owners, and so on. These high-level actors, in turn, must be able to exercise influence over meso-level actors like regional legislators, mayors, town councilors, and firm managers, etc. Finally, these meso-level actors must be able to exercise influence over the front-line agents—precinct election officials, low-level civil servants, party operatives, etc.—and even individual voters themselves. As these examples suggest, election manipulation networks are usually pyramidal, with actors at each level responsible for overseeing a larger number of actors at the next level down (Hale 2014). Political candidates' dependence on agents raises the possibility that agents' may not always behave as the boss might prefer (Rundlett & Svolik 2016). These are not easy problems for incumbents to solve, as actors at every step in the chain may have incentives to misrepresent their loyalty and effort on the boss's behalf (Harvey 2022b).

While both principals and agents may participate in electoral manipulation, their underlying incentives diverge in important ways. Political principals benefit directly from manipulation (Greene 2007; Magaloni 2006) since it improves their chances of winning close elections (Lehoucq & Molina 2002) and widens their margin of victory (Gehlbach & Simpser 2015; Simpser 2013). They gain utility, in other words, from each added vote. Agents, by contrast, are primarily motivated by credible access to patronage resources: the jobs, rents, and other benefits that come with participation in a political leader's network (Diaz-Cayeros 2006; Lust-Okar 2006; Reuter & Robertson 2012). A neighborhood broker, for instance, may seek a local administrative position through which rents can be extracted (Zarazaga 2014), while a schoolteacher serving as an election administrator in Russia may participate in ballot-stuffing only to preserve her own salary or benefits (Forrat 2018). These divergent incentives can create a classic principal-agent problem. Because principals cannot perfectly monitor their agents' be-

havior, an agent may attempt to shirk her assigned manipulation tasks while still hoping to retain her place in the patronage network—pocketing the reward without bearing the risk.

In order to solve these problems, and ensure that a directive to manipulate the election issued at the top of the pyramid is in fact carried out across the bottom, incumbents need three things. First, incumbents must have access to benefits that can be shared with subordinates, to reward them for their efforts. Front-line agents do not directly benefit from each manufactured vote they generate. Instead, agents perform their assigned tasks in order to remain embedded within a principal's patronage network. For example, Russia's primary election-monitoring group recorded numerous incidents of voters being pressured to support the ruling party by their employers during the 2011 election. The following example is representative:

At Kindergarten No. 620 [in St. Petersburg], a meeting was held in which employees were compelled to take absentee ballots in order to vote on school grounds. It was said that otherwise the district would be cut off from funding, but that voting by absentee would be rewarded with cash bonuses and time off. ...It was pointed out that [Duma] Deputy S. Shatunovskii (a member of United Russia) had done a lot for the district and it was necessary to support him (Golos 2011).

As the anecdote illustrates, local school administrators pressured their employees with the risk of job loss and the promise of bonuses, in order to remain within the ruling party's patronage network. This sort of voter pressure / vote-buying is common in sectors that rely on state patronage for their success (Frye *et al.* 2014). Other forms of manipulation which rely more directly on state actors, such as ballot-stuffing or falsification of results, are also carried out in order to retain access to patronage. Principals in electoral authoritarian regimes tie access to the state and its associated opportunities for rents and patronage to electoral success (Diaz-Cayeros 2006; Lust-Okar 2006; Reuter & Robertson 2012; Reuter & Robertson 2015), and can use the same resources to penalize opponents (McMann 2006). This creates a powerful incentive for local agents to boost the principal's vote-share by whatever means are available, including misuse of the election administration apparatus, in order to remain within the privileged network.

Second, because election manipulation of the type studied here is by definition illegal (even in the most authoritarian cases), incumbents need to be able to credibly promise their subordinates that they will not be punished for carrying out their assigned tasks. Exposure of an individual's illegal attempt to influence the election can carry criminal, civil, professional, reputational, and personal risks. The individual may face civil lawsuits or criminal prosecution, which—even in the most favorable circumstances—requires them to retain legal representation and devote time to the case. Loss in court can result in penalties like fines, prison time, or loss of official position. In some contexts, conviction of a crime can lead to professional penalties, including dismissal. Even probation, a relatively lenient penalty, brings restrictions on an individual's movements and activities and increased monitoring by the state. These are all possible negative consequences for participating in election manipulation, which weigh against the negative consequences of refusing to manipulate (i.e. punishment by the principal). Crucially,

as I argue below, these risks exist even if the incumbent remains in power.

Even the most closed authoritarian regimes have competing incentives here. On the one hand, they may desire to protect their agents in order to promote manipulation in the future. On the other hand, they have incentives to allow a degree of judicial independence and transparency. More independent courts enhance regime legitimacy, reduce corruption, and increase investment (Moustafa & Ginsburg 2008; Tsai *et al.* 2022). Furthermore, by allowing some agents to be exposed and punished, the incumbent may burnish the overall image of the election. ‘Of course, a small number of our supporters were overzealous and bent the law,’ this approach implies, ‘but the legal system will handle these exceptional cases.’ Naturally this is a bad place to be for the scapegoated agent.

Consequently, courts in non-democratic regimes do sometimes act to redress low-level electoral violations. For example, Popova (2012) finds that district courts in Russia were more likely to hear election-related cases in competitive districts, and that pro-government candidates were not systematically more likely to win than pro-opposition candidates (pp. 94-95). More dramatically, beginning in the 1970s, the combination of legal reforms criminalizing certain electoral malpractices, the creation of more independent bodies to enforce those laws, and public and legal contestation by opposition parties largely cleaned up elections in authoritarian Mexico (Eisenstadt 2003; Serra 2016). Ultimately these changes helped usher out the ruling PRI after seven decades in power.

Courts often hear charges against election officials for election tampering, but they can also adjudicate cases against ordinary individuals accused of other types of manipulation: vote-buying, voter pressure, voter impersonation, and multiple voting (Orozco-Henríquez *et al.* 2010). Since authoritarian rulers have incentives to create a court system that does, on occasion, rule against the regime’s supporters (Ginsburg & Moustafa 2008; Harvey 2022a; Hendley 2017; Popova 2012), this can create acute risks for front-line agents in cases where exposure is more likely. In 1999, for example, Russian courts ruled against election commissioners accused of electoral malfeasance (including fraud allegations) in about half of cases (Solomon 2004). A report on the punishment of election commissioners for violations of the election law from 2009 to 2015 in Russia found that, while most infractions are punished by small fines, significant punishments could be brought in cases with sufficient local political pressure (Golos 2015). In some cases recorded by the monitoring group, election commissioners were found guilty of criminal offenses and faced stiff penalties, including fines of over half an average annual salary. Chapter 6, in this volume, shows further evidence of such risks in modern, more authoritarian Russia.

Such risks may have high or low probabilities of being realized, depending on individual context. Local agents are valuable to principals in part because of their deep knowledge of their local environment, which better enables them to monitor voters, distribute clientelistic benefits, or otherwise alter election results (Frye *et al.* 2014; Zarazaga 2014). However, this local knowledge also allows agents to make strategic judgments about the level of local risk involved in manipulating an election in particular ways. They may abstain, or—in more competitive settings—may stop mobilizing voters or switch

parties if the status quo becomes too risky (Stokes *et al.* 2013b pp. 121–126).

The risk to agents has two components: the likelihood that a particular action will be exposed, and the likelihood that it will subsequently be punished. For example, the presence of election monitors makes it more likely that manipulation will be exposed (Kelley 2012), and can deter manipulation (Hyde 2011a; Sjoberg 2013) at particular polling sites. Similarly, when opposition parties have limited or no representation on election commissions, pro-incumbent manipulation is harder to expose and easier to accomplish (Bader 2012; Calingaert 2006; Kovalov 2014). Local media can also play an important role in exposing criminal corruption (Usher & Kim-Leffingwell 2024), of which election manipulation can be an example. Once publicly exposed, individual agents' risks can still be mitigated if the likelihood of punishment is low. In cases where a dominant party machine exercises control over regional courts, opposition party figures are less likely to pursue complaints in regional courts (Popova 2006), reducing the risk to agents of engaging in manipulation.

Opposition parties know that criminal-legal risk is part of agents' calculations. In the 2003 State Duma election, the Communist Party of the Russian Federation lost 61 seats, more than half of its delegation. In an essay in the party newspaper *Pravda Rossii*, party leader Gennady Zyuganov highlighted the importance of holding election manipulators to account in the courts:

“Hundreds, thousands of cases of vote-rigging, forgery and manipulation have been identified. Not a single fact of fraud must be overlooked. We must go to the courts and seek the prosecution of the fraudsters. This is a special and very important front of the struggle.... If we can identify and punish the falsifiers, we will strengthen popular democracy and it will be easier for us to win in the future” (Zyuganov 2003).

The same edition of the paper also depicted the unfairness of the election outcome in an editorial cartoon, shown in Figure 2.1. In it, ballots in United Russia's favor are made to weigh more by a television and a policeman's baton—two pillars of the incumbent's 'administrative resources' used to bias elections.

Finally, the incumbent must be able to convince his subordinates that he will remain in power through the election and beyond; that is, that his ability to mete out rewards and punishments will be lasting (Gehlbach & Simpser 2015; Hale 2014; Simpser 2013). If the principal appears less likely to control access to patronage due to electoral defeat or intraparty rivalry, her offer of post-election patronage will appear less viable to agents, reducing their incentive to work on her behalf (Hale 2006). When one patronage network controls a large share of resources, agents have a strong incentive to support the principal: access to rents and resources outside that network is limited, competing offers of patronage by opposition figures are necessarily discounted, and punishment of defectors by exclusion from the network seems assured (Hale 2014). In a society characterized by multiple patronage networks, by contrast, the credibility of an individual principal's offer is contingent on the likelihood that the principal will win the election or leadership struggle. As a result, clients 'hedge their bets or pin their hopes on different networks in an uncoordinated fashion' (Hale 2014 p. 72). Consequently, agents



Figure 2.1: Post-election cartoon showing United Russia's advantages: control over the media and police

are more strongly incentivized to participate in electoral manipulation efforts when patronage networks are more consolidated.

Finally, manipulation on a national scale can be very expensive, and principals' resources are not limitless. Even relatively cost-effective tactics like co-opting employers to pressure voters requires monitoring efforts and rewards for compliant businesses (Frye *et al.* 2014 p. 207). Agents and brokers engaged in falsification or other types of manipulation must still be organized and compensated (Langston & Morgenstern 2009). Vote-buying, however, is especially costly (Lehoucq & Molina 2002; Wang & Kurzman 2007), and such efforts become increasingly expensive as competitiveness increases (Corstange 2018). As a result, incumbents are likely to prefer centralized forms of manipulation in low risk areas, due to their cost-effectiveness. This pattern has been documented both domestically in Russia (Harvey 2016) and cross-nationally (Van Ham & Lindberg 2015). Consequently, if higher local constraints make agents less willing to tamper with elections in administrative ways, principals may find agents both more expensive to hire (as they turn toward vote-buying and similar tactics) and more likely to shirk their duties on election day (as they become harder to monitor). This limits the ability of principals to compensate for higher competitiveness by boosting payments for agents.

To summarize, low-level actors will be more willing to engage in electoral manipulation when the rewards are high and the risks are low. The rewards are well-understood; they

typically involve participation in the incumbent's patronage network (providing access to jobs, career advancement, opportunities for enrichment, favors, and so on). The risks have been less well understood. Even in authoritarian regimes, incumbents have an incentive to permit the independent operation of the justice system to some degree. Even where he has firm control over the police and the courts, the incumbent may still have incentives to allow a small proportion of agents to be penalized for electoral crimes, in order to bolster the overall legitimacy of the election and the regime. While prospective agents cannot know *a priori* whether they will be protected, they can use their local knowledge to estimate the risk of exposure and subsequent punishment. Where the possibility of exposure and punishment is perceived to be high (relative to the patronage rewards), agents should be less willing to take risks to manipulate on the incumbent's behalf. However, as the next section describes, this dynamic does not mean that elections will necessarily be cleaner; instead, risk pushes agents into harder-to-detect forms of manipulation that are costlier to incumbents.

2.3.1 Variation in manipulation tactic as response to agent risk

While ballot-stuffing, voter pressure, and falsification can all add to the incumbent's tally in the election, considerable scholarship has been invested in understanding why incumbents may prefer one strategy or another. Incumbents may prefer a certain mix of strategies in order to evade observation (Asunka *et al.* 2017) and loss of legitimacy (Van Ham & Lindberg 2015), due to resource constraints (Greene 2007) or availability (Frye *et al.* 2018), to avoid appearing weak (Harvey & Mukherjee 2020) or to evade the strictures of modern electoral procedure (Kuo & Teorell 2017). With few exceptions (Harvey 2019; Rundlett & Svolik 2016), front-line agents' cooperation with incumbents' preferences is often assumed.

However, front-line agents do indeed have agency, and are not indifferent among the choices on the menu of manipulation. In particular, different illegal election manipulation tactics can be traced back to their individual perpetrators with varying degrees of difficulty. This affects the degree of personal risk to which the agent is exposed. Table 2.1 summarizes these differences. To be clear, it is likely not typically the case that the principal is trying to get the agent to adopt one manipulation tactic, but the agent chooses another. Instead, as conditions change, it becomes harder for principals to recruit agents to perform certain kinds of tasks (e.g. precinct officials to stuff ballot boxes), forcing them to rely on different agents who perform different tasks (e.g. party operatives to buy votes).

To my knowledge, there have been no prior studies of the factors that make electoral crimes more or less attributable to the perpetrator. However, there is a detailed literature in criminology that examines the 'solvability factors' that contribute to the likelihood of suspect arrest and case clearance in other crimes.⁶ An influential early study of policing in American cities concluded that "If information that uniquely identifies the perpetrator is not presented at the time the crime is reported, the perpetrator, by and

⁶While some research in this literature focuses on violent crime, the bulk of the literature focuses on solvability factors of non-violent 'volume crimes' like burglary.

Manipulation tactic	Perpetrators known	Location known	Time known	Attributability
Falsification	Yes (Officials)	Yes	Yes	High
Ballot-stuffing	Possibly (Officials or voters)	Possibly	Partially	Moderate
Vote-buying / voter pressure	Rarely (Various)	No	No	Low

Table 2.1: Variation in how attributable election manipulation tactics are to perpetrators

large, will not be subsequently identified” (Greenwood *et al.* 1975 p. ix). This finding has been consistent in more recent research (Coupe & Girling 2001; Coupe & Blake 2006; Olphin *et al.* 2021; Robinson & Tilley 2009). The effects can be large; one study finds that being caught at the scene increases the likelihood of attribution of a burglary or theft by as much as 20,000 percent (odds ratio 207.4); on the other hand, a simple description of the suspect increases the likelihood of attribution by only 40 percent (Robinson & Tilley 2009).

A comprehensive study of UK policing found that the strongest predictor of solvability is having caught the perpetrator at the scene of the crime, though this is rare; cases where the crime is known to have taken place in a narrow time window are also more easily solved (John Burrows *et al.* 2005). On the basis of these trends, criminal cases are sometimes divided into three categories (Eck 1983). First, there are cases with so few ‘leads’ that no amount of police effort is likely to result in a suspect being apprehended. Second, there are cases with enough initial evidence that an arrest could be made with sufficient devotion of police effort and resources. Finally, there are those cases “where the suspect has been positively identified, [which] will usually result in an arrest, even with only minimal investigative effort” (Brandl & Frank 1994).

Electoral crimes can be mapped onto these features identified in criminology research. Falsification of the vote count is the electoral crime most easily attributable to its perpetrators. Only the election officials, who are typically publicly named individuals, can count, tabulate, and record the election results; the individuals responsible for any discrepancies are thus easily identifiable. Moreover, counting the votes takes place at a known location (the polling place), as does tabulation (higher level election commissions); these activities also take place at known times (after the close of polling). Election monitors, unsurprisingly, take advantage of these facts to detect attempted manipulations. The OSCE Election Monitoring Handbook, for instance, notes that observers “should select one of their assigned polling stations at which to observe the closing procedures, and then remain there for the entire vote count”; it goes on to list detailed descriptions of the kinds of activities that monitors should be alert to (Office for Democratic Institutions and Human Rights 2010 p. 79).

Similar instructions are provided for monitoring tabulation. An election monitoring guidebook from the National Democratic Institute (NDI) states that “Monitors should take note of who is present inside the voting station.... Election officials are responsible for administering the voting process.... [monitors] should observe and record the conduct of election officials in order to deter fraud, to help correct inadvertent mistakes, as well as detect and record actual irregularities” (National Democratic Institute 1995 p. 71). Due to their power, and the fixed time and location of their efforts, election officials are obvious targets of attention for those who seek to monitor and expose election fraud. This makes committing fraud an exercise in considerable risk for such officials, if they are operating in a context where monitoring by NGOs, parties, or citizens is vigorous.

At the other end of the spectrum of attribution are techniques where the relevant violation happens away from the polling place, both in space and in time. The actors involved are diverse and often non-public, including voters’ employers and managers (Frye *et al.*

2018, 2025b), local mayors and councilors (Mares & Young 2019; Núñez 2018), civic organizations (Holland & Palmer-Rubin 2015), labor unions (Horacio Larreguy *et al.* 2017), partisan neighborhood brokers (Berenschot 2019; Szwarcberg 2015), and others. Ample scholarly evidence attests to the difficulty that even their patrons have in monitoring brokers' behavior (Aspinall 2014; Langston & Cornejo 2023; Stokes *et al.* 2013a). Observers likewise face difficulties. The NDI handbook notes that observers should devote some attention to the atmosphere immediately outside the polling place, and should note "the identities (*or descriptions*)" of the people involved in incidents of bribery or intimidation (National Democratic Institute 1995 p. 74, emphasis added). The OSCE handbook has detailed instructions on how to evaluate the pre-election and election-day period, but unsurprisingly makes no mention of how to observe vote-buying or voter intimidation away from the polling place (Office for Democratic Institutions and Human Rights 2010), beyond an evaluation of the formal rules limiting abuse of government resources (OSCE/ODIHR *Handbook for the Observation of Election Campaigns and Political Environments* 2021). The Carter Center takes a similar approach in its guidelines for observers (The Carter Center n.d.).

Recognizing these difficulties, the Russian domestic election monitoring organization Golos aimed to recruit ordinary citizens in the observation of dispersed forms of manipulation. Training materials from Golos state:

"Elections are not just the voting day itself, but the three months of campaigning beforehand. During this period, voters may face pressure from their superiors and illegal campaigning. Officials who are prohibited from doing so may participate in it. You may also witness the illegal use of administrative and budgetary resources in the interests of one of the candidates. All this is called 'administrative resources.' Only the voters themselves can effectively respond to this blatantly illegal behavior."

Golos goes on to provide placards that citizens can print and distribute in public places, or post on walls, to inform others of their legal rights ("How to Deal with Administrative Resources" 2025). The placard encourages citizens to record photographic, audio, or video evidence of violations, and provides QR-codes that link to the authorities' online complaint portals, and to Golos' crowdsourced election violation website. These documents all illustrate the challenges facing organizations that wish to monitor and deter election violations that take place away from the polling station, and—in the Golos example—the lengths the organization must go in order to try to make such techniques attributable and risky for perpetrators. It is perhaps not surprising in this context that Golos has been the subject of increasingly harsh legal repression, and was finally forced to disband in the summer of 2025 (Alexey Strelnikov 2025).

Ballot-stuffing falls somewhere in between these two extremes. Illegal ballots can be cast by election officials, of course, but can also be cast by legitimate voters or by third-parties. However, ballot-stuffing can only occur where the ballot box is, and can only occur sometime between when voting starts and ends. As a result, it is much simpler for monitors attempt to observe this kind of manipulation than it is for vote-buying and voter-pressure, which are far more dispersed and involve a more diverse range of agents.

Consequently, if agents are indeed motivated by the desire to avoid personal attribution of electoral misdeeds, it is to be expected that agents will be less interested in techniques higher on the ladder the more likely they are to be exposed. That is, holding other factors equal, in local areas where political opposition and activist civil society are limited, we should expect to see more falsification by election officials. As the risk of exposure increases due to greater opposition and/or civil society activity, manipulation should move down the ladder in Table 2.1. Election officials should shift from falsification to ballot-stuffing, and then increasingly drop out of the manipulation enterprise in favor of less easily identifiable individuals. As the risk of exposure increases further, even these third-party individuals should be less willing to manipulate in and around the polling place; instead, the incumbent will need to rely on a broader network of agents distributed throughout society. As this dispersion increases, a given ‘unit’ of manipulation becomes more expensive for the incumbent, as principal-agent problems mount and monitoring agents becomes more difficult.

This insight—that election-manipulating agents constrain their principals’ options—produces a unique test of the regime-strength model of manipulation. Traditionally, explanations of variation in type of electoral manipulation has emphasized political leaders and their fear of legitimacy loss (Birch 2011; Schedler 2013), their ability to monitor voters’ compliance (Cox & Kousser 1981; Stokes 2005), their confidence in victory (Hauser 2018) or their access to certain resources (Van Ham & Lindberg 2015). Writing in 2013, Simpser noted that “the question of why some tactics of electoral manipulation are chosen over others in particular circumstances remains an open one,” but sketched an expectation that incumbents would choose more cost-effective tactics over less cost-effective ones (2013 pp. 28–29).

These theories suggest distinct predictions at the national and local levels. On the one hand, in a close election, theories that hinge on legitimacy costs suggest that incumbents should prioritize fraud in less-competitive regions. This is because fraud is the most cost-effective election-day manipulation strategy, but it requires control of the local election administration in order to implement. In more competitive regions, such models would seem to predict a decline in manipulation across all strategies. The difficulty in controlling the election administration in contested regions makes fraud difficult, while vote-buying, voter pressure, and voter intimidation are all more visible strategies; being directly visible to voters, their potential legitimacy cost is high if such efforts are widespread (Birch 2011; Schedler 2013). A principal-focused theory of manipulation that emphasizes legitimacy costs should thus predict that all types of election-day manipulation will decrease with the risk of exposure, and that fraud should predominate where the risk of exposure is low.

Different predictions emerge if, instead, the cost-effectiveness of a given strategy for incumbents is in large part conditioned by *agents’* incentive structures (rather than by legitimacy costs to principals). We should expect to see fraud decrease with local risk of exposure, as in the principal-focused approach. However, we should expect to see *less attributable*, though still visible forms of manipulation, *increase* with local risk of exposure. This outcome is expected because incumbents are not deterred from manipulating by legitimacy costs; indeed, they seek to demonstrate their power and

impunity through the use of manipulation (Simpser 2013). However, as local risks of exposure increase, it becomes increasingly difficult to pressure election officials into engaging in attributable falsification. Instead, incumbents must rely on less attributable techniques like vote-buying and voter-pressure, despite their significantly greater cost and lower reliability.

Theories of manipulation that focus solely on principals' incentives should generally favor increased election fraud. As electoral outcomes become more uncertain, both the likelihood of losing office and the likelihood of significant post-election backlash increase. Incumbents are thus in a position of needing to significantly boost their vote-count while minimizing the visibility of manipulation. Falsification (and to a lesser extent ballot-stuffing) meets these criteria most effectively. It is very cost effective, requiring only that the incumbent have influence over members of the electoral administration and that they mis-report the results of the election. It does not require large networks of agents, is easily monitored (e.g. by setting vote-share and turnout targets), and can be kept hidden from voters.

2.4 Summary and general expectations of theory

The core of this theory is that front-line agents of election manipulation campaigns in authoritarian regimes and electoral democracies face real risks of exposure and punishment. When deciding whether and how to participate in an election-manipulation scheme, agents must weigh the risks of exposure against the risks of displeasing their political patrons.⁷ Knowing this, in order to survive against a strong opposition, incumbents must invest in the tools needed to solve principal-agent problems. They must centralize control over patronage resources in their domain, to better offer rewards to agents and entice them away from the opposition. This theory thus expects that when incumbents face stronger opposition threats will *invest more heavily in the tools social control*. They will be more likely to centralize control over patronage resources, to invest in repressive capacity, and to seek influence over the legal system.

Second, the theory predicts that incumbents who develop those capacities will use them to effectively and extensively manipulate elections. This follows the logic laid out by Simpser (2013), who argues that incumbents have strong incentives to demonstrate their capacity to manipulate elections in order to influence other actors' behavior. In other words, the theory predicts that *incumbents should manipulate more when they face strong oppositions*, rather than moderate their behavior, as conventional wisdom

⁷The risk of being cut off from the patronage network for failing to deliver sufficient votes is real. However, the risk is mitigated by the fact that principals can only imperfectly monitor their agents. It is difficult for a principal to know, for instance, how much of a positive electoral result is due to the agent's efforts and how much is due to her own local popularity. Moreover, it is difficult for the principal to know how many votes are being produced per unit of cost, and how much the agent is pocketing for himself. Incumbents have developed a variety of tools to try to circumvent this problem, like turnout-buying (Gans-Morse *et al.* 2014) and rewarding agents for public rallies (Szwarcberg 2014). These methods are imperfect, and some—like maintaining original, correct election protocols in addition to the official, doctored versions—actually increase the risk of exposure to agents. Consequently, while the probability that electoral misdeeds will be exposed can sometimes be low, so too can the probability that defection will be discovered by the principal.

might hold.

Incumbents are willing to take this risk, according to the theory, because they know that the capacity to manipulate elections overlaps with the capacity to suppress protest movements. The same tools that enable incumbents to solve principal-agent problems vis-à-vis front-line election agents also allow them to maintain loyalty within their networks and among the security services. As a result, theory predicts that, when post-election protests do occur, *greater electoral manipulation will be associated with quicker defeat of protest movements*.

Finally, the mechanism underlying the theory—agent-centered decision-making in the context of principal-agent problems—also yields testable hypotheses. The model assumes that agents face serious personal risks when they engage in illicit manipulation, even in highly authoritarian settings. This implies that *some agents must face serious criminal or other personal penalties when caught cheating in elections*. In the presence of such risks, the theory predicts that it will be more difficult to recruit agents to perform illicit acts that are easily attributable to the perpetrator. As a result, *when the local risk of exposure is high, falsification should be less common, while dispersed techniques like vote-buying should be more common*. Lastly, we should expect agents to update their estimation of local risks over time. *When an agent is harshly punished for illicit manipulation, subsequent manipulation in that region should decline*. However, by the same token, *when an exposed agent receives little to no penalty for illicit manipulation, subsequent manipulation in that region should increase*.

2.5 Conclusion

By shifting the analytical focus from leaders' incentives to those of front-line agents, this theory identifies new constraints on election manipulation efforts: those factors which increase the likelihood that perpetrators of illicit manipulation will be identified and punished. As such factors—like local political competition, independent courts and prosecutors, and active local media and civil society organizations—become more prominent, it is more difficult for incumbents to recruit agents to perform the most attributable forms of manipulation. Unfortunately for incumbents, these are also the techniques that tend to be most cost-effective; it is far cheaper to add five hundred votes to the ruling party's tally at the stroke of a pen, than to actually *buy* five hundred votes from the community. This helps explain how authoritarian regimes can disintegrate from the bottom-up, as opposition groups steadily gain power at the local level; it also points toward policy mechanisms that can help uphold election integrity.

However, it also suggests that protest risk will rarely deter incumbents from engaging in as much electoral manipulation as they can, as they steadily develop greater and greater social control. This is a pessimistic account for democratization in authoritarian regimes, which also highlights some possible 'red lines' for democratic erosion in established democracies. Democratic incumbents who succeed in politicizing control over patronage resources and over the legal system are building tools that may in able them to win rigged elections *and* survive the associated popular blowback.

Chapter 3

Survival of the fraudulent: Cross-national patterns of manipulation and protest outcome

Beginning with the ‘Bulldozer Revolution’ in Serbia, and ending with the 2009 electoral protests in Moldova, a series of mass protest events succeeded in ousting incumbent governments across the post-communist region. These ‘Color Revolutions’ (though only one, Ukraine’s Orange Revolution, is technically named after a color) often captivated public attention, with dramatic scenes of sustained mass protest, sometimes in the face of harsh repression. They also drew considerable attention of scholars of democracy and authoritarianism, coming as they did in the second decade after the fall of the Soviet Union brought about a ‘third wave’ of democracy.

Whether driven by effective opposition strategy (Bunce & Wolchik 2010b) or structural factors (Hale 2006; Lucan Way 2008), these contentious elections appeared to highlight a significant risk that incumbents accept when they manipulate elections. Though far from certain, egregious manipulation could result in mass protests that are costly to the regime, regardless of their outcome. In the worst case, as in Georgia (2003), Ukraine (2004), Kyrgyzstan (2005) and Moldova (2009), incumbents may find themselves ousted. Even in the case of a ‘failed revolution,’ as in Russia (2011-2012) or Belarus (2020-2021) incumbents may find themselves paying considerable resource costs, experiencing international repercussions, making concessions to the opposition, and/or reallocating the distribution of rents to elites and the security services in order to survive protest outbreaks.

Events like these play a central role in theories about election manipulation and how it might be curbed — with broader implications for the stability of both democratic and

authoritarian regimes. A classic view, influential in formal modeling, holds that when an incumbent resorts to election manipulation, it signals their unpopularity. That lack of public support, in turn, makes it harder for them to suppress a protest movement if the opposition decides to mobilize. Models in this tradition predict that some incumbents need to cheat to win reliably, but — fearing the backlash of costly protests — choose instead to take their chances with a relatively clean election. This framework carries an optimistic message: stronger opposition movements, meaning those that are better organized, better funded, and more popular, are more capable of deterring incumbents from rigging elections in the first place. That dynamic, in turn, makes democratic transition and consolidation more likely. I call this the regime-weakness model of manipulation.

A competing view has emerged in recent years. Developed most prominently by Simpser (2013), it argues that election manipulation is actually a costly signal of the incumbent's power and resources. By manipulating elections, incumbents demonstrate their financial muscle, patronage networks, organizational capacity, and ability to bend or break the law. On this account, incumbents who manipulate elections effectively are not revealing weakness through unpopularity — they are displaying alternative sources of strength that can offset low public approval, and that can equally be deployed to suppress protest movements after the election. I call this the regime-strength model.

At first glance, testing these competing models might seem straightforward. The regime-weakness model generally predicts that more manipulation — holding the incumbent's true popularity constant — makes it more likely that opposition groups will launch a post-election protest (Luo and Rozenas 2017; Little 2012; Schedler 2002; Beaulieu 2014). The most telling signal of incumbent weakness is a low vote-share achieved through heavy manipulation: by relying heavily on 'cheap-talk' manipulation and still posting a poor result, the incumbent demonstrates that its popularity is very low and that its chances of defeating a protest movement are slim. The regime-strength model, by contrast, predicts the opposite (Simpser 2013): by demonstrating resourcefulness and impunity, more manipulation should make protest less likely (holding vote-share constant). Under this model, the conditions most favorable for protest initiation are a low incumbent vote-share combined with a low level of manipulation — a combination that signals both weak natural popularity and limited resources.

There are two problems with this neat picture, however. First, the empirical evidence on the relationship between manipulation and protest has been mixed, revealing the limits of existing theory (Ananyev and Poyker 2022; Daxecker 2012; Hafner-Burton, Hyde, and Jablonski 2016; Hyde and Marinov 2014; Lankina and Skovoroda 2017). Second, the expected relationship between manipulation and protest under either model is complicated by a third framework: a more complex, grievance-based model of electoral protest. This view, which has substantial empirical support, holds that electoral protests are driven primarily by citizen grievances — not by the narrowly strategic calculations about the odds of toppling the government that the regime-weakness model assumes. Under the grievance framework, a heavily manipulated election can serve as a focal point for collective action when citizens harbor widespread discontent toward the incumbent (Tucker 2007). Combined with opposition elites' various incentives to stage or join protests (e.g. generating publicity, waging factional battles, costly signal-

ing in bargaining for policy change, etc.), this means that mass electoral protests may occur even when they have little chance of unseating a strong incumbent.

This theoretical tangle makes it difficult to distinguish between the regime-strength and regime-weakness models when looking at protest initiation as a dependent variable. Depending on which model of protest behavior is correct, the two models of manipulation can generate identical predictions. If protest movements are instrumentally rational and manipulation signals weakness, we would expect the probability of protest to rise with the level of manipulation. But if manipulation instead indicates regime strength, we might reach the same expectation — provided that mass protests are driven by grievance rather than instrumental calculation. In that model, protest initiation and extensive manipulation are correlated, but the relationship is confounded by the incumbent's low popularity. A strong-but-unpopular incumbent must manipulate heavily to win the election, while protests are likely to occur due to that same unpopularity (not because the opposition is exploiting a signal of weakness). Because a single outcome is consistent with two different theories, we are left at an impasse if protest initiation is the variable of interest.

To move the debate forward, I model electoral protest *duration* as a dependent variable, in addition to protest occurrence. The regime-weakness and regime-strength models produce distinct predictions with regard to protest duration, unlike with regard to protest initiation. Once protests begin, the 'strength' of an incumbent (that is, its likelihood of defeating the opposition movement) is no longer latent. Instead, the incumbent's response and its survival (or not) reveal the incumbents' true strength relative to the opposition. The more quickly a government is able to restore order, the greater the underlying (unobserved) distribution of power can be assumed to favor the incumbent. By contrast, the longer the government struggles to put down the protest movement, the less favorable the distribution of power.

Using data from 644 elections across 92 electoral authoritarian countries, from 1989 to 2012, the primary analysis in this chapter shows that governments that engage in more manipulation are likely to put down protests more quickly than governments that produce little manipulation, especially when incumbents claim small vote-shares. This result is consistent with a regime-strength model of electoral manipulation, in which the same incumbents that are best equipped to rig elections are also best equipped to survey extra-electoral challenges. The results also show that protest is most likely to be initiated when manipulation is severe but incumbent vote-share is low. Additional analyses make use of a fuller dataset which includes electoral democratic country-years, bringing the total number of cases to 1120.

In combination, this pattern is consistent with a world in which extensive election manipulation is indicative of incumbent resilience, while protest initiation is often not motivated by narrowly strategic goals. That is, protesters may take to the streets even when they have rationally low expectations of unseating the incumbent, in pursuit of broader goals and/or to express their anger and sense of grievance. In light of this pattern, it is likely that the role of electoral protest as a deterrent to manipulation has been overemphasized in prior theories.

This interpretation offers a unified explanation for several secular patterns: the infrequency of electoral protests (Brancati 2016), the limited success of such protests in toppling incumbent regimes, and the tendency of governments to report implausibly large victory margins in heavily rigged elections. For theories of electoral manipulation, it implies that more attention should be given to alternative deterrents to manipulation (such as the role of risk to low-level actors who implement manipulation, as explored later in this volume). Ultimately, this perspective points to a more pessimistic view of democratization through elections in authoritarian contexts, and for the logic of ‘self-enforcing democracy.’

3.1 Theory: Developing the regime-strength model of electoral manipulation

Under what circumstances should protest movements be expected to last longer in authoritarian regimes? Authoritarian incumbents have strong incentives to keep protests small and short-lived. Generally speaking, by definition, authoritarian regimes have a smaller winning coalition and selectorate than democracies do, and allocate more private and club goods to elites as a result (Bueno de Mesquita *et al.* 2005). Despite this, they can appear superficially popular, with most citizens falsifying their preferences and demonstrating support for the regime, tacitly or otherwise. The appearance of even a moderate number of protesters publicly signalling their disapproval of the government can trigger a cascade of dissent in short order, as other citizens stop falsifying their preferences as well (Kuran 1991). Given time, persistent protests can lead elites and the security services to update their prior beliefs about the strength of the incumbent, prompting defections (Chenoweth & Stephan 2011; Svolik 2012). Protest movements can also challenge the regime’s legitimacy (Keremoğlu *et al.* 2022), eroding individual compliance in other areas. To prevent all these negative outcomes, incumbents try to prevent mass protest from occurring, and to quickly quell those protest movements that do arise.

Assuming the incumbent remains in office, stronger protest movements will tend to last longer than weaker ones. Ordinary protesters are more likely to remain engaged when they are more aggrieved (Gurr 2015), when they are angrier, and when they observe many other people expressing their discontent; extensive public grievance can thus be a source of durability for protest movements. The longer-lasting and larger protest movements are, the more protesters may become socially networked, enabling easier subsequent mobilization (Schussman & Soule 2005; Stryker 2000), increasing organizational resilience and capacity. When group goals appear more achievable—in part because the protest movement is large, well-organized, and well-resourced, and the incumbent appears off balance—individuals will be more willing to participate in protest (Klandermans 1997) and to become regulars (Saunders *et al.* 2012). Strategic protest entrepreneurs, who are using protest as a form of costly bargaining against the incumbent, will aim to demonstrate the resilience and popularity of their movements in order to present a stronger negotiating position (Beaulieu 2014; Robertson 2010). As a result, they often seek to maintain high levels of mobilization even in the face of

repression and ordinary citizens' waning interest over time (Tilly & Tarrow 2015). On average, then, I expect that authoritarian and proto-authoritarian incumbents will seek to demobilize protest, and protest movement leaders will seek to maintain (or even increase) high levels of mobilization. Which side prevails, and how quickly, depends on the relative strength of each.

Simpser's foundational argument in the regime-strength model holds that manipulated elections can send costly signals of the incumbent's "capacities, resources, [and] dispositions" that will help it retain power in the future (Simpser 2013 p. 80)—that is, of its political strength. Additional research focusing on the principal-agent dynamics inherent in election manipulation reinforces the idea that manipulation carries such costly signals, such that more extensive electoral manipulation indicates greater regime strength. This research trend emphasizes the degree to which political principals require the cooperation of large numbers of front-line agents in order to generate extensive election fraud, agents who may shirk if their perceived interests are not aligned with the incumbent (Rundlett & Svolik 2016).

Electoral manipulation has been shown to be more extensive under conditions that minimize that minimize principal-agent problems (i.e. those that make low-level agents more likely to cooperate with the incumbent). These include: greater local popularity for the incumbent (Rundlett & Svolik 2016), greater incumbent control over patronage resources (Hale 2014; Harvey 2019), and lower risk of punishment for pro-regime law-breaking (Harvey 2022a). As discussed below, these capacities and resources are also independently useful for surviving post-election protest. Consequently, if an incumbent is able to manufacture a large numbers of votes, it is also likely to have the resource capacity, control over bureaucratic institutions, and perhaps deep wells of popularity in parts of the country that can serve as independent sources of regime durability, even if the incumbent's nationwide margin of victory is low. Lastly, extensive manipulation also indicates that large number of agents assess that the incumbent will remain in power in the future (Simpser 2013), which itself becomes a self-reinforcing equilibrium (Hale 2014).

These resources and capacities improve the incumbent's ability to respond to a nascent protest movement through repression or concessions.¹ (Bishara 2015; Frantz & Kendall-Taylor 2014; Hummel 2019; Lipsky 1968; Rasler 1996; Tilly 1978). Concessions may be aimed at protesting parties themselves (Hafner-Burton *et al.* 2016; Moore 2000; Piven & Cloward 1979; Reuter & Robertson 2015) or the more moderate public, in order to keep them on the sidelines of the conflict (Hummel 2019). In either case, large-scale election manipulation indicates control over considerable patronage resources (Greene 2007; Hale 2014; Harvey 2019), which in turn indicates the capacity to engage in such payments (or withhold them from clients in exchange for passive support (Rosenfeld 2017)).

Ruling parties may also lean on repression, calling upon the security services to disperse protests, arrest leaders, and perhaps employ harsher methods including disappearance, torture, and execution (Davenport 2007; Escribà-Folch 2013). Though such

¹Toleration, another possibility, is discussed later.

crackdowns risk provoking a backlash, they are aimed at demobilizing the opposition by increasing the costs of participation in overt dissent (Vogel 2022). The ability to protect regime agents from any legal consequences for carrying out orders, a condition which helps enable illegal election manipulation (Harvey 2022a), is also an asset when asking law enforcement agents to carry out possibly violent repression (Abouharb *et al.* 2013; Magaloni & Rodriguez 2020; Stavro & Welch 2023). Additionally, more consolidated control over patronage resources can help incentivize elite unity (Arriola 2009; Hale 2014; Reuter & Szakonyi 2019), which can enable repression by the security forces (Albrecht & Ohl 2016; Frugé 2019; Hendrix & Salehyan 2017).

In addition, as Gehlbach and Simpson (2015) argue, effective electoral manipulation can induce regime agents to exert effort on behalf of the incumbent. Elite defections, which can presage real challenges for the incumbent during a crisis, are also rarer in less democratic regions, where election manipulation is likely more severe (Reuter & Szakonyi 2019). Just as election manipulation has been held to solve a coordination problem for regime opponents, it may also solve a coordination problem for regime agents: when successful, a campaign to manufacture votes signals to agents that other agents are likely to stick with the incumbent due to its revealed capacities (Hale 2014).

Putting it all together: this theory assumes that authoritarian incumbents generally prefer order to unrest, and that protesters—who under either a narrow or broadly strategic view are aiming for some kind of concession from the incumbent—want to demonstrate the popularity of their cause through large, sustained protests. Electoral protests are a form of competition between the incumbent and opposition actors, in which both sides are trying to demonstrate their strength in order to win concessions from—or defeat outright—the other (Beaulieu 2014). The outcome of this contest reveals the underlying strengths of the participants. Consequently, governments that quickly defeat protest movements can be considered stronger than those that take weeks or months to prevail, which in turn can be considered stronger than those governments which collapse in the face of mass protest. Incumbents with the resources and capacities needed to produce widespread election manipulation can draw on those same tools to buy off, repress, or otherwise quash post-election protest. This yields Hypothesis 2.

H1: Election manipulation is negatively associated with protest movement survival, with the size of this effect increasing with incumbent vote-share.

Second, this analysis will also confirm that electoral manipulation is associated with increasing likelihood of protest initiation, especially when the incumbent vote-share is low. The proposed mechanism, however, is different from that articulated in regime-weakness models. In those models, a high fraud / low incumbent vote-share is the ideal signal of regime weakness. It alerts the opposition that the incumbent's true popularity is unusually low (since fraud is cheap talk), and thus that the incumbent is unlikely to survive a protest movement. Protest initiation is thus strategically rational in a narrow sense, in regime-weakness models of manipulation.

This argument holds that widespread public grievances lead to low natural popularity for the incumbent, prompting the use of electoral manipulation to offset this disadvantage. Protests are more likely to occur both because of these underlying grievances (Beaulieu

2014; Brancati 2016) and because a manipulated—or “stolen”—election serves as a coordination signal for collective action (Tucker 2007). As an incumbent’s genuine vote share rises, holding the level of manipulation constant, protest becomes less likely due to diminished public discontent. Conversely, for a constant level of popularity, an increase in manipulation raises the perceived credibility of election theft, thereby making protest more likely among disaffected citizens.

Here, the argument is that widespread grievances result in low natural popularity for the incumbent; at election time, the incumbent must compensate for this low popularity by manipulating the election. Protest initiation is made more likely both by the population’s grievances alone (Beaulieu 2014; Brancati 2016), and by the coordination device provided by the ‘stolen’ election (Tucker 2007). As natural vote-share increases for a fixed level of manipulation, the likelihood of protest initiation should decline due to reduced grievances; for a fixed level of popularity, increasing manipulation should increase the likelihood of protest by raising the plausibility of a stolen election among dissatisfied citizens.

H2: Increasing election fraud makes protest initiation more likely, with the size of this effect decreasing with incumbent-party vote-share.

The core of the argument is as follows: incumbents generally aim to manipulate elections as extensively as possible to reap both the direct and indirect benefits of doing so (Simpser 2013). Achieving this requires overcoming principal-agent problems—by tightening control over patronage networks and insulating agents from potential consequences. The very resources that enable large-scale manipulation—such as genuine popularity, control over state resources, and dominance of the legal system—also equip incumbents to suppress or dismantle protest movements when they arise. Consequently, more extensive manipulation should correlate with shorter durations of anti-incumbent protests.

One potential challenge to this theory is the possibility that incumbents might choose to tolerate protests rather than suppress or co-opt them. However, this concern is relatively limited for the cases considered here. Toleration is most likely when protests pose minimal costs to the regime and make narrow or localized demands (Klein & Regan 2018). National elections, by contrast, are highly salient, and contesting their legitimacy poses a direct threat to incumbents’ survival in office. In such contexts, tolerance is unlikely. What may appear as toleration is more accurately described as attrition—efforts by the incumbent to raise the costs of participation and gradually wear down protest movements without resorting to overt repression (Yuen & Cheng 2017). Thus, even without direct crackdowns or concessions, we should expect incumbents to take measures to undermine and disperse post-election protests.

Testing both H1 and H2 will shed light on the validity of the regime-weakness model of electoral manipulation. If H2 is supported but H1 is not, this would suggest that manipulation reflects incumbent vulnerability, with protest movements exploiting this weakness. Alternatively, if both hypotheses are supported, it would point toward a regime-strength interpretation, in which manipulation reflects incumbent capacity and protest serves broader purposes.

This argument—that successful, large-scale election manipulation draws on the same resources a state may use to suppress protest—turns the deterrent logic on its head. Instead of signalling weakness, large-scale fraud indicates a well of resilience: control over resources, impunity for pro-regime lawbreaking, and loyal agents. As a result, governments that build and deploy an electoral manipulation apparatus are simultaneously inoculating themselves against the expected cost of protest.

3.2 Data and methods

These hypotheses are tested using data from three datasets: NELDA (Hyde & Marinov 2012), V-Dem version 15 (Coppedge *et al.* 2025b), and the Electoral Contention and Violence dataset (Daxecker *et al.* 2019). The unit of observation for this study is an election period as recorded in NELDA. This framework prevents selecting on the dependent variable, by capturing both protested and non-protested elections. I include in the sample authoritarian regimes which hold multiparty national elections (as well as, in some analyses) electoral democracies. This excludes fully closed autocracies (where no national elections are held *de jure*), as well as liberal democracies. The specific variable used is ‘v2x_regime’; I limit the sample in the primary analysis to those regime-years coded 1 (electoral authoritarian) for the election year. Secondary analyses also include country-years coded 2 (electoral democracy). This sample includes a range of electoral authoritarian cases, including those that might be labeled as ‘hegemonic’ and ‘competitive’ (Donno 2013).² For instance, the dataset includes election years from Egypt and Belarus, but also from Ukraine, and Mexico in the 1990s. Regarding electoral democracies, the dataset includes cases like Bulgaria, Brazil, or Senegal in the 1990s and 2000s, and India in the 1990s.

Although the theoretical mechanisms discussed here may also operate in liberal democracies, their influence likely diminishes as democratization progresses. As states move closer to liberal democracy, patronage networks tend to weaken, and adherence to the rule of law increases—developments that inherently make it harder for incumbents to manipulate elections and easier for challengers to mobilize electoral protest. Moreover, in more liberal-democratic contexts, citizens and opposition actors have a broader range of institutional tools beyond protest to hold executives accountable. Independent judiciaries and stronger constraints on executive power have been linked to improved electoral integrity (Bishop & Hoeffler 2016; Harvey 2022a). It is in electoral authoritarian regimes—where such institutional checks are weakest—that the deterrence logic associated with the regime-weakness model is most applicable.

Additionally, from a methodological standpoint, protest duration becomes a less reliable indicator of regime strength in more liberal democratic environments, where protests are more routine and pose less of an immediate threat to incumbents. Therefore, the

²According to the V-Dem codebook, the coding scheme includes cases where multiparty elections were manipulated to the extent that “irregularities...affected the outcome of the election,” and ones in which it is “hard to determine whether the irregularities affected the outcome or not.” Only when irregularities definitively did not affect the outcome would election-years be categorized as electoral democracy, and excluded from the main analysis.

decision to exclude liberal democracies from the analysis aligns both with the theoretical focus and with the goal of conducting a more rigorous test of the regime-weakness model. The case selection strategy here, excluding liberal democracies, is thus one that both fits the theory and makes for a stronger test of the regime-weakness model. In total, there are 1120 elections across 117. The date range is limited by the availability of data on protest from ECAV, which ranges from 1989 to 2012.

For models of protest-wave duration, as discussed in more detail below, I include only observations where a positive number of protests occurred. Only 291 fall into this more limited dataset. In eleven of these cases, according to NELDA, protesters succeeded in ousting the government for forcing new elections.³

3.2.1 Dependent variables and modeling strategies

ECAV records protests and other events related to an election, ranging from six months before to three months after the vote (or three months after the final round of a multi-round election). To qualify, an action must be contentious; rallies in support of the incumbent are excluded. I only include events labeled as protests, occupations, or blockades, excluding acts like shootings, bombings, and coups. If any post-election protests are recorded in the ECAV data for a particular election, the binary variable *protest initiation* is marked as 1. ECAV data is in event-day format; to capture *protest duration* I take the number of days between the last protest recorded in ECAV and the first, for each election.⁴ For the survival models, protest movements that were ultimately defeated by the incumbent are considered ‘dead’ after the last day of protest. Protest movements that prevailed in unseating the incumbent are included, and are marked as ‘alive.’

The large majority of elections experience no post-election protest: in 829 of the 1120 elections, no protests are recorded. Figure 3.1 reports the distribution of election fraud across the dataset, as well as protest duration. As the figure shows, while election fraud is common among this set of regimes, protests are rare, and, when they do occur, are usually short in duration. These distributions—extensive election fraud combined with large numbers of non-protest—provides some early indication that the regime-weakness model has limited support. Still, approximately one-quarter of elections experienced some protest, and so protest initiation is modeled using standard logistic regression. Protest wave duration is modeled using Cox proportional hazards models.

3.2.2 Explanatory variables

To capture the severity of *election fraud*, I use the V-Dem measure of intentional election irregularities, a category which includes “double IDs, intentional lack of voting materials, ballot-stuffing, misreporting of votes, and false collation of votes.” It is important to note that this measure captures illegal election-day manipulation broadly, and is not confined simply to falsification.

³These cases are: Bangladesh (1996), Peru (2000), Serbia (2000), Georgia (2003), Ukraine (2004), Azerbaijan (2005), Kyrgyzstan (2005), Haiti (2006), and Cote d’Ivoire (2000 and 2010).

⁴The duration of a protest wave with only one protest is taken to be one day.

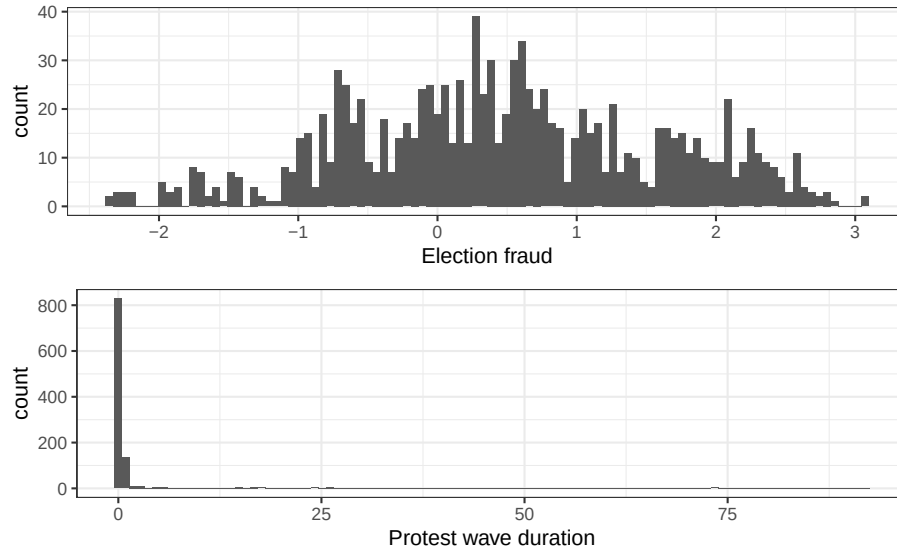


Figure 3.1: Histograms of election fraud and protest duration

I operationalize electoral manipulation using this variable, rather than alternative measures of election integrity, because fraud of this kind is thought to be most likely to trigger protest (Linebarger & Salehyan 2020)—it is often incumbents’ tool of last resort (Sjoberg 2016), may not mobilize real voters (Harvey & Mukherjee 2020), and can be more damaging to legitimacy than pre-election manipulation (Birch 2011; Szakonyi 2021). This measure of election integrity should thus serve as a strong test of the regime-weakness model: if manipulation indicates incumbent weakness, it will be most likely to do so when employed in this way. It also matches the conception of election manipulation used in much of the relevant formal literature.⁵

3.2.3 Control variables

Since vote-share data is given in V-Dem for the winning party in an election, without recording whether that winner was the incumbent or the challenger, it is necessary to include controls for incumbent defeat in the models. From the point of view of those considering anti-incumbent protest, for instance, a large opposition vote-share conveys very different information when the opposition is declared the loser compared to when it wins outright. Consequently, in models of protest initiation, I condition for whether the incumbent party lost, based on coding in NELDA. In the binary models of Hypothesis 2, I control for incumbent loss as a standalone variable or in interaction with the main explanatory variables.

For the models of protest duration, I exclude all cases where the incumbent lost the

⁵For example, election manipulation is treated as post-hoc adjustment of the results in Little et al (2015a), Little (2012), Magaloni (2010), and Fearon (2011), among others.

election outright. This limits the observations to those that fit the population of interest: protest following an election in which the incumbent claimed victory, possibly through reliance on election fraud.⁶

The models incorporate several potential confounding variables, in addition to the *election fraud* variable described above. The *lagged GDP growth rate*, taken from V-Dem, is used to capture economic grievances: lower GDP growth rates, especially negative ones, should be expected to increase citizens' sense of grievance. The winning party's *vote-share* is also taken from the V-Dem dataset.⁷

As identified in prior research, other factors that may influence both fraud and protest are included as controls variables. The repressive capacity of the government (Davenport *et al.* 2019) is measured using the *physical integrity index* from V-Dem (*v2x_clphy*), and its square term. Indicators of government *control over civil society* (the '*v2csecorgs*' variable from V-Dem), *de facto judicial independence* (Linzer & Staton 2015) and the available of *alternative sources of information* ('*v2x_freexp_altinf*' from V-Dem) are also employed. Since urban areas can make electoral manipulation more difficult (Larreguy *et al.* 2016a; Ziblatt 2009) while also making protest more likely (Wallace 2013), I also include data on *urbanization* taken from the United Nations (Department of Economic and Social Affairs (Population Division) 2019). All models include *legislative constraints* on the executive, a V-Dem variable which captures the extent to which the legislative body in the country acts independently in practice to limit executive power.

In addition, the literature on the diffusion of electoral protest holds that successful electoral protest in one country increases the likelihood of electoral protest in similar countries nearby (Beissinger 2007; Bunce & Wolchik 2010a). Such a dynamic could plausibly increase the likelihood of protest in a nearby country, while also reducing the incumbent's use of fraud. I control for this using each country's geopolitical region as coded in Teorell *et al.* (2019), in conjunction with binary variables indicating a successful protest movement from NELDA. A 'successful protest' is recorded if a protest movement resulted in either a new election being run or the incumbent stepping down. The *regional diffusion* dummy variable takes on a value of one for all countries in the same region as a successful protest, for elections within one calendar year of the successfully overturned election.⁸

Several other binary control variables are also included. First, a variable from NELDA is used to indicate *presidential* elections, since these may include both higher levels of

⁶Excluding cases where incumbents stepped down after losing an election avoids introducing measurement error in the dependent variable, due to a quirk of the ECAV dataset, which codes the 'side' of the protest (pro- or anti-government) as missing during the period between an election and the swearing in of a new government in cases where the incumbent loses. Including these cases thus runs the risk of conflating pro- and anti-incumbent protest, along with cases where protesters goals are genuinely unknown. However, excluding them also influences the interpretation of the results from these models. Threats to inference from this section are evaluated in more detail in the discussion section.

⁷This variable has considerable missingness, which I reduced in part by updating missing values in V-Dem using data from Wikipedia (when links to official sources were available), and Psephos.

⁸For example, the variable takes on a positive value for elections held in the post-communist region, within one year of the September 24, 2000 election in Serbia that sparked the 'Bulldozer Revolution'.

Table 3.1: Summary statistics and variable distributions

	Unique (#)	Missing (%)	Mean	SD	Min	Median	Max
Legislative constraints	369	2	0.5	0.3	0.0	0.5	1.0
Alternative information	410	0	0.6	0.2	0.0	0.7	1.0
GDP growth rate	713	1	0.0	0.0	-0.2	0.0	0.3
Civil society openness	362	0	0.9	1.1	-2.7	1.2	3.1
Election fraud	610	0	0.5	1.1	-2.3	0.4	3.1
Presidential election	2	0	1.4	0.5	1.0	1.0	2.0
Incumbent term-limited	3	4	0.1	0.3	0.0	0.0	1.0
Physical integrity index	365	0	0.6	0.3	0.0	0.6	1.0
Urbanization	712	0	49.2	19.5	6.8	49.1	100.0
Winning vote-share	633	10	0.5	0.2	0.1	0.5	1.0
Number of pre-election protests	38	0	1.6	7.5	0.0	0.0	100.0
Off-schedule election	2	0	1.4	0.5	1.0	1.0	2.0
Regional protest diffusion	2	0	0.2	0.4	0.0	0.0	1.0
Large protest	2	0	0.0	0.1	0.0	0.0	1.0

manipulation (Simpser 2013) and a greater risk of protest. Another NELDA variable indicates if the incumbent executive is not running due to *term limits* (Hale 2014). Since strong non-democratic governments may be able to adjust the electoral calendar strategically (to affecting both election manipulation and protest risk), I include a variable from NELDA that indicates *off-schedule elections*.

In the models of electoral protest initiation, I include the *number of pre-election protests* counted in the ECAV dataset, which is likely to be an important possible confounder; more numerous pre-election protest may affect the level of election fraud (as the deterrence logic predicts) as well as being directly tied to the likelihood of post-election protest. Finally, in the models of protest duration, I also include a binary measure that captures whether any protest in the wave was *large*, using ECAV data. ECAV data codes protest size as a categorical variable, ranging from 1 (< 10 participants) to 5 (> 10,000). If any single protest event was categorized as a ‘5’ on this scale, the *any large protest* variable takes on a value of 1. This is important as a control for the possibility that incumbents may tolerate smaller protests.

Table 3.1 provides summary statistics for these variables.

3.3 Results

3.3.1 Fraud and the duration of protest

Table 3.2 reports the results of Cox proportional hazard models of protest duration. In these models, positive coefficients indicate factors that are associated with shorter-lived protests; those with a negative sign indicate factors associated with greater likelihood of protest-movement survival. Models 4 and 5 do not include controls (other than *presidential election*, which is included due to the common mechanical difference in win-

ning vote-shares between presidential and parliamentary elections), while the remaining models include a fuller set of controls. Models 1 and 3 do not account for potential right-censoring, while Models 2, 4, and 5 do. Accounting for right-censoring helps address a threat to inference in this design that derives from the 90-day post-election window considered by ECAV. It is possible that some protest movements considered ‘dead’ in the baseline Models 1 and 3 are, in fact, ‘alive,’ if subsequent protests occurred after 90 days and are unobserved. To address this, observations are assumed to be right-censored if a protest occurred within three-weeks of the 90-day cutoff in Models 2, 4, and 5. This amounts to 15 of the 156 observations in the sample. Model 5 includes right censoring as well as a control variable for the occurrence of at least one very large protest. Lastly, in order to interpret these findings, it is important to recall that these models include only cases where incumbents claimed victory and electoral protest occurred.

To aid in the interpretation of the interaction effect in Model 4 (with right-censoring), Figure 3.3 shows the predicted risk score. As shown in the figure, for all incumbent vote-shares near and below fifty percent, large-scale fraud significantly increases the likelihood that a protest movement will end in defeat. This result also supports the regime-strength model, and shows that only as vote-share increases above fifty percent—creating a stronger signal of popularity, another independent source of regime strength—does a government in a low-fraud election have the same likelihood of defeating a protest movement at a given time. In effect, either high genuine popularity *or* the ability to produce high levels of fraud enables governments to more quickly end protests.

The results of the models are roughly consistent whether they incorporate censoring or not. Model 5 adds the a control for large protests, as a measure of the level of danger faced by the incumbent. Including this control variable does not meaningfully change the results; the interaction coefficient retains its direction and statistical significance.

The relationship between the level of fraud and the survival of protest movements can also be demonstrated non-parametrically using Kaplan-Meier curves for varying levels of fraud. In Figure 3.2, observations are divided into three groups. High fraud observations are those where *election fraud* is one standard deviation above the median or more, low fraud observations are those one standard deviation below the median or less, with moderate levels in between. The figure shows a clear difference between the low-fraud group and the other two. Low-fraud cases are much more likely to see their protest movements survive past the first day than their counterparts. For much of the range of the data, they remain roughly twice as likely to survive at any given date than protest movements in medium- or high-fraud cases. This is further evidence in that high levels of fraud is an indication of regime resilience, as it is the low-fraud cases where governments struggle to put an end to protest movements on average.

3.3.2 Fraud and the likelihood of protest

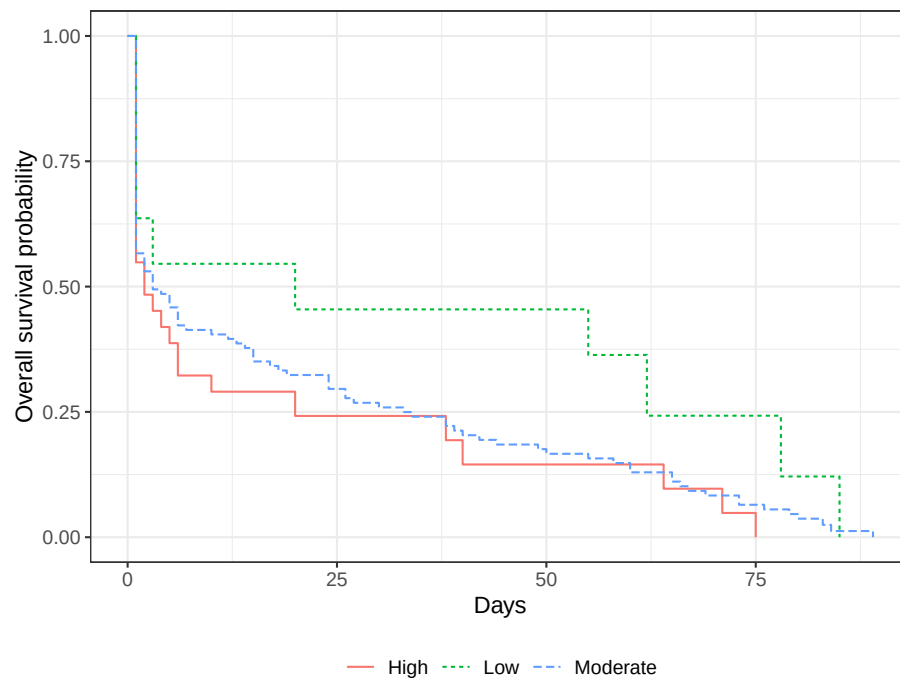


Figure 3.2: Kaplan-Meier curves for protest duration across levels of fraud

Table 3.2: Table 4: Cox proportional hazard models of protest duration

	Model 1	Model 2	Model 3	Model 4	Model 5
Presidential election	−0.214 (0.183)	−0.213 (0.186)	−0.141 (0.198)	−0.173 (0.203)	−0.157 (0.208)
Leg. constraints (lag)			−0.666 (0.454)	−0.549 (0.451)	−0.448 (0.473)
GDP growth rate (lag)			−3.079 (2.410)	−3.399 (2.402)	−3.506 (2.428)
Incumbent term-limited			−0.551 (0.337)	−0.446 (0.336)	−0.410 (0.334)
Urbanization			0.002 (0.006)	0.002 (0.006)	0.003 (0.006)
Off-schedule election			0.182 (0.241)	0.222 (0.242)	0.294 (0.242)
Number of pre-election protests			−0.016* (0.008)	−0.013+ (0.007)	
Phys. integrity index (lag)			0.072 (0.447)	0.270 (0.454)	0.425 (0.466)
Regional protest diffusion			−0.499* (0.228)	−0.105 (0.217)	
Large protest (> 10,000)					−0.096 (0.385)
Incumbent vote-share	2.846* (1.178)	3.278** (1.171)	2.876* (1.258)	3.244** (1.256)	3.322** (1.255)
Election fraud	0.853* (0.384)	1.072** (0.370)	0.898* (0.420)	1.061** (0.405)	1.105** (0.401)
Election fraud:Inc. vote-share	−1.461* (0.664)	−1.814** (0.647)	−1.413* (0.704)	−1.696* (0.680)	−1.772** (0.678)
Num.Obs.	149	146	144	141	141
RMSE	0.95	0.93	0.93	0.95	0.94

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

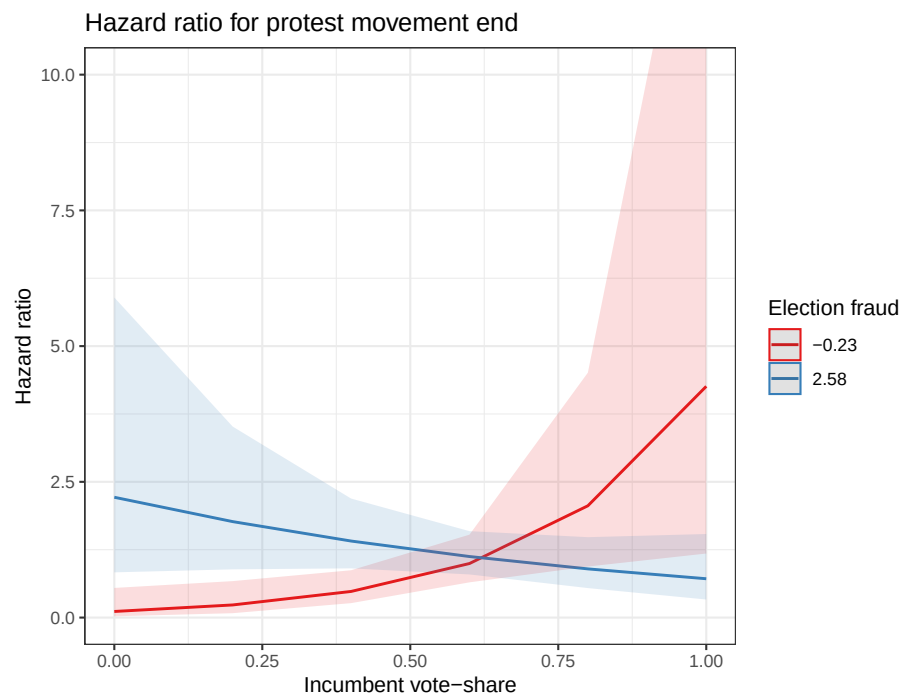


Figure 3.3: Fraud, winning vote-share, and duration of protest

Table 3.3: Table 3: Logit models of protest occurrence

	Model 6	Model 7	Model 8
(Intercept)	-0.020 (0.304)	-1.333* (0.611)	-8.582*** (1.866)
Incumbent loss	0.067 (0.252)	2.239* (1.047)	5.211** (1.845)
Election fraud	0.160 (0.103)	1.091** (0.415)	3.466*** (0.849)
Winner vote-share	-1.253** (0.466)	0.039 (1.000)	6.402** (2.093)
Winner vote-share:Election fraud		-1.455* (0.635)	-5.633*** (1.366)
Winner vote-share:Inc. loss		-3.965+ (2.030)	-9.187* (3.587)
Election fraud:Inc. loss		-1.719* (0.818)	-4.374*** (1.284)
Election fraud:Winner vote-share:Inc. loss		3.067+ (1.636)	8.431*** (2.501)
Judicial independence (lag)			2.281 (1.493)
Leg. constraints (lag)			0.850 (0.948)
GDP growth rate (lag)			4.390 (3.459)
Alternative info. (lag)			-0.849 (1.516)
Civil soc. openness (lag)			0.411 (0.266)
Incumbent term-limited			-1.426* (0.725)
Urbanization			0.009 (0.010)
Rentier state			0.758 (0.517)
Tax state			0.309 (0.505)
Presidential		1.084***	1.984***

		(0.207)	(0.396)
Off-schedule election			0.158
			(0.372)
Number of pre-election protests			21.189
			(1146.339)
Phys. integrity index (lag)			3.759
			(3.904)
Phys. int. lag squared			-5.488
			(3.848)
Regional protest diffusion			0.648
			(0.447)
Num.Obs.	500	500	455
AIC	656.7	633.1	293.6
BIC	673.5	671.1	388.4

+ $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table 3.3 shows the results for Hypothesis 2. Model 6 is a base model, where incumbent loss, winner vote-share, and *election fraud* are standalone variables. In keeping with the general (though inconsistent) findings in the prior literature, there is a significant positive relationship between fraud severity and the likelihood of protest initiation. The winner's claimed margin of victory is negatively associated with protest initiation. Model 7 includes the three-way interaction between *election fraud*, incumbent loss, and winning vote-share, with no controls other than a dummy variable for *presidential elections*. This allows for the largest possible sample size, and shows that the coefficient signs are consistent with those of the full Model 8.

Model 8 is the main model, which includes the full set of controls. Given the complexity of the model, Figure 3.4 illustrates the effects of election fraud on protest risk across various levels of winning vote-share and incumbent loss⁹. The values for election fraud represent one standard deviation above and below the mean value.

The direction of the effect supports Hypothesis 2. When an incumbent claims victory (left panel) and their vote-share is low, electoral protest is significantly likelier when fraud is elevated than when the election is relatively clean. Furthermore, protest against winning incumbents is significantly likelier when fraud is high and vote-shares are low, compared to an election with an equivalent level of fraud but high claimed vote-shares. As noted above, such a finding could be consistent with either the regime-weakness or regime-strength models of manipulation, under different conceptualizations of protest. To distinguish between the two, we turn to the models of protest duration.

⁹All other variables constant at their means (continuous variables) or modes (categorical variables).

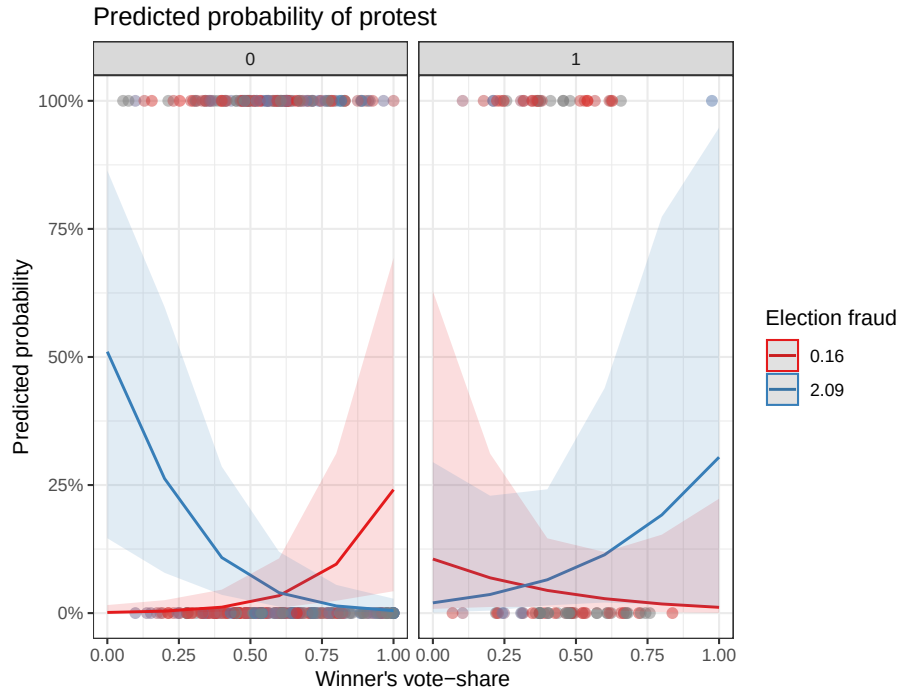


Figure 3.4: Fraud, winning vote-share, and probability of protest initiation

3.4 Additional analysis: structural and protest-based correlates of fraud

The final section of this chapter tests the implication that incumbents should respond to greater protest risk by *increasing* the level of electoral manipulation (conditional on their structural ability to do so). Testing for this possibility simultaneously helps confirm the theory that strong incumbents are not fearful of mass protest, and helps rule out selection effects that might undermine the general findings above.¹⁰ Here, I use a similar approach to take two different cuts at the data. First, I model the likelihood of post-election protest in each case, using only pre-election variables. I then use this propensity score for protest to model the level of electoral manipulation that in fact occurs. In the second approach, I model the predicted average level of manipulation in each case, and use the residuals from that model as a measure of over- or under-production of manipulation relative to baseline. I then model those residuals as a function of pre-election predictors of protest. In both approaches, the outcome is the same: a greater risk of protest is associated with a *higher* production of manipulation, not lower.

Together, these two approaches provide mutually reinforcing evidence. The propensity score approach establishes that anticipated protest is a positive predictor of manipulation; the residuals approach confirms that this relationship holds even after accounting for the structural conditions that make manipulation possible in the first place. Both findings are consistent with the theory that strong incumbents are not deterred by the prospect of mass protest — indeed, they treat it as a reason to consolidate their advantage further. This directly complements the main analysis: if incumbents feared protest, they would pull back on manipulation to avoid provoking it; the fact that they do the opposite suggests they are confident in their ability to weather any backlash.

3.4.1 Predicted and residual levels of fraud

First, let us consider how indicators of protest risk shape deviations from the expected level of electoral manipulation in each case. To do so, I use all the observations in the dataset to estimate the predicted level of election fraud for each case, using only structural variables (i.e. professionalization of the bureaucracy, electoral management body autonomy, urbanization, etc.) in an OLS model. Factors associated with classic protest deterrence, like the number of pre-election protests, are excluded. This should produce an estimate of the structural level of manipulation the incumbent could produce in the absence of strategic deterrence.

The residuals from this first model are then used as the dependent variable in a second model. These residuals capture the extent to which an incumbent manipulated more or less than their baseline level would predict — that is, whether they over- or

¹⁰The classic regime-weakness models predict that some incumbents who will voluntarily avoid electoral manipulation and accept a possible loss at the ballot box, to avoid costly protest. If this is the case, it could introduce selection bias into the sample for the duration analyses, by sorting only the strongest incumbents into the sample that faces protest.

under-produced manipulation. If the deterrence interpretation is correct, indicators of protest risk should be negatively associated with these residuals: incumbents facing greater protest risk should pull back on manipulation, producing less than expected. The regime-strength logic predicts the opposite — that incumbents facing riskier environments will work harder to signal strength, and so will manipulate more than their baseline predicts.

Table 3.4 shows the results. Model 5 shows how structural factors are predictors of the level of observed manipulation. We observe some expected results; for instance, more autonomous EMBs and more professionalized bureaucracies are associated with lower fraud. Model 6 shows that indicators of protest risk—the number of pre-election protests, and the existence of a recent successful protest movement in the region—are not associated with lower fraud. In fact, just the opposite: incumbents appear to manipulate more heavily under riskier conditions. This is a key finding, and is evidence against the classic deterrent approach; it also suggests that weaker governments are not voluntarily dialing back manipulation to avoid protest, mitigating concerns about selection effects in the main models.

Table 3.4: Models of manipulation and residuals (OLS) and incumbent loss (logit)

	Model 5	Model 6
	Fraud	Fraud residual
(Intercept)	0.967*** (0.135)	−0.041+ (0.023)
Judicial independence (lag)	−0.615*** (0.140)	
GDP growth rate (lag)	1.321** (0.432)	
Presidential election	0.062 (0.043)	
Urbanization	−0.008*** (0.001)	
Rentier state	−0.005 (0.068)	
Tax state	0.225*** (0.067)	
Phys. integrity index (lag)	1.987*** (0.400)	
Phys. int. lag squared	−2.313*** (0.356)	
Private ownership (lag)	0.080** (0.025)	
Professional bureaucracy (lag)	−0.195*** (0.029)	
EMB autonomy	−0.429*** (0.026)	
Number of pre-election protests		0.0007 (0.003)
Regional protest diffusion		0.223*** (0.054)
Num.Obs.	1072	1072
R2	0.614	0.016
R2 Adj.	0.610	0.014
AIC	2253.6	2218.7
BIC	2318.3	2238.6
F	153.199	8.474

+ $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

3.4.2 Protest risk and fraud level

Examining the data from the other direction produces similar results. In this approach, a logit model of any post-election protest is fit, using a broad set of covariates. The

fitted values (i.e. predicted probabilities of protest) for each observation are obtained as propensity scores for protest, to be used in the second set of models. The goal of this step is to estimate the underlying likelihood of post-election protest in each case, independent of the level of election fraud observed on election day. This propensity score can then be used as an explanatory variable in subsequent models of *electoral fraud*, to see if a greater risk of protest is associated with reduced manipulation (as the regime-weakness model would predict) or greater manipulation (as the regime-strength model might hold).

Since this approach takes the overall level of fraud as a dependent variable (rather than deviation from baseline), it is also appropriate to include electoral democracies in this analysis. As countries democratize, we might expect that protest risk increases, through greater freedom to organize, fewer media restrictions, and greater respect for individual political liberties (this is the logic behind the idea of ‘self-enforcing’ democracy). Alternatively, we might expect that as countries democratize, incumbents on average become more constrained and less capable of wielding state power to influence election outcomes (through reduced control over patronage resources and greater accountability for law-breaking). Both of these factors should limit incumbents’ freedom to ‘dial manipulation up’ for particular elections in electoral democracies.

It is important to note that I am not implementing a propensity-score *matching* or weighting approach here. In this framework, actual protest cannot be considered a cause of electoral manipulation which occurs *before* the protest, and thus cannot be operationalized as a treatment variable. Instead, I aim to estimate the latent protest risk in each case, and analyze that risk as a predictor of observed electoral manipulation.

The effectiveness of this propensity score approach hinges on the success of the first-stage model, which should include variables that influence the likelihood of treatment. The first-stage model here includes lagged *judicial independence* (Linzer & Staton 2015), which can influence parties’ decision to challenge elections in the streets vs. the courtroom. It also includes lagged measures of civil society organization and legislative constraints on the executive, as estimates of the degree of contestation in the political system. The lagged openness of the media environment is included, since this could influence citizens’ ability to gather information about the quality of elections and to communicate their grievances. De facto protection of individual physical integrity is included (lagged), to account for the linear and curvilinear effects of repression on protest. The urban population share is included, since population density is a common correlate of protest. Lagged GDP growth is included as a measure of economic grievances. Three binary variables capture relevant features of the election. *Presidential* elections may have higher stakes, and thus be more prone to sparking protest. *Off-schedule elections* may be strategically timed by incumbents to account for more elevated protest risk. In addition, whether the executive is facing *term limits* is also included, since this can lead to fragmentation in the elite that can in turn yield protest Robertson (2010). These variables are all taken from V-Dem. The occurrence of a successful regional electoral protest in the previous year is included, given its potential to inspire protests in neighboring countries. Lastly, two final—and very important—covariates are included. These are: the number of pre-election protests (a very direct measure of protest risk),

and lagged overall election integrity (i.e. overall manipulation in the previous national election). This model appears to capture the latent risk of protest reasonably well; the average propensity score for country-years where no protest ultimately occurred is 0.12. By contrast, the average propensity score for country-years where protests *did* occur is 0.66.

The results of the first stage model are presented in Table 3.5.

The second-stage models are reported in Table 3.6. Model 7 includes the protest propensity score as the only covariate, as a baseline. For comparison, Model 8 includes all other covariates but excludes the protest propensity score. Model 9 includes the full set of variables. Finally, Model 10 replaces *protest propensity score* with ordinal indicators for each quartile of latent protest risk. That is, observations with propensity scores in the lowest quartile are assigned a value of 1, those in the second quartile, 2, and so on. This is done as a robustness check against the possible introduction of bias in the model from using a propensity score as a regression covariate (Hade & Lu 2014).

The results are strongly disconfirmatory for the regime-weakness model. Models 7, 9, and 10 show that latent protest risk (as operationalized by the protest propensity score) is associated with *increased* election-day manipulation. This is the opposite of the prediction that greater protest risk should be associated with restraint on the part of incumbents. We also observe the same relationship with successful regional protest; rather than making incumbents more cautious, the success of a neighboring protest movement appears to increase incumbents' incentives to manipulate.

Moreover, the models in Table 3.6 suggest that factors like judicial independence and the state's repressive capacity retain their sign and statistical significance even after controlling for the underlying risk of protest. This suggests that, even if such features of the political environment do contribute to protest risk, they have additional, separate effects on electoral manipulation. In particular, these results are consistent with the theory that more independent courts increase the risk of punishment for low-level election manipulators, making it more difficult for incumbents to secure their services. Likewise, a more active opposition in the legislature appears to reduce the severity of electoral fraud *after controlling for* the latent likelihood of protest in a case. In turn, this is consistent with a worldview that suggests that greater political fragmentation and contestation deprives the executive of centralized control over resources and the ability to promise impunity to its lower level agents.

3.5 Conclusion

Scholars disagree about how election fraud relates to post-election protest. One family of models — which I have called the regime-weakness model — predicts that incumbents may opt for cleaner elections when the risk of post-election protest is higher. A competing family of models holds that election fraud can itself be a signal of incumbent strength. Building on the principal-agent literature on election fraud, I argue that large-scale fraud draws on the same resources that make incumbents resilient to protest, even when low popularity is reflected in weak vote-shares. Fraud is easier to carry

Table 3.5: Logit model of protest occurrence in electoral authoritarian and electoral democratic regimes

	Model 9
(Intercept)	−3.211*** (0.732)
Presidential election	0.851*** (0.224)
Judicial independence (lag)	0.647 (0.797)
Leg. constraints (lag)	0.083 (0.600)
GDP growth rate (lag)	3.031 (2.147)
Alternative info. (lag)	−0.234 (1.047)
Civil soc. openness (lag)	0.319+ (0.181)
Incumbent term-limited	−0.586 (0.382)
Urbanization	0.0005 (0.006)
Overall elec. integrity (lag)	−0.936 (0.689)
Number of pre-election protests	19.596 (610.029)
Phys. integrity index (lag)	4.701* (2.341)
Phys. int. lag squared	−5.253** (2.038)
Regional protest diffusion	0.456+ (0.259)
Num.Obs.	1042
AIC	661.0
F	2.613
RMSE	0.30

+ $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table 3.6: OLS models of election fraud in electoral authoritarian and electoral democratic regimes

	Model 7	Model 8	Model 9	Model 10
(Intercept)	0.325*** (0.043)	2.078*** (0.154)	2.061*** (0.153)	1.932*** (0.158)
Presidential election		0.020 (0.055)	-0.005 (0.056)	-0.133+ (0.068)
Judicial independence (lag)		-2.027*** (0.174)	-2.031*** (0.174)	-2.052*** (0.173)
Leg. constraints (lag)		-0.539*** (0.140)	-0.562*** (0.140)	-0.565*** (0.140)
GDP growth rate (lag)		0.939+ (0.509)	0.744 (0.512)	0.344 (0.530)
Alternative info. (lag)		-0.278 (0.245)	-0.246 (0.244)	-0.177 (0.244)
Civil soc. openness (lag)		-0.054 (0.042)	-0.058 (0.042)	-0.101* (0.044)
Incumbent term-limited		-0.170+ (0.088)	-0.155+ (0.088)	-0.055 (0.093)
Urbanization		-0.008*** (0.001)	-0.008*** (0.001)	-0.008*** (0.001)
Number of pre-election protests		0.002 (0.003)	-0.003 (0.004)	-0.003 (0.003)
Phys. integrity index (lag)		1.877*** (0.492)	1.657*** (0.497)	0.932+ (0.550)
Phys. int. lag squared		-2.236*** (0.424)	-1.986*** (0.432)	-1.160* (0.509)
Regional protest diffusion		0.197** (0.064)	0.172** (0.065)	0.125+ (0.067)
Protest risk prop. score	0.709*** (0.104)		0.261** (0.093)	
Prop. score quartile				0.138*** (0.037)
Num.Obs.	1042	1042	1042	1042
R2	0.043	0.504	0.507	0.510
R2 Adj.	0.042	0.497	0.501	0.504
AIC	3128.6	2468.6	2462.6	2456.3
F	46.614	80.199	75.534	76.438
RMSE	1.08	0.78	0.78	0.77

+ $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

out when incumbents control patronage resources and can shield front-line agents from legal consequences — and those same capacities help incumbents defuse mass protest. Resolving this debate has significant implications for our understanding of both election fraud and authoritarian stability.

This chapter tests the core assumptions of these two models by examining the relationship between election fraud and two dimensions of protest: its initiation and its duration. The key insight is that the regime-weakness and regime-strength models may generate identical predictions about whether protest occurs, but diverge in what they predict about how long protest lasts. Drawing on cross-national data from the V-Dem, NELDA, and ECAV datasets — covering 659 elections in electoral authoritarian regimes — I show that protest is most likely when incumbent vote-shares are very low and fraud is extensive, a finding consistent with both models. More importantly, however, incumbents who engage in larger-scale fraud are able to put down protest movements more quickly.

Additional tests, including on a broader dataset that includes electoral democracies, confirm the regime-strength conception of fraud. When confronted with a higher risk of electoral protest, incumbents tend to produce more election fraud rather than less. This correlation holds true across multiple modeling approaches and measures of manipulation.

Taken together, these findings suggest that the threat of protest is unlikely to constrain election manipulation in the way the regime-weakness model predicts. The incumbents who manipulate most aggressively are also the best equipped to defeat the protests that may follow. This points to electoral authoritarianism as a remarkably durable equilibrium — and paints a bleak picture for those who hope that the threat of protest can discipline incumbents or open pathways to democratization. It also suggests that researchers should look beyond mass protest when modeling the forces that shape electoral manipulation. As subsequent chapters show, a promising approach for upholding election integrity involves breaking the links that tie political principals to their front-line agents.

Chapter 4

Agent risk and variation in manipulation tactics in Russia

During the 2011 Russian legislative election campaign, the city manager of Izhevsk, a regional capital, was filmed while speaking to a meeting of local veterans' groups. In the video, city manager Denis Agashin speaks bluntly about the rewards the veterans can expect if they contribute to the ruling party's victory in the polls. 'If the party receives less than fifty percent of the vote in your district,' Agashin declares, 'that means nothing will change....If the party receives between 50 and 54 percent, we will fund [the local veterans' groups] with 500,000 rubles.' Agashin went on to add rewards for even more specific targets up to 1,000,000 rubles for a 60% vote-share.¹

Despite multiple efforts by opposition parties to bring political and criminal penalties against Agashin², he was largely protected from punishment by the local dominance of the ruling party, United Russia's. Others have not been so fortunate. For example, in 2009 a district court in Saratov oblast levied a 200,000 ruble fine against the chair of a precinct election commission for falsifying votes in favor of United Russia; still others have received suspended prison sentences.³ Such punitive outcomes are not uncommon even in a relatively closed case like Russia: after the 2016 legislative election, the Russian Central Election Commission reported 32 criminal cases related to electoral manipulation, in addition to approximately 1,000 administrative cases and 300 fines (Tikhonova 2016).

¹ See <http://www.newsru.com/russia/30oct2011/agashin.html> for a summary of the event, and the video clip.

² These included efforts to remove him from office, and pressure on the regional prosecutor to bring criminal charges. See <http://www.dayudm.ru/article/51302/> (Russian) for details.

³ A website for the Honest Elections Public Council, a Kremlin-approved non-governmental agency, maintained a list of dozens of other incidents of arrests, administrative charges, and criminal proceedings against individuals who have allegedly helped manipulate an election. The organization and website are now defunct, but an archive is available at <https://web.archive.org/web/20170809084414/http://www.chestvibor.ru/chronicles/>.

These anecdotes illustrate the personal risk undertaken by those who actually tamper with elections, an aspect of manipulation that has been largely overlooked by research that emphasizes the costs and risks borne by political leaders (Hyde 2011a; Magaloni 2010; Simpson 2013; Ziblatt 2009). A recent principal-agent model of electoral manipulation addresses this gap, by highlighting risks faced by agents if their patron loses the election. However, this emphasis on the risk of electoral defeat does not account for evidence that shows illegal electoral manipulation tactics are often used as substitutes, with one tactic increasing in severity as another declines (Harvey 2016; Kuo & Teorell 2017; Sjöberg 2013). In particular, some forms of manipulation stubbornly persist even as the risk of patron defeat increases along with growing levels of competition and democratization (Asunka *et al.* 2017; Van Ham & Lindberg 2015).

The model presented here helps reconcile these findings by arguing electoral defeat for their patron is not the only risk that agents face. Instead, local political conditions—like active opposition parties or independent courts—can make participation in electoral manipulation costlier for agents, even if their patron remains in power, by increasing the local risks of exposure and political or criminal penalties for the perpetrator. However, agents can insulate themselves from local risks by engaging in forms of manipulation that are harder to observe and trace, such as vote-buying and voter pressure, which helps explain the persistence of these tactics even as political competitiveness increases. These hypotheses are supported by election-forensic analysis of two types of electoral manipulation, using electoral data from more than 90,000 precincts in each election year, across Russia’s eighty-plus regions during six national elections from 2003-2012.

4.1 Case selection: local and national political conditions in Russia

Russia provides an excellent case with which to test the theory. The country is large and diverse, with wide variation in socioeconomic variables across its 80-plus regions. There is also wide variation in local political opposition, with the ruling party’s margin of victory in the 2011 election ranging from one percentage point in the most competitive regions to 99 points in the least. National patronage consolidation has increased on average during the time period covered here, as regional power centers and oligarchic clans lost influence relative to the Kremlin. This evolution of the national political system, combined with a diversity of local political environments, provides ample opportunity to study agents’ behavior under different conditions. In addition, Russia provides a tough test for the theory. If the principal-agent dynamics proposed here can be detected in Russia, a case where patronage consolidation is relatively high and local constraints are relatively limited in the broader comparative context, principal-agent problems may be even more prevalent in less authoritarian hybrid regimes.

Institutional reforms, organizational investments in the ruling party, strong economic growth, pressure on outside elites, and consistently high approval ratings for Putin himself strengthened the president’s position as the country’s chief patron. In the 2008 presidential election, the Kremlin successfully performed the transfer of the presidency from

Putin to his chosen successor, Medvedev, while Putin took up the role of prime minister. However, as the 2011 Duma and 2012 presidential elections approached, tensions began to appear in the ‘tandem-ocracy’. Commentators began to consider Medvedev and Putin as representatives of ‘liberal’ and ‘conservative’ factions in the elite (Black 2014). Speculation about which of the two would run for the presidency in 2012 continued until September 2011, when Medvedev urged the United Russia party conference to endorse Putin for that office. This announcement, and its apparent disregard for the public’s role in the matter, exacerbated divisions in the elite, exemplified by the resignation of long-serving finance minister Alexei Kudrin (Butrin *et al.* 2011). In this context, United Russia won only forty-nine percent of the vote and lost more than seventy seats in the Duma—a major setback. In addition, the election prompted widespread allegations of manipulation and large protests in many Russian cities (Buranov *et al.* 2011). Since beginning his third term, Putin re-established the single-pyramid structure of patronage in Russia, after a modest fracturing during his years away from the presidency (Hale 2014 pp. 267–291).

4.2 Building the vertical of power

As the time of writing, Vladimir Putin has been Russia’s paramount leader (as either president or prime minister) for over twenty-five years; the politically tumultuous 1990s are a distant memory. However, the period was one of genuine political uncertainty and electoral risk for President Yeltsin and his allies. The multi-decade Putinite project has been, in large part, an effort to blunt those risks. The following provides a brief qualitative sketch of major events in this trajectory, illustrating the process by which the incumbent sought make it easier for other political actors to cooperate with the center, and harder to cooperate with the opposition.

The early period of economic reform in post-Soviet Russia was painful; price liberalization led to skyrocketing inflation, and the decline of the planned economy led to widespread wage arrears. Opposition to the reform agenda crystallized in Russia’s holdover legislature, the Congress of People’s Deputies, and its upper house the Supreme Soviet, where a mix of communist and nationalist lawmakers contended with supporters of Yeltsin’s reforms. The Congress narrowly failed to impeach the president in March 1993. By September, Yeltsin (unconstitutionally) dissolved the legislature, and by October had ordered the military to seize the parliament building from parliamentarians and protesters barricaded there.

Efforts to eliminate the threat of losing power began immediately. Afterward, parliamentary leaders were arrested, and the Ministry of Justice banned sixteen communist or nationalist organizations and eleven newspapers—including *Pravda* (though some of these bans would be lifted before the next election) (Urban 1994). The new, 1993 constitution was developed within the presidential administration, and would enshrine what some would call ‘supreidentialism’ (Holmes 1993). The Central Election Commission decided to disqualify several well-known opposition parties from the December election, and ordered that party labels be excluded from ballots for the single-member district Duma deputies (thus privileging the party of power, Russia’s Choice, which had

a larger share of candidates with high local name recognition) (Urban 1994).

Despite increasing control over the institutional levers of power, difficult social and economic conditions produced competitive elections. In 1993, first place went to the nationalist Liberal Democratic Party of Russia (LDPR), and third place to the Communist Party of the Russian Federation (KPRF), with Russia's Choice in second. The 1995 election was even worse for the Kremlin, with the opposition KPRF winning a plurality of seats: 157, compared to 55 for the party of power. The leader of the KPRF, Gennady Zyuganov, posed a significant challenge to Yeltsin in the 1996 presidential election, winning 32.5 percent of the vote to Yeltsin's 35.8 percent. Yeltsin won the second round, in part due to many Russian voters' fears of returning to the Soviet past (McFaul 1996), but also due to Yeltsin's deals with regional leaders and a class of newly minted oligarchs, exchanging long-term power short-term electoral support. For regional governors, the trade involved granting greater institutional independence to their regions (Paustyan 2021); for the oligarchs, it involved ownership of state enterprises (Treisman 2010). Evidence of significant electoral irregularities has been detected, especially in Russia's ethnic republics (Myagkov *et al.* 2005).

The Yeltsin operation only became more fragile as his health declined and Russia suffered further economic disruptions. A group of some of Russia's most powerful regional elites and political exiles from Yeltsin's administration (e.g. former prime minister Yevgeny Primakov) put their resources behind a challenger party, 'Fatherland-All Russia.' The regional elites' ability to mobilize votes, along with help from supportive oligarchs, made Fatherland-All Russia a genuine threat to those in power (Hale 2004).

The center responded to the immediate threat of Fatherland-All Russia, as well as to the longer-term challenge posed by empowered regional elites and captains of industry. The ailing Yeltsin appointed a (relatively) young Vladimir Putin as prime minister in August 1999. Putin's appointment coincided with the initiation of the Second Chechen War and a series of apartment bombings across Russia. Putin's vigorous response, especially in contrast with the unsteady president, helped raise his public profile and popularity; this, in turn, helped the pro-Kremlin Unity party narrowly defeat Fatherland-All Russia in the 1999 Duma election. On New Year's Eve 1999, Yeltsin resigned; as prime minister, Putin became acting president.

Buoyed by incumbency and his popularity, Vladimir Putin was elected president in 2000. He subsequently embarked on a years-long project of restoring power to the center. Seeing the writing on the wall, Fatherland-All Russia merged with Unity to form the ruling party United Russia. United Russia became one of the regime's primary vehicles for distributing patronage rewards (Remington 2008). Regional governors steadily saw the wisdom in joining the party (Reuter 2010), accelerating a process by which the patronage resources of the regions were linked to the interests of the center (Konitzer & Wegren 2006). The administration utilized the law enforcement powers of the state to chasten opposition-oriented oligarchs and gain control of major television networks and major industrial enterprises (Sakwa 2008). Mikhail Khodorkovsky—once Russia's richest man, and most visible 'opposition' oriented oligarch—was arrested in 2003; following his conviction for fraud and tax evasion he was jailed until 2013. The oil company he controlled, YUKOS, was dismantled and much of its assets absorbed by

state-owned companies.

Ambitious efforts in the 1990s sought to reform the Soviet-era judiciary to be more autonomous. Judges gained life tenure, and the judiciary itself a prominent role in recruiting and disciplining judges. As discussed in more detail in Chapter 6, much of these efforts were rolled back over the course of Vladimir Putin's time in office. While judges retain life tenure, at least *de jure*, the institution as a whole has become increasingly subordinated to the presidential administration over time. As a result, the Russian judicial operates in two modes: an ordinary mode where procedures are followed impartially (though with substantial prosecutorial bias), and a politicized mode when significant interests are at stake (Hendley & Jr 2023).

The Russian experience fits the background expectation of the theory: the incumbents facing serious threats to their power should invest heavily in the tools of social control. In this case, those tools required the subordination of regional and oligarchic patronage resources to the center, and the expansion of executive influence over the courts.

4.3 Hypotheses

The theory outlined in Chapter 2 produces several hypotheses that can be tested in the Russian case. First, it is expected that the incumbent regime in Russia will take steps over time to reduce principal-agent problems in the face of a genuine opposition, as we have seen above.

Changing conditions, in turn, will influence the types of illegal electoral manipulation that we observe across the country and over time, as agents respond to risk. In particular, I expect that less attributable, more dispersed forms of electoral manipulation will be more common in regions where there is a higher risk that centralized fraud will be exposed. Since exposure carries significant risk of being caught up in the legal system, where the risk of exposure is higher, agents will become less willing to engage in attributable tactics. However, given that the incumbent controls significant patronage resources, dispersed manipulation will be used to make up for the shortfall. Specifically, I expect:

H1: Falsification will be less common as regional political competitiveness increases.

H2: Dispersed manipulation (e.g. vote-buying, voter pressure, and multiple voting) will increase as regional political competitiveness increases.

4.4 Data and measures

In order to test the theory, it is necessary to estimate two types of electoral manipulation: easier-to-monitor administrative falsification and harder-to-monitor vote-buying / voter pressure. To do so, I employ two separate election forensic techniques. I use these methods to estimate the level of both types of electoral manipulation in each of Russia's regions, per election-year. These models draw on electoral data at the precinct level

(more than 90,000 precincts in each election), while second-stage models incorporate control variables at the regional (80+ regions) and election-year levels (10). In both sets of models, I include socioeconomic control variables to incorporate local context (Myagkov *et al.* 2009) and reduce the risk of false positives (Deckert 2013).

In the original turnout-based measure of electoral manipulation developed by Myagkov *et al.* (2009), turnout by precinct in a territory is compared to a party's *absolute vote-share* across the same precincts. Precinct-level absolute vote-share is defined as the number of votes a party receives divided by the total number of eligible voters in the precinct. Increasingly large correlations between these two variables indicate increasingly suspicious results, as they show that—as turnout increases in a region—the party in question is drawing more and more voters to its side from the pool of available voters. Figure 4.1 provides an illustration of the method.

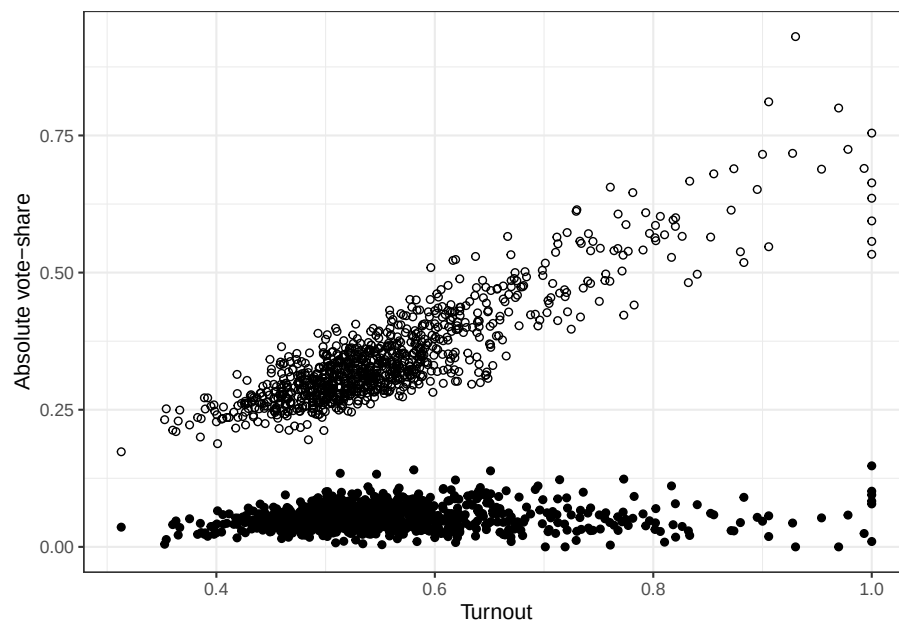


Figure 4.1: Overall turnout and absolute vote-share for United Russia (hollow circles) and the KPRF (solid circles) in Leningradskaya Oblast', 2007

As the figure shows, there is a markedly different relationship between turnout and absolute vote-share for the ruling party United Russia, and the largest opposition party, the KPRF. For United Russia, higher precinct-level turnout is associated with a consistent increase in its share of the overall electorate. It is important to be clear on what absolute vote-share means. Consider the precincts in Figure 4.1 in which turnout approached ninety percent; in these precincts, United Russia claimed the votes of approximately seventy percent of *all eligible voters*. In relative terms, this is an even more astonishing feat. Imagine, for arithmetic ease, that such a precinct has 1,000 voters on the rolls. To win 75% of these votes with 90% turnout, United Russia would need to claim 750 out

of 900 voters: an eighty-three percent relative share.

These notional results look much different in the median precinct by turnout (where roughly 54% of eligible voters turned out). In such precincts, United Russia claimed roughly 34% of the eligible voting population. Using our hypothetical list of 1,000 eligible voters, these figures work out to 340 votes for United Russia out of 540 voters; a sixty-three percent relative vote-share. Meanwhile, absolute vote-shares for the primary opposition party have no relationship at all to turnout. Whether forty percent or ninety percent of voters are recorded as casting votes, the Communists claim roughly five percent of the voting population.

A pattern like this can be explained in two ways. First, there could be innocuous explanations. Perhaps turnout and support for the ruling is confounded by a third factor, such as income, education, urban location, or ethnicity. Perhaps, as a notional example, voters are likely to cluster in districts by education, with more educated voters both more likely to turn out *and* more likely to support United Russia. In that view, the suspicious pattern in Figure 4.1 could be easily explained away: the more educated on average a precinct's voters are, the more likely they are to turn out in droves (and cast their ballots for the ruling party).

The alternative explanation is electoral malfeasance. In that story, a variety of techniques are available for directly inflating the number of votes for the ruling party: e.g., fraud, coerced voting, ballot-stuffing, vote-buying, and multiple voting. Precincts vary in how susceptible they are to such techniques, for many reasons: socioeconomic characteristics, the presence or absence of observers, the skill and dedication of regime agents, and so on. The more susceptible a precinct is to such tampering, the more these techniques can be used to inflate both turnout and the ruling party's *share* of that turnout. While the approach is somewhat different, a similar logic is also used in the widely-cited method for identifying the country-level 'fingerprints' of election manipulation (Klimek *et al.* 2012; Kobak *et al.* 2016).

Distinguishing between these two stories is crucial to successful election forensics (Deckert 2013). To minimize the risk of false positives—of using forensics analysis to falsely claim fraud (Eggers *et al.* 2021b)—two precautions should be taken. First, where possible, quantitative analysis should control for possible confounding variables (e.g. socioeconomic factors). Second, and more fundamentally, election forensic tools should be used in coordination with qualitative assessments of overall election integrity by experts and observers. Both approaches are taken in the subsequent analysis. The fragility of election integrity in Russia is well-documented by the domestic monitoring organization Golos, by external observers (e.g. the OSCE), and by international and local experts. I have also included region-level control variables to reduce the risk that cross-regional patterns are confounded by varying levels of income, population size, urbanity, and more across regions.

The measure developed by Myagkov *et al* (2009) captures all forms of direct election manipulation. It does not matter for the tool whether officials stuff pre-filled ballots into the ballot boxes, brokers pay voters to show up and vote multiple times, factory workers are pressured to cast their ballots a certain way, or votes are added to the final tally at

the stroke of a pen; any systematic inflation of a party's vote-share may show up in the relationship between turnout and absolute vote-share. This makes it a useful gauge of overall manipulation; it cannot, however, serve as a dependent variable in the present analysis. For the present purpose, election forensic tools must be able to discriminate between centralized techniques like falsification, and more dispersed techniques like voter pressure and ballot stuffing.

With regard to these less centralized techniques, I use a modified version of the turnout-based measure proposed by Myagkov et al (2009) by comparing the share of votes cast by absentee ballot and mobile ballot-box to the ruling party's absolute vote-share across precincts using a first-stage multilevel model (Harvey 2016; Moser & White 2017). Absentee ballots have consistently been used in Russia to facilitate vote-buying, workplace mobilization, and multiple voting (Frye *et al.* 2014; Golos 2011; White 2011), until they were phased out in 2018. Russian electoral law provides for the use of a mobile ballot box, which is—in theory—brought by election officials to voters who are homebound, hospitalized, or otherwise unable to physically visit the polling place on election day. In practice, however, the mobile ballot box also creates easy opportunities for ballot-stuffing by officials. In particular, by removing electoral officials and the ballot box from the polling place, it limits observers' ability to monitor officials' behavior.

Election reporting by the civil society group Golos provides examples of how this process can work. In one instance in the 2011 election, the Golos report notes "The chair of the [precinct electoral] commission did not announce the beginning of the mobile voting, or show the register [of mobile voters]." This violation of procedure allows election officials to stuff the mobile ballot box with whatever number of votes for the ruling party is needed. As the report continues, "Afterward, 296 people were on the list, which is too many for voting at home. All 296 people were visited in 1.5 hours" (Golos 2012). The authorities have continued to rely on such methods in subsequent elections. By 2021 (when absentee voting was no longer permissible), Golos recorded 715 procedural violations related to the mobile ballot box; this was the second-largest category of violations, accounting for 16 percent of all observed violations ("«Karta narušenij»" 2021).

To construct an election-forensic measure of voter pressure, ballot-stuffing, and similar techniques, I replace overall turnout in the Myagkov et al model with 'nonstandard' turnout. Nonstandard, here, is shorthand for ballots cast by absentee and the mobile ballot box. The measure is generated for each of Russia's regions by comparing a party's absolute vote-share to turnout by absentee and mobile ballot box. An increasingly large correlation between nonstandard turnout and a party's absolute vote-share indicates the party is drawing increasingly large proportions of the nonstandard vote. The steps taken to construct the measure are as follows.

Precinct-level election data was obtained from the Russian Central Election Commission for national election-years 2001, 2003, 2004, 2007, 2008, 2011, 2012, 2016, 2018, and 2021. The constitutional referendum held in 2020, which (among other things) enabled President Putin to prolong his tenure in office, is not included.⁴ For each election

⁴The national referendum, the first since 1993, was excluded because of its distinctiveness as a case. While

year, a multilevel regression analysis was performed on the precinct-level data, using a party's absolute vote-share as the dependent variable and nonstandard turnout as the independent variable. The multilevel models incorporate random slopes and intercepts by region. The random intercepts allow for the party's baseline absolute vote-share in the absence of any non-standard votes to vary across regions. The random slopes allow the relationship between non-standard turnout and absolute vote-share to vary by region, producing the regression coefficients that are used as measures of decentralized election manipulation in the second stage.

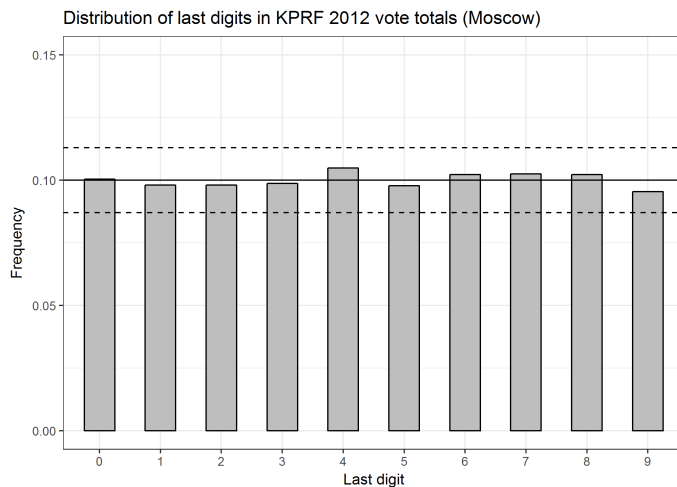


Figure 4.2: Last digits of precinct vote totals for KPRF, Moscow City 2012

The second measure of electoral manipulation must capture falsification of results only. The digits-based test proposed by Beber and Scacco (2012) has been useful for estimating falsification of results by election officials (Cantú 2014; Harvey 2016; Sjöberg 2013; Weidmann & Callen 2013). Their method rests on the assumption that the ones-digit for a party's vote totals across precincts in a territory should be uniformly distributed in a clean election. That is, in the absence of human intervention, a roughly equal number of precincts should report vote totals ending in 0, 1, 2, 3, and so on. Put another way, whether the number of people who turn up to vote for a particular party at a given polling place is 100, 101, 102, etc., is a highly random process, influenced by (among other things) the weather, individuals' moods and obligations, conditions on the evening commute, and so on. Figure 4.2 illustrates this tendency using precinct-level votes for the KPRF candidate in Moscow city in the 2012 election.

it was a political campaign, it did not involve opposing parties or candidates on the ballot. While the primary function of the constitutional reform was to 'reset' President Putin's term count to zero (allowing him to bypass constitutional term limits) the reform package was salted with 205 additional changes to the constitution to appeal to various constituencies (Teague 2020), a prospect which complicates election-forensic interpretations of the vote. Finally, the vote itself took place during the early months of the Covid-19 pandemic, which introduced all manner of procedural changes and ad hoc administrative decisions to the administration of the vote (Hutcheson & McAllister 2021).

However, as Beber and Scacco demonstrate, human beings are poor random number generators; when asked to produce ‘random’ numbers they tend to overestimate some integers (especially zeroes and fives), and underestimate others. As a result, when precinct-level election officials are tasked with inflating a party’s vote total at their precinct, they tend to over-produce certain digits. This process, when aggregated hundreds or thousands of times, can result in non-uniform distributions across the territory—a signal of human electoral falsification. Figure 4.3 illustrates a non-uniform distribution of digits, with significant over-representation of zeroes, for the KPRF candidate in Dagestan in the 2012 election. This type of election forensic measure captures falsification only; election results may be highly influenced by vote-buying, voter pressure, or ballot-stuffing and still generate randomly distributed last digits (Harvey 2016).

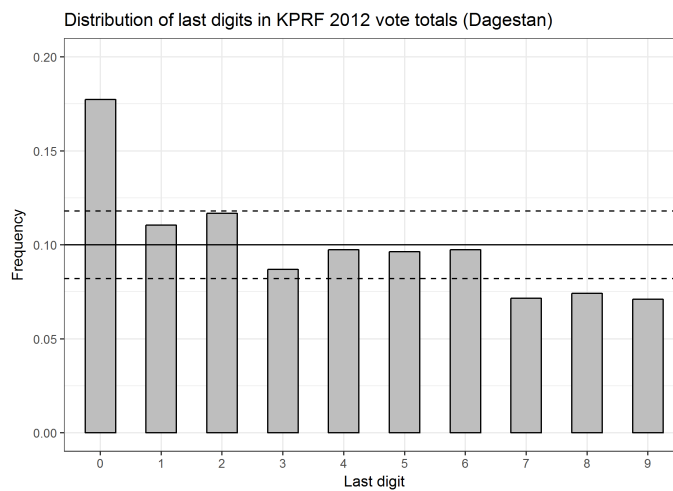


Figure 4.3: Last digits of precinct vote totals for KPRF, Dagestan 2012

I estimate centralized manipulation by formal agents (i.e. falsification of results) using three approaches. First, I follow the classic technique from Beber and Scacco, using chi-square tests for the uniform distribution of trailing digits for the ruling party and the second-place finisher in each region per election-year. I test for deviations from the uniform that are statistically significant at the .05 level for both parties; the binary variable *any fraud* is marked as 1 if either party’s results are significantly non-uniform, and 0 otherwise. This variable is used as the dependent variable in a second-stage logit model. This approach measures falsification of results only; it does not measure behaviors like stuffing the ballot box with pre-filled ballots (Sjoberg 2016).

Further research has produced more refined estimates of falsification. While relying on the same logic as Beber and Scacco (2012), Lankina and Skovoroda (Lankina & Skovoroda 2017) propose using the deviance between the expected value for a trailing digit (10%) and its observed value, controlling for the number of precincts in a territory. I follow their measure of deviance for last-digit zero; a larger deviance indicates

increasing under- or over-production of zero as a last digit, a possible signal of human tampering with results. Using the deviance measure rather than a binary indicator of significant difference from the uniform allows for a more precise test. Unlike the binary measure, which would classify a chi-squared test with a p-value of 0.049 as fraudulent but one with a p-value of 0.051 as clean, the deviance measure allows for a more continuous measure of ‘fraudulent-ness.’ However, the original chi-square approach has the advantage of detecting deviations in digits other than zero.

Finally, I also employ the ‘resampled kernel density’ method developed by Arturas Rozenas (Rozenas 2017). The intuition behind this approach is that elections which feature human falsification may produce vote-share or turnout distributions with ‘spikes’—a high number of precincts reporting certain values. These values might be numbers divisible by five due to their appeal to human beings working in a hurry (i.e. 60 percent vote-share, or 65 percent). Or they might be due to specific targets laid out by political leaders (e.g. 67 percent). However, a certain degree of ‘spikiness’ is to be expected for simple arithmetic reasons. To account for this, Rozenas develops an approach that estimates the percentage of precincts in ‘spikes’ that go beyond what would be expected.

This approach takes the observed precinct-level results from a territory and calculates the smooth distributions of a party’s vote-share and overall turnout (i.e. the distribution without any spikes or valleys). It then draws a number of samples from this distribution (i.e. a number of hypothetical elections) and computes new vote-share and turnout distributions from these samples. Finally it compares the actual distribution (with its spikes and valleys) to the sampled distributions. Where the density of precincts at a given point in the distribution (e.g. sixty percent vote-share, or seventy-five percent turnout) exceed the maximum density from the sampled distributions, those precincts are marked as potentially fraudulent. I utilized Rozenas’s *spikes* package in R to estimate the percentage of fraudulent precincts in each of Russia’s regions across all of the elections in the dataset.⁵ I utilize this percentage value as a dependent variable.

All three of these variables should only be sensitive to falsification. Ballot-stuffing, vote-buying, voter pressure, and other forms of electoral manipulation cannot reliably produce the deviations from expected distributions that these methods identify since they still produce random vote-shares. In the analysis below, I model the binary *any fraud* variable using logistic regression. The deviance and ‘spikes’ dependent variables are modeled using OLS.

there is likely to be a core of precincts that reflect more-or-less the true level of turnout and support for United Russia in the region. Votes in these precincts are subject to less—and less direct—forms of manipulation. Like all voters in the system, they experience the effects of media bias, incumbent resource advantages, and selective access to the

⁵The package will fail to produce an estimate if the total number of votes exceeds the number of registered voters in any precinct (i.e. when turnout is greater than 100%). Since such precincts are suspicious at face value, I handle regions with any such precinct differently. In order to successfully compute the estimate from *spikes*, I first exclude any precincts with greater than 100% turnout, and then run the models. Once an estimate has been returned, I add the excluded precincts back in and compute an ‘adjusted’ percentage of suspicious precincts. In other words, this adjusted estimate equals the percentage of fraudulent precincts identified using Rozenas’s method, plus the percentage of precincts where turnout exceeds 100 percent.

ballot. However, they are less subject to artificial inflation of the ruling party's vote-share through . The more the voters in a precinct are subject to the latter forms of electoral malfeasance—due to a lack of election monitors, socioeconomic conditions, or other factors—

a larger positive correlation between the share of absentee ballots and United Russia's absolute vote-share is more indicative of these kinds of manipulation (especially after controlling for demographic factors that might affect honest use of absentee ballots). The regression coefficient linking absentee voting and ruling-party vote-share is used as the dependent variable in a second-stage feasible generalised least squares (FGLS) regression to account for the fact that the dependent variable is itself a regression estimate (Lewis & Linzer 2005).

4.4.1 Explanatory variables: local political constraint

Across all models, I operationalize local constraints in three ways in the Russian context. First, I measure *regional political opposition* by taking the United Russia's vote-share in the most recent regional legislative election and subtract it from 1. However, regional legislative election results are not available prior to the 2004 national election. In order to include data from earlier periods, I rely on the margin of victory in gubernatorial elections.⁶ Since there can be a mechanical difference between the two types of elections that may the value of the variable, with more parties possibly competing in the legislative election than the executive one, I first center and scale each variable according to its variance before combining them.

This variable thus increases as United Russia's vote-share in a region decreases. A higher value for this variable indicates greater opposition contestation, reduced popularity of the incumbent, and greater opposition influence in the legislature. While these factors should directly translate into constraints on the ruling party, the measure also raises concerns about endogeneity. United Russia's vote-share in regional elections is, after all, in part attributable to electoral manipulation that it may also deploy during federal elections. I address this concern in two ways. First, as a theoretical matter, I expect that increased competitiveness will affect different types of manipulation differently, rather than being associated with generally cleaner elections. In other words, I do not argue that better showings for opposition parties will be associated with reduced manipulation—an argument that would indeed be vulnerable to accusations of reverse causation. Instead, I argue that competitiveness shifts the form that manipulation takes.

As an empirical matter, I also supplement this measure with two non-electoral measures of political competitiveness in Russia; both are based on ethnicity. Russia's administrative structure—its federal oblasts, okrugs, krais, and republics—is largely inherited from that of Soviet Russia (the Russian Soviet Federated Socialist Republic, which formed the largest constituent of the USSR). In an effort to balance their Marxist distrust of national identity with the ethnic realities they had themselves inherited from the Russian Empire, early Soviet governments built politicized ethnicity into the structure of the

⁶Similarly, the results of gubernatorial elections cannot be used for all elections, since Russia abolished gubernatorial elections between 2005 and 2012.

Union (Hajda & Beissinger 2019; Smith 2013). The need to administer a multi-ethnic, multi-lingual (and multiconfessional) state led the Soviet Union to be founded along national-identity dimensions—its constituent republics were drawn up along national lines (a titular republic for Kazakhs, for Uzbeks, for Ukrainians, etc.). The RSFSR, the largest republic, was itself subdivided into national enclaves where non-Russian ethnicities predominated. Ethnic groups that were thus recognized received privileged positions in the Soviet political structure, not least of which were organs of government for the titular territory of the national group (e.g. both a regional government for, and a communist party of, the Kazakh SSR) and party cadres recruited based on nationality (Martin 2001; Slezkine 1994). The Soviet Union ultimately imploded along national lines, as regional leaders took advantage of the institutional structure of the Union—its internal borders, its regional legislative bodies, its regional party structures—and nationalist movements fostered by politicized ethnicity (Beissinger 2009; Suny 1993). A similarly centrifugal process took place within Russia itself, as its ethnically-defined regions likewise pushed for additional sovereignty (Kahn 2000).

Subordinating these regions, with their powerful governors and extensive political machines, was a major objective of the early Putin government (Golosov & Konstantinova 2016; Reuter 2010). As a result, those political machines assets were put to use generating electoral support for United Russia; Russia's titular ethnic republics tend to be the least politically competitive regions in the country (Hale 2007; White & Saikkonen 2017). Ethnic minority enclaves tend to be politically unified around United Russia, due to the coherence of their political machines, while regions with larger populations of ethnic Russians tend to allow more space for competition. I operationalize this in two ways. First, the proportion of ethnic Russians in a region is taken from the Russian Census, with interpolation between census years. Second, I categorize regions as majority-minority titular ethnic regions, non-majority titular ethnic regions, and ordinary regions (i.e. oblasts). A region is coded as majority-minority if it is both a titular ethnic homeland and ethnic Russians make up a minority of the population (e.g. Tatarstan, Chechnya). A region is coded as a non-minority titular ethnic region if it is formally an ethnic homeland, but ethnic Russians make up a majority of the population (e.g. Karelia). All other regions are coded as oblasts, or ordinary regions.

4.4.2 Control variables

Several control variables that may influence both electoral manipulation and regional competitiveness are included in the models. In addition, some control variables must be included in order to account for potentially non-manipulative explanations for suspicious patterns in the electoral data. All socioeconomic controls are taken from the Russian Federal State Statistical Service.

Since large populations may be more difficult to control and require more resources to manipulate, I include a measure of the *population size* in each region; this variable is replaced with *number of precincts* in the models of deviance. Since many retirees are directly dependent on the state for their livelihoods (and thus may be easier to pressure), but may also simply be more disposed to vote for or against the incumbent as a demographic group (Colton & McFaul 2003; Hemment 2009), I include the number of

pensioners per 1,000 residents in a region. Poor individuals are likely more susceptible to vote-buying efforts and other forms of clientelism (Kitschelt & Wilkinson 2007; Stokes *et al.* 2013b), and, like pensioners, may support or oppose the government as a demographic. To address this possibility, I include a measure of the percentage of the population falling below the official poverty line, as well as each region's gross regional product per capita. Researchers have often found that rural populations are more vulnerable to electoral manipulation (Simpser 2012), and cities have typically been sites of greater opposition to United Russia. I thus include the percentage of a region's population living in cities as a control.

Several variables are measured at the election-year level. First, I include a dummy variable to control for *presidential elections*, which may produce higher levels of manipulation due to their high stakes for incumbents (Simpser 2013). As I have argued in prior work, the degree to which an incumbent has consolidated control over patronage resources is a key component of their ability to manipulate elections (Harvey 2016, 2019). I control for the degree to which the so-called 'power vertical' has been constructed in Russia using two measures. The first measure is the nationwide share of regional governors who belong to the United Russia party, and indicator of the degree to which the Kremlin was able to consolidate control over the regional political machines Reuter (2013).⁷ The persistence of United Russia as a party of power, where previous partisan experiments by President Yeltsin and his circle failed, is largely tied to its success as a vehicle for channeling patronage resources from patrons to clients Turovskii (2010). Lastly, I use the V-Dem measure of *subnational party control* (v2pssunpar), which measures the degree to which "a single party control[s] important policymaking bodies across subnational units (regional and local governments)." Higher values on this variable indicate greater subnational competitiveness.

4.5 Results

The results for the three distinct measures of falsification are presented in separate tables. Table 4.1 reports the logit models of the *any fraud* variable, based on the Beber and Scacco digits test. Table 4.2 reports the results for OLS regression models of the last-digit-zero deviance indicator, and Table 4.3 shows results from OLS models of the resampled kernel density (RKD) indicator. All nine models tell a consistent story: for all three operationalizations of falsification, and all three measures of political openness, increased openness is associated with reduced falsification. Models 1 through 3 show this effect holds for a binary measure of falsification, which is positive if the distribution of ones-digits across precincts falls outside the uniform for any digit. They show that ordinary regions, on average, are significantly less likely than titular ethnic regions to experience falsification of this kind. The effect extends to measures of ethnicity generally, where an increasing proportion of ethnic Russians (and thus, typically, weaker political machines) yields reduced fraud. Finally, Model 3 shows that, as opposition parties perform better in the regional legislature, falsification in federal elections

⁷I collected these data myself using Russian-language Wikipedia, following linked external sources for confirmation.

declines.

Models 4 and 7 show the relationship between the ethnic status of a region and the level of falsification is consistent across the deviance and RKD indicators. The baseline category for *ethnic status* in Models 1, 4, and 7 is the least competitive type of region: a majority-minority ethnic republic. The models show that Russia's ordinary regions, along with ethnic republics that lack a majority-minority population, are associated with less fraud as measured by both the deviance and RKD indicators. Similarly, Models 5 and 8 show that fraud decreases in the ethnic Russian share of the population. Lastly, the most direct indicator—regional competitiveness—is also negatively associated with both measures of falsification in Models 3 and 6.

The effect sizes are substantively significant. The change in the level of last-digit-zero deviance between a majority-minority ethnic region and an ordinary oblast is -2.36; this represents a bigger shift than that between the first (0.13) and third (1.89) quartiles of the deviance variable. The shift is even larger when falsification is measured as the percentage of possibly fraudulent precincts using the RKD estimator. For that variable, the distance between the first and third quartiles is roughly 0.8, about a third the size of the effect for oblast' status. Effect sizes are substantially larger for the *percent ethnic Russian* variable, which also ranges from zero to one. The effect of *regional competitiveness* is smaller, but still statistically and substantively significant. A shift from the first to the third quartile in competitiveness is associated with a reduction in last-digit-zero deviance of 0.48. This is roughly the difference between the deviance value for the city of Moscow in 2004 and the Karachay-Cherkess Republic⁸ in the same year.

Regional competitiveness shows a larger effect on the 'spikes' measure of falsification. An increase from the first to the third quartile in competitiveness reduces the estimated share of fraudulent precincts by -1.14 points, or about one-third of a standard deviation of the dependent variable. All together, the results are compelling: increasing political openness is associated with substantively significant reductions in falsification operationalized in two distinct ways, across three operationalizations of political openness, and when including a suite of control variables.

Table 4.4 reports models of manipulation via non-standard voting (that is, of the relationship between United Russia's vote-share and ballots cast by absentee or mobile ballot box). The table shows that the results are similarly consistent, but with opposite-signed effects for the explanatory variables. Where regions that lack a titular ethnic majority demonstrate less evidence of falsification in Models 1 and 4, the same regions show an increase in non-standard voting in Model 7. The same result appears for ethnic Russian population share in Model 8, and regional competitiveness in Model 9. Effect sizes for the explanatory variables remain substantively important. The average oblast', for instance, reports a nonstandard voting coefficient that is 0.206 larger than the average majority-minority republic. This is a shift larger than the difference between the median non-standard coefficient (0.45) and the third quartile (0.62), and represents about two-thirds of a standard deviation (0.32). The effect size for Russian ethnicity is somewhat larger, just as it is for falsification. Lastly, the effect size

⁸A majority-minority ethnic republic in the Caucasus region.

Table 4.1: Table 1: Logit models of election falsification (digits test)

	Model 1	Model 2	Model 3
(Intercept)	-2.800* (1.245)	-2.449* (1.232)	-2.122 (1.560)
Non-minority ethnic region	-0.434 (0.340)		
Oblast'	-1.024*** (0.262)		
Ethnic Russian percent		-1.802*** (0.435)	
Regional competitiveness			-0.015** (0.006)
Subnational party control	1.888 (1.426)	1.953 (1.422)	1.656 (2.028)
Presidential election	-0.091 (0.199)	-0.091 (0.199)	-0.079 (0.238)
Pensioners per 1000 pop.	0.0004 (0.0005)	0.0002 (0.0005)	0.0005 (0.0006)
GRP per capita	-0.000 09 (0.0002)	-0.0002 (0.0002)	-0.000 05 (0.0002)
Poverty rate	-0.011 (0.013)	-0.011 (0.013)	0.015 (0.018)
Urban share of pop.	0.017+ (0.009)	0.020* (0.010)	0.006 (0.010)
UR governors share	1.271 (0.960)	1.247 (0.960)	1.229 (1.172)
N. precincts	-0.0005 (0.0003)	-0.0003 (0.0003)	-0.0005 (0.0003)
Num.Obs.	812	812	597
F	2.273	2.719	1.531

+ $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table 4.2: Table 2: OLS models of election falsification (deviance measure)

	Model 4	Model 5	Model 6
(Intercept)	5.293** (1.973)	5.708** (1.926)	6.593*** (1.824)
Non-minority ethnic region	−2.552*** (0.608)		
Oblast'	−2.359*** (0.458)		
Ethnic Russian percent		−5.398*** (0.721)	
Regional competitiveness			−0.017* (0.007)
Subnational party control	−0.928 (2.216)	−0.586 (2.182)	−0.988 (2.334)
Presidential election	−0.413 (0.318)	−0.412 (0.313)	−0.345 (0.288)
Pensioners per 1000 pop.	−0.002* (0.0009)	−0.003** (0.0008)	−0.001* (0.0007)
GRP per capita	0.0002 (0.0002)	−0.000 03 (0.0002)	−0.000 04 (0.0002)
Poverty rate	0.010 (0.021)	0.005 (0.021)	−0.049* (0.023)
Urban share of pop.	−0.027+ (0.015)	−0.004 (0.015)	−0.040** (0.013)
UR governors share	−0.723 (1.494)	−0.897 (1.470)	−0.572 (1.339)
N. precincts	0.002*** (0.0005)	0.002*** (0.0004)	0.001* (0.0004)
Num.Obs.	812	812	597
R2	0.083	0.111	0.064
R2 Adj.	0.072	0.101	0.050

+ $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table 4.3: Table 3: OLS models of election falsification (RKD estimator)

	Model 7	Model 8	Model 9
(Intercept)	4.967*** (1.179)	5.661*** (1.156)	7.333*** (1.788)
Non-minority ethnic region	-2.822*** (0.368)		
Oblast'	-2.435*** (0.287)		
Ethnic Russian percent		-5.234*** (0.472)	
Regional competitiveness			-0.040*** (0.007)
Subnational party control	0.357 (1.375)	0.670 (1.349)	-1.570 (2.384)
Presidential election	-0.066 (0.195)	-0.042 (0.192)	0.024 (0.287)
Pensioners per 1000 pop.	-0.004** (0.001)	-0.0002 (0.002)	-0.006** (0.002)
GRP per capita	0.0001 (0.0002)	-0.0001 (0.0002)	0.0001 (0.0002)
Poverty rate	-0.016 (0.013)	-0.022+ (0.013)	0.013 (0.022)
Urban share of pop.	-0.033*** (0.009)	-0.015+ (0.009)	-0.047*** (0.012)
UR governors share	1.127 (0.924)	0.676 (0.908)	0.148 (1.348)
Population size	0.001** (0.0004)	0.0001 (0.0004)	0.002** (0.0005)
Num.Obs.	799	799	584
R2	0.191	0.221	0.152
R2 Adj.	0.181	0.212	0.139

+ $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

for *regional competitiveness* is smallest. Moving from the first to the third quartile in competitiveness is associated with an increase in non-standard manipulation of only 0.09—about one-third of a standard deviation.

As a final check, Table 4.5 shows results of models of each dependent variable, which include fixed effects by election year. This controls for any nationwide factors that are invariant for that particular election: for instance, the handoff from Putin to Medvedev in 2008, or the reverse in 2012. The reference category for the regression models is the year 2011, due to its substantive importance as the election that sparked Russia's largest electoral protest movement. Taking this approach requires dropping other variables that are constant by election year: *presidential election*, *UR governors share*, and *subnational party control*. For the sake of brevity, I report results only for the *ethnic status* explanatory variable, excluding *ethnic Russian population share* and *regional competitiveness*.

While ethnic status, as a categorical variable, is something of a blunt instrument, it has the dual advantages of avoiding endogeneity concerns while still being well-grounded as an indicator of political openness in the Russian context. The results remain substantively unchanged, when compared to the previous models. One interesting observation from the fixed effect models is that there is no significant effect for any election-year for measures of falsification, but there is for nonstandard voting bias. Early years of the Putin era show significantly less evidence of voter pressure and ballot-stuffing than the reference election year (2011), and later years show significantly more. This is in line with prior work suggesting that falsification requires a less-developed patronage machine than more dispersed forms of manipulation require (Harvey & Mukherjee 2020).

4.6 Discussion and conclusion

In this chapter, I use data from over 800,000 precinct-level election returns in Russia, across ten election-years, to estimate four election-forensic indicators of electoral manipulation. Three of these indicators estimate falsification of election results by human hands (Beber & Scacco 2012; Lankina & Skovoroda 2017; Rozenas 2017). The fourth indicator, an innovation on my part of a classic forensic technique (Myagkov *et al.* 2009), uncovers bias toward the ruling party in 'nonstandard' voting by absentee or mobile ballot box. Since these methods of voting have regularly been used in Russia to facilitate ballot-stuffing and voter pressure, I take this as an indicator of more dispersed manipulation with less obvious perpetrators.

Having generated these indicators of manipulation for each of Russia's regions, I then test how they respond to three different indicators of political openness in Russia: majority-minority republic status, ethnic Russian share of the population, and regional legislative vote-share of the ruling party United Russia. Regardless of which indicators are used, the regression models all tell the same story: increasing competitiveness is associated with reduced falsification, but increased voter pressure and/or ballot-stuffing.

Table 4.4: Table 4: OLS models of vote-buying and ballot-stuffing

	Model 10	Model 11	Model 12
(Intercept)	0.394*** (0.118)	0.325** (0.122)	0.096 (0.159)
Non-minority ethnic region	0.202*** (0.038)		
Oblast'	0.206*** (0.030)		
Ethnic Russian percent		0.317*** (0.050)	
Regional competitiveness			0.003*** (0.0006)
Subnational party control	-0.607*** (0.138)	-0.610*** (0.141)	-0.187 (0.211)
Presidential election	-0.021 (0.020)	-0.021 (0.020)	-0.052* (0.026)
Pensioners per 1000 pop.	0.0005*** (0.0001)	0.0005** (0.0002)	0.0008*** (0.0002)
GRP per capita	-0.000 04** (0.000 01)	-0.000 04* (0.000 02)	-0.000 04* (0.000 02)
Poverty rate	0.002+ (0.001)	0.003* (0.001)	0.0002 (0.002)
Urban share of pop.	0.000 07 (0.0009)	-0.000 06 (0.001)	0.001 (0.001)
UR governors share	0.047 (0.093)	0.075 (0.096)	0.193 (0.120)
Population size	-0.0001*** (0.000 03)	-0.0001** (0.000 04)	-0.0002*** (0.000 04)
Num.Obs.	844	812	635
R2	0.210	0.213	0.137
R2 Adj.	0.200	0.204	0.125
F	22.104	24.061	

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Table 4.5: Table 5: Regression models of electoral manipulation with year fixed effects

	Any fraud	Deviance	RKD	Nonstandard
	Model 13	Model 14	Model 15	Model 16
(Intercept)	−1.947* (0.766)	4.494*** (1.344)	6.004*** (0.782)	0.181* (0.078)
Non-minority ethnic region	−0.409 (0.341)	−2.555*** (0.609)	−2.832*** (0.369)	0.205*** (0.038)
Oblast'	−1.059*** (0.263)	−2.374*** (0.459)	−2.464*** (0.288)	0.212*** (0.030)
Pensioners per 1000 pop.	0.0004 (0.001)	−0.002* (0.0009)	−0.004* (0.002)	0.0005*** (0.0001)
GRP per capita	−0.0001 (0.0002)	0.0003 (0.0003)	0.0002 (0.0002)	−0.0004** (0.0002)
Poverty rate	−0.010 (0.015)	0.007 (0.024)	−0.022 (0.015)	0.004** (0.001)
Urban share of pop.	0.024* (0.009)	−0.028+ (0.016)	−0.034*** (0.009)	0.0004 (0.0009)
Population size	−0.0002 (0.0004)		0.001** (0.0004)	−0.0001*** (0.0003)
N. precincts		0.002*** (0.0005)		
2000	0.108 (0.552)	−0.068 (0.928)	−0.125 (0.565)	−0.389*** (0.057)
2003	0.107 (0.446)	0.985 (0.758)	−0.422 (0.464)	−0.175*** (0.047)
2004	−0.203 (0.445)	−0.125 (0.725)	−0.247 (0.445)	−0.108* (0.045)
2007	−0.257 (0.414)	−0.296 (0.677)	−0.101 (0.415)	0.026 (0.042)
2008	−0.266 (0.412)	−0.0008 (0.674)	0.451 (0.414)	−0.049 (0.041)
2012	−0.036 (0.389)	−0.301 (0.666)	−0.254 (0.412)	0.032 (0.041)
2016	0.105 (0.383)	0.532 (0.662)	0.562 (0.412)	0.127** (0.041)
2018	0.230 (0.382)	−0.573 (0.665)	0.0002 (0.417)	0.056 (0.041)
2021	−0.268 (0.421)	0.021 (0.682)	−0.101 (0.432)	0.103* (0.042)
Num.Obs.	844	812	799	844
R2		0.089	0.197	0.221
R2 Adj.		0.071	0.181	0.206
AIC	809.0	4688.2	3817.5	200.0
BIC	889.5	4772.8	3901.8	285.3
F	1.483			14.675

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

While I identified this pattern in prior work on Russian elections (Harvey 2016, 2019), the analysis in this chapter confirms the pattern using new forensic techniques and shows that it remains robust even after including four additional election years that were then unavailable.⁹ There are two possible explanations for finding that increasing political openness is associated with more intensive dispersed manipulation, but less intensive centralized manipulation. First, it could be—as the regime-weakness model of manipulation would hold—that incumbents intentionally seek out less visible forms of manipulation when openness is high, to avoid the legitimacy costs associated with exposed manipulation. Alternatively, as I argue in this volume, it could be that low-level agents are less willing to expose themselves to personal risk when political openness is high, leaving the incumbent to rely on less efficient forms of manipulation (or, in the extreme, none at all).

There are two reasons to doubt the regime-weakness version of events, one empirical and one conceptual. Empirically, the analysis in Chapter 3 shows that election fraud tends to *increase* with protest risk, rather than decline. We observe the opposite pattern here, at the regional level. Ecological inference could be the culprit, though it is difficult to see how falsification could decrease nationally in response to political openness, while increasing with competitiveness at the regional level. Is this what we see in the Russian case?

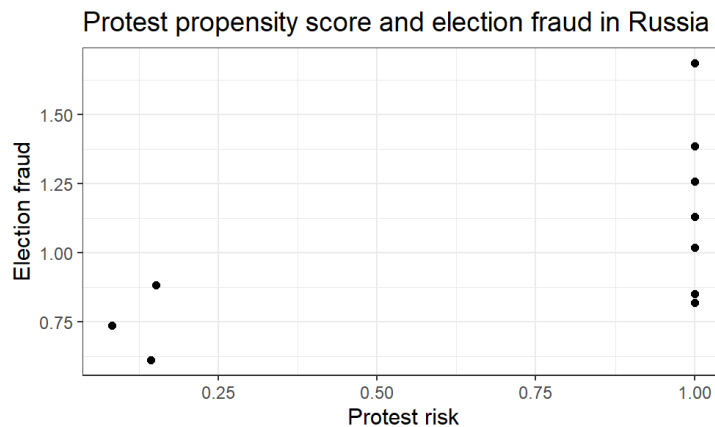


Figure 4.4: Protest risk and fraud in Russia

Figures 4.4 and 4.5 show this is not the case, using the measures from Chapter 3; the data from Russia follow the cross-national pattern. The figures present data from Chapter 3 for the Russian case only. Protest risk is a pre-election measure of the likelihood of post-election protest, based on a variety of predictors (including prior election integrity).¹⁰ As Figure 4.4 illustrates, election fraud in Russia is consistently higher when protest risk is elevated. Similarly, Figure 4.5 shows that fraud appears to increase as pre-election

⁹My previous work considered election years 2003, 2004, 2007, 2008, 2011, and 2012. This study adds election years 2000, 2016, 2018, and 2021.

¹⁰See Chapter 3 for more details.

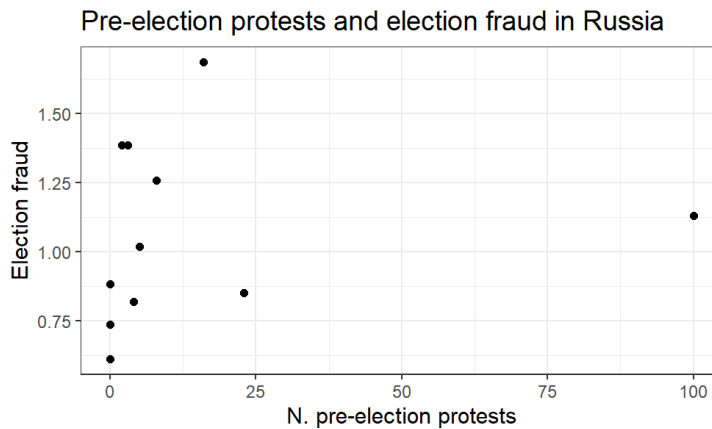


Figure 4.5: Pre-election protest and fraud in Russia

unrest increases. The combined pattern appears inconsistent with the regime-weakness model, and with itself! Fraud increases with the risk of protest (both cross-nationally on average, and in Russia specifically), but it also appears to decline with political openness.

This seeming paradox is resolved if we shift our analytical focus away from incumbents and toward low-level agents of manipulation. This allows us to distinguish between how political openness affects the risks of electoral manipulation for principals and agents. For principals the risk of exposed electoral manipulation is, possibly, legitimacy loss and costly protest. However, the risk is offset to the extent that obvious manipulation sends costly signals of regime resources and capacities (Simpser 2013). Following this logic, incumbents may be perfectly comfortable using visible forms of manipulation, as long as they communicate such costly signals. Indeed, doing so may even reduce the risk of mass mobilization (Harvey & Mukherjee 2020).

For agents, however, the risk of exposure is more personal, and has very little upside. An individual who is caught falsifying election results or stuffing ballot boxes faces direct costs: they may have the unpleasant experience of dealing with the police, having charges brought by the public prosecutor, hiring defense attorneys, and going to court. If convicted, as discussed in Chapter 6, they may face large fines and even the risk of prison. Even when prison terms are converted to probation (a suspended sentence, in the Russian legal parlance), such a status imposes significant restrictions and vulnerabilities. During the probationary period, the convicted individual must check in regularly with their probationary officer, inform the authorities of any change in work or residence, and—most importantly—avoid committing any other crimes or administrative misdeed. Failure to perform these duties could lead to imposition of the original prison sentence (Articles 73 and 74 of the Russian Criminal Code). Finally, there may be social and reputational harms that accrue to the individual for breaking the law; such social damage cannot be ruled out, given that the typical precinct-level election commissioner is not a

hardened party activist, but rather a low-level public servant (often a teacher) pressed into service by their superiors (Forrat 2018).

Finally, why would principals or agents be more comfortable employing decentralized forms of manipulation like voter pressure and vote-buying / multiple-voting when political openness goes up? The principal-focused argument would hold that, by being harder to detect, such activities reduce the legitimacy cost of manipulation compared to falsification. This is a fair assumption, given that such manipulation is more difficult to observe by election monitors. However, in my view it misses the mark, because voter pressure, vote-buying, and multiple-voting are *by necessity* public forms of manipulation—they involve direct contact with voters. Often, voters targeted in vote-buying / multiple voting schemes are asked to recruit additional confederates from their own networks (see Chapter 6 for examples). Each individual in the scheme is free to share their experience with others after the fact. On the other hand, election officials who falsify results strive to keep their efforts private. Often, there is no hard evidence of falsification; instead, there is merely evidence that observers were kept separate from officials during the count (an administrative, rather than criminal, offense).

What makes falsification less desirable in political open environments is not its observability—manipulation methods that involve direct contact with voters are inherently more observable to ordinary citizens. Instead, what distinguishes falsification is its easy *attributability*. Election officials are publicly named individuals. They operate at a specified location, date, and time. This means that, when exposed, they are particularly vulnerable to legal penalties. Vote-buying and voter-pressure, on the other hand, are carried out by private, perhaps anonymous or pseudonymous individuals at a multitude of locations throughout the voting period. This means that, even if voters, parties, and observers know that vote-buying or voter pressure operations took place, they are hard pressed to identify the organizers.

As a result, incumbents have little incentive to shift from away from a more private form of manipulation to a more public one, under the regime-weakness approach. Such forms of manipulation are costlier and less efficient, and more public. There is some evidence to suggest that personal experience with vote-buying, as well as knowledge that others have sold their votes, is corrosive to public trust in elections (Cohen *et al.* 2025; Guerra & Justesen 2022) and to confidence in ballot integrity (Oliveros n.d.). Voter pressure has the same effects, boosting turnout among the targeted individuals but at the cost of political support from those who are not targeted (Frye *et al.* 2025a). Both social pressure (Matland & Murray 2013) and fear of electoral violence (Burchard 2020) have been associated with a backlash effect against the sponsoring party. Since vote-buying cannot be concealed from its targets and their social networks, and both are associated with legitimacy costs, it is difficult to see the benefits of shifting to this kind of manipulation in politically open districts under the regime-weakness model. Doing so risks further publicizing failures of election integrity, and potentially incensing the targets of such efforts or those who become aware of them.

International practitioners are well aware of the importance of legal accountability for those who tamper with elections. The ACE Electoral Knowledge Project notes, for example, that “Enforcement is a deterrent to fraud, and a safeguard” of electoral in-

tegrity. The report goes on to note that, “Investigating electoral corruption is not easy,” highlighting the political biases of prosecutors, judges, and juries as well as the challenges of accessing witnesses and suspects (Finn *et al.* 2012). The same report notes numerous challenges to the successful prosecution of vote-buying, specifically: certain activities may escape legal scrutiny due to loopholes in the law. Activities that scholars may clearly identify as vote-buying may not fall under the same legal category if, for instance, the giver’s intent to influence the election cannot be proven, if the ‘gift’ in question has small or uncertain value, if the ‘gift’ is given to communities rather than individuals, if the actual vote-buying agents cannot be tied to a party or candidate, and so on (Finn *et al.* 2012). The legal ambiguity of vote-buying, relative to falsification, is another key reason that decentralized forms of manipulation are less risky for agents (even as they continue to pose legitimacy costs to principals). Similarly, a report by International IDEA finds that “inadequate law enforcement frequently enables” the persistence of vote-buying (Oliver Joseph & Vasil Vashchanka 2022).

These expert opinions, in addition to the more detailed historical analyses presented in Chapter 2, strongly suggest that the central distinction between falsification and vote-buying / voter pressure is not in their potential legitimacy costs to principals, but rather in the degree to which these tactics expose agents to individual risk. The next chapter investigates similar dynamics in the more competitive, less consolidated context of Ukrainian elections. Finally, Chapter 6 returns to Russia, to confirm the agent-risk model using court records and additional election forensic analysis.

Chapter 5

Election manipulation, patronage, and agent risk in Ukraine

The Ukrainian case provides an opportunity to test the theory in a very different set of circumstances. No ruling party has ever managed to dominate Ukrainian politics in the way United Russia does. Instead, Ukraine's political history from 2002 to 2014 (the period covered here) is one of crisis, alternation in power, polarization, democratization and democratic backsliding. In other words, the case provides an opportunity to test the regime-strength theory of election manipulation at the opposite end of the spectrum from Russia: where the regime is highly competitive and unconsolidated, though still in the context of extensive patronage networks and weak rule of law.

Ukrainian politics at the time was roughly divided into two broad camps: a largely pro-Western camp which came to be known as the Orange coalition, and a largely pro-Russian camp centered around the Party of Regions.¹ Each of these camps had durable bases of political support, substantial legislative representation at the national level, and support from wealthy oligarchs. Alternative models of election manipulation make distinct predictions for the Ukrainian case, as a result.

Models that assume election manipulation signals weakness to elites and opposition actors would predict restraint on incumbents' part. In a closely divided polity, where the opposition is well-resourced and well-organized, incumbents would anticipate that substantial, costly protest would be the outcome of any manipulation effort large enough to make a difference in the election. Likewise, a grievance-based model of electoral protest would predict election manipulation would galvanize a large portion of the population—supporters of the out-of-power group—to protest.

¹ This is, of course, a shorthand description that overlooks considerable nuance in the two camps.

As this chapter will show, none of these patterns are quite borne out in the election-forensic data. Election forensic analysis of election data from 2002 to 2014 is used to estimate the level of overall manipulation in favor of pro-Eastern and pro-Western parties in each region. An election-forensic measure of falsification is likewise generated for each region. The results show no evidence of systematic falsification across the period. This is as expected given the higher risk to agents in the Ukrainian than Russian case; highly attributable falsification is scarce. This indicates that less attributable (but more public) forms of manipulation, like voter pressure and vote-buying, are more common

The results indicate that these less attributable forms of manipulation are sensitive to patronage consolidation and agent risk. When a pro-Eastern president is in office, manipulation in favor of pro-Eastern parties increases—but only in regions where those parties are locally dominant. Pro-eastern manipulation is systematically lower in regions that were not part of Soviet Ukraine prior to World War II; these are regions where the risk of exposure is especially high. Finally, an analysis of the political loyalties of Ukraine oligarchs shows that electoral manipulation increases as oligarchic political machines consolidate in support of pro-Eastern parties and candidates.

5.1 Ukraine's political history, 2000 to 2014

Though analysts should be wary of over-emphasizing the point, Ukraine's political divisions during this period were broadly regional. Voters in the country's east generally supported parties and candidates that adopted a more interventionist economic policy and took a more favorable view toward Russia. By contrast, voters in the west were more likely to support parties and candidates with economic and foreign policies oriented towards the market and towards Europe (Birch, 2000). The two regions are characterized by ethnic and linguistic divisions, with the west home to more ethnic Ukrainians and Ukrainian-speakers, while Russian ethnicity and language is more common in the east.

5.1.1 Overall context

These differences can be attributed, in part, to historical legacies: much of western Ukraine was ruled by the Austro-Hungarian Empire prior to World War I, and by Poland, Romania, or Czechoslovakia during the interwar years. Government policy in these regions, before they were incorporated into the Soviet Union in 1939, was relatively democratic and favorable to the development of Ukrainian national identity. By contrast, eastern Ukraine was part of the Russian Empire, which emphasized a Ukrainian identity that was a regional subset of the broader Russian ethnicity and language (Katchanovski 2006). Despite the well-documented importance of language (Fournier 2002; Kulyk 2011) and ethnicity (Barrington 2002) in Ukraine, however, the regions' voters are not homogeneous blocs (Sasse 2010). For example, using a survey experiment, Frye (2015) finds that a hypothetical candidate's position on closer ties with Europe or Russia is more likely to drive a voter's preference than either the candidate's reported ethnicity

or language. Furthermore, many of Ukraine's eastern regions are more diverse linguistically and ethnically than is generally reported.

Additionally, as in other post-communist countries, Ukraine's economic transition created a class of oligarchs who were able to gain control of the state's major economic assets. In Ukraine, these oligarchs are often linked in regional clans and can use their resources to back local politicians. These patterns can be seen even in independent Ukraine's earliest elections, but intensified following the Orange Revolution (D'Anieri 2011).

While regional attitudes follow the general contours described above, it is important to note that major Ukrainian political parties have not been characterized by stark ideological conflicts so much as by regional loyalties, affiliation with particular leaders, and the distribution of patronage. Parties in Ukraine tend to be highly personalized, and frequently depend on the resources, reputation, and charisma of particular leaders for their electoral success (Rybiy 2013). This is especially true of the western-oriented parties associated with Viktor Yushchenko and Yulia Tymoshenko (Kudelia & Kuzio 2015; Kuzio 2012). This personalization contributed to parties' ideological fluidity² and voters' difficulty in placing parties on an ideological spectrum (Rybiy 2013).

This weak ideological commitment on the part of voters, combined with social inequality and overlapping political and economic responsibilities of local leaders (Allina-Pisano 2010), allows parties to rely on 'administrative resources' like access to state employment, favorable (or unfavorable) business treatment, and selective law enforcement to build and maintain networks of supporters (D'Anieri 2011; Protsyk & Wilson 2003). Tools like these give political leaders the ability to raise funds, mobilize voters, and manipulate elections (Hale 2003). These tools are usually held by regional or local actors in Ukraine, rather than being institutionalized at the national level (Way 2005). In particular, such methods are characteristic of the pro-eastern parties exemplified by the Party of Regions (Kudelia & Kuzio 2015; Kuzio 2012).

A large public sector and a relatively compliant judiciary (Kudelia 2012) provide ample opportunity for the executive branch to apply pressure to voters and opposition figures in Ukraine. Post-Soviet reforms subordinating regional governors to the president created 'a strong vertical executive power running from the president down to the village level'—in order to retain office, regional and local officials were required to mobilize voters on behalf of their bosses (Konitzer-Smirnov 2005). As in Russia (Frye *et al.* 2014), state employees and workers in industries that are vulnerable to state regulation are susceptible to pressure from above. In one particularly stark example, school children at a school in eastern Ukraine informed their parents that their teachers would be fired if the parents did not support the government in an upcoming election (D'Anieri 2007).

During the 2004 presidential election, which sparked the Orange Revolution, the government leaned on administrative resources to encourage "the police, the army, prisons,

²Some parties are exceptions to this rule: the ideologically cohesive Communist Party of Ukraine and Svoboda (Freedom) did well in the 2012 parliamentary election, winning 13% and 10% of the vote, respectively (Rybiy 2013).

public universities, schools, and hospitals, to campaign and vote for Prime Minister Viktor Yanukovich,” who enjoyed the backing of the sitting president and many Ukrainian oligarchs (Katchanovski 2008). Moreover, government officials engaged in tampering with the electronic results of the second round of the election; the combined efforts of mobilization and falsification appeared sufficient to tip the election in favor of Yanukovich and against his pro-Western rival Viktor Yushchenko—a rare example of a stolen election (Simpser 2013). The Party of Regions, which was led by Yanukovich and came to be the dominant party in eastern Ukraine and Crimea, relied on a mix of state administrative resources, political patronage, and intra-elite bargaining to maintain its support in the region (Kudelia & Kuzio 2015; Myagkov *et al.* 2009). Patronage, clientelism, and voter pressure are all common features of the Ukrainian election system in this period, and—as in Russia—it is characterized by a political hierarchy that links the president to local officials through intermediaries like regional officials and oligarchs.

Ukraine’s election law divides the country into 225 district election commissions. Rules determining membership on the committees have varied from year to year, but have generally granted automatic representation to representatives of the parliamentary parties, with remaining seats filled by non-parliamentary parties via lotteries. This setup allowed for small, hastily registered parties—operating informally on behalf of major parties or politicians—to gain representation on the district commissions. This problem became especially egregious in 2012, when the Central Election Commission implemented a change in the lottery process five days before the drawing: instead of individual lotteries for each district commission, a single lottery would be held that would determine the makeup of all 225 commissions. As a result, small parties that had nominated only one or two candidates nationwide gained representation on all district commissions, while larger opposition parties were excluded (Kovalov 2014; OSCE Office for Democratic Institutions and Human Rights 2013). District election commissions then implemented a similar nominating procedure for all their subordinate precinct election commissions.

This system can be especially problematic when combined with the deep patronage roots enjoyed by the Party of Regions in eastern Ukraine, which it used to gain outside influence on the commissions. In one notable example, OSCE observers in a single election district of Donetsk oblast’ determined that 1,667 of the 2,551 precinct election commissioners in the district worked for an enterprise headed by the Party of Regions candidate—meaning that more than two-thirds of precinct commissioners presided over balloting for their employer (OSCE Office for Democratic Institutions and Human Rights 2013).

While the presence of technical representatives on election commissions was perhaps most extensive in the 2012 campaign, it figured prominently in previous elections as well. In the first round of the 2004 election, technical candidates had the right to nominate up to 66,000 members of precinct election commissions; while both major candidates took advantage of technical candidates, the OSCE concluded that Viktor Yanukovich benefited the most, finding that supportive technical candidates gave him “a de facto majority on election commissions” (OSCE Office for Democratic Insti-

tutions and Human Rights 2005). The 2010 election, in which Yanukovych was first elected, was relatively free of electoral fraud, with candidates emphasizing voter mobilization (Herron 2011), though the analysis presented here suggests that some of these mobilization efforts may have been extra-legal and/or characterized by the misuse of state resources (OSCE Office for Democratic Institutions and Human Rights 2010).

Partisan control of election commissions at various levels facilitates electoral manipulation in various forms, which observers frequently witnessed in Ukraine. In 2004, the OSCE observed—among other issues—ballot box stuffing, irregularities with absentee voting, large numbers of voters being turned away from the polls, implausible turnout figures, and suspicious tabulation process. All of these forms of electoral manipulation are either implemented or influenced by election commissioners at the precinct, territorial, or central level. Similar problems were observed by the OSCE in 2012, when observers negatively assessed the vote count in eleven percent of monitored precincts, and tabulation was negatively assessed in almost half of the 161 district election commissions monitored (OSCE Office for Democratic Institutions and Human Rights 2013).

In sum, the context of the case is one in which formal democratic structures coexisted with deeply embedded patronage networks, which were consistently employed to undermine electoral integrity. A relatively polarized electorate, however—partially reflecting historical socioeconomic and cultural differences across regions—helped prevent any one party or faction from consolidating control, particularly benefiting pro-eastern political forces.

5.1.2 Frustrated efforts to consolidate power

Soviet Ukraine was characterized by heavy reliance on patronage and clientelism, transmitted by informal networks operating within the formal Communist Party and command economy structures in a system Kitschelt calls (1995) terms *patrimonial communism*. This framework persisted in post-Soviet Ukraine, as many political and bureaucratic officeholders remained in place, while communist-era managers and officials became private-sector owners of capital (Zimmer & Haran 2008). Especially in the heavily industrialized eastern parts of the country, where small-scale enterprises are less common (Aslund 2005), large portions of the population are dependent on state- or employer-based patronage (Zimmer 2005). A power vertical has been solidly established in the eastern part of the country, based on an alliance of regional and local administrative officials and business actors (Zimmer 2005). Nationally, the pro-presidential constitution of 1996 subordinated regional governors and local executives to the president (Konitzer-Smirnov 2005), a structure which remained largely unchanged under the post-Orange constitution.

However, the Cassette Scandal crisis, also known as ‘Kuchmagate’—in which illicit recordings of the president allegedly ordering a kidnapping, among other unsavory details, were made public—limited the ability of President Kuchma to further consolidate control over the patronage resources and hand them to his preferred candidate in the 2004 presidential election, Viktor Yanukovych. As a result of the ensuing political crisis, the party system fractured, oligarchic alliances were ruptured, momentum toward

a super-presidential constitution was scuppered, President Kuchma's succession plans were thrown into turmoil, and an opposition movement based in civil society began to form (Kuzio 2007). The scandal helped lay the foundations for the 2004 Orange Revolution, in which hundreds of thousands of citizens took to the streets to protest electoral manipulation in the presidential elections. The subsequent opposition victory in a repeat election upended the party structure, and helped usher in a new constitution that divided power more evenly between the presidency and the parliament.

As part of a compromise following the Orange Revolution, a new constitution was adopted which greatly increased the patronage capabilities of the parliament and prime minister. As a result of the new constitution, the parliamentary majority gained more discretion over the nomination of prime ministers, more influence over the defense and security ministries and the prosecutor general, and shifted much executive staffing power away from the president and to the cabinet (Christensen *et al.* 2005). This shift reinforced the *de facto* competing-pyramid structure of patronage in the post-revolutionary period, by expanding and legitimizing the influence of the parliamentary majority while still retaining some patronage powers in the office of the presidency (Hale 2014).

The competing pyramid structure would not survive long into the Yanukovych presidency, when the Party of Regions was eager to press its advantage in patronage resources. After defeating Tymoshenko's network in the 2010 presidential election, Yanukovych moved swiftly to encourage elite defections within the Rada, building a pro-presidential coalition that secured control of the premiership (Hale 2014; Kudelia 2012). Subsequently, Yanukovych was able to win restoration of the pre-revolution constitution favoring the president; he rapidly reconsolidated patronage networks that had become fragmented during the Orange period.

This centralizing period would be short-lived however, as massive crowds during the 2014 Euromaidan crisis helped depose Yanukovych, leading to the seizure of the Crimean peninsula by Russia, the *de facto* secession of two of Ukraine's most populous and industrialized regions, a prolonged civil war, and the effective collapse of the pro-eastern Party of Regions. The patronage networks that had helped propel the success of the Party of Regions locally and nationally began to unravel (Hale 2014).

5.1.3 The role of the oligarchs

In addition to the shifting consolidation of state-based patronage, analysts of Ukrainian politics must also contend with a complex arrangement oligarchic 'clans,' which deploy their resources to support favored parties. Unlike in Russia, where the major oligarchs generally do not risk challenging the Kremlin Ukraine's oligarchic clans have been more fractious. During Kuchma's presidency, three regional oligarchic clans became influential in politics: the Dnipropetrovsk network, the Donetsk network, and the Kyiv network. All three were generally aligned with Kuchma until the Orange Revolution (Pleine 2016), and used their resources to influence election outcomes (Katchanovski 2008). The revolution split the political-oligarchic patronage networks into three competing camps—one each aligned with Viktor Yushchenko, Yulia Tymoshenko, and Vik-

tor Yanukovych—a framework that persisted until the 2010 presidential election (Hale 2010). Even after being cast into the political wilderness nationally by the Orange crowds, Yanukovych and the Party of Regions could rely on regional patronage networks and elected local mayors to retain influence in the east (Hale 2010).

When Yanukovych assumed the presidency in 2010, the fractiousness of the opposition coalition of oligarchs gave way once again to a more united patronage pyramid around the presidency and the Donetsk clan. In turn, this informal patronage network collapsed as a result of the Euromaidan and subsequent civil war, generally reconstituting itself around oligarch Petro Poroshenko after his 2014 presidential victory (Pleine 2016). Poroshenko, though his own election was largely clean, used patronage resources to good effect (especially in the East, where networks still remained largely intact) in the subsequent legislative elections (Fedorenko *et al.* 2016).

Some oligarchs control industrial conglomerates and associated patronage networks (Lankina & Libman 2019; Puglisi 2003); others control mass media outlets (Wilson 2016); many use their wealth to prop up ‘spoiler parties’ and ‘clone candidates’ to draw votes away from opposition parties (Wilson 2016). Oligarchs in Ukraine are a potential source of patronage resources, but cannot on their own promise impunity for electoral crimes. Their ability to protect themselves and their agents from legal punishment hinges on their relationship with the state authorities, which can shift over time and with election outcomes (Zubytska 2018).

5.1.4 Risks of manipulation exposure

Given the divisions of the country, local constraints in Ukraine must be conceptualized for each broad political group, referred to here by the shorthand terms ‘pro-western’ and ‘pro-eastern.’ Risks vary for each group according to local conditions. For example, the pro-eastern Party of Regions has been able to exert influence over local courts in regions it controls (Katchanovski 2008), reducing the risk faced by its own agents while exacerbating them for pro-western agents. The Party of Regions inherited much of the political culture and resources of the Communist Party of Ukraine, and used these advantages to build a locally dominant coalition of government administrators, red directors (communist-era managers of large firms), and local business / oligarchic interests (Kudelia & Kuzio 2015; Zimmer & Haran 2008). As a result, the heartland of the PoR is politically sealed off (Osipian & Osipian 2006).

The situation is more complicated in regions where pro-western parties tend to dominate. Machine politics, essential to delivering votes in places like Donetsk and Luhansk in the east, were difficult to export to territories in Western Ukraine (Sushko 2002; Zimmer 2005), due to a more politically active civil society there (D’Anieri 2005) and the relative absence of locally dominant economic interests (Kudelia & Kuzio 2015; Kuzio 2012). This lack of consolidation produced two major pro-Western party groups, primarily oriented around the figures of Yushchenko and Tymoshenko. As a result, these two blocs competed with each other for votes within their territories (Kuzio 2013), limiting the ability of either bloc to develop the kind of local political monopoly that reduces risks for election manipulating agents.

The development of active civil society in the west accelerated as a result of the Kuchma-gate crisis, and was nurtured by opposition parties during the Orange Revolution (Kudelia 2007). However, the historical roots of civil society and multiparty democracy run deeper in Western Ukraine than in the East. During perestroika, dissidents and former political prisoners in Western Ukraine formed Rukh (the Ukrainian Popular Movement for Restructuring) to challenge the Communist Party; while Rukh gained popularity in Kyiv and central Ukraine, it never gained much of a foothold in the east (Kuzio 2010). In surveys from the early post-Soviet period, respondents from western Lviv were twice as likely as residents of Donetsk to attempt to “resolve social problems” by contacting mass media, contacting officials, or joining an organization, and three times as likely to have signed a petition or participated in a demonstration (Aberg 2000). These connections persisted through the Orange Revolution: protesters in that movement were motivated less by democratic ideology and more by the fact that they were highly networked, with higher incomes, and less dependent on the state (Beissinger 2013).

As demonstrated in more detail for the Russian case in Chapter 6, the Ukrainian judicial system does address allegations of election crimes. As in Russia (and as predicted in Chapter 2), it is difficult for the legal system to penalize the organizers of vote-buying or multiple-voting rings. Rather, a precinct election official is a more typical defendant. For example, three precinct election officials in one highly competitive single-member district were convicted of attempting to falsify the election returns (Zhytomyr Oblast’ 2015). Effectively caught in the act—partisan and non-partisan observers found the pre-filled returns—the officials refused a plea bargain but attempted to convince the court that their actions were innocent mistakes. Upon weighing the testimony of eight witnesses, the court found the officials’ protestations unconvincing, and sentenced them to five years imprisonment (converted to one year of probation). The race for the seat in District 66, where these events happened, was highly competitive—the winner claimed the seat with only 19 percent of the vote (“Central Election Commission - 2012-2013” n.d.).

Risks to election-manipulating agents are heightened by the presence of partisan and non-partisan election observers. In Ukraine’s more competitive environment, parties can dispatch election monitors to try to catch their opponents’ agents in the act. Observers’ role in documenting the abuses that preceded the Orange Revolution is well documented (Bunce & Wolchik 2006; McFaul 2007); their importance in increasing risk to agents is less so. The youth organization *Pora* (It’s Time!) was instrumental in documenting and publicizing electoral misdeeds in Ukraine’s 2004 election; its primary early activities were raising public awareness of such abuses and to serve as protest entrepreneurs (Kuzio 2006). In part, this protest-centric strategy is sensible in the criminal-legal environment of the time, in which a dominant executive patronage network was able to exercise considerable influence over the judiciary (Trochev 2018)—though, as Chapter 6 will show, agents are still at risk of punishment even in highly closed environments. Nevertheless, as Ukraine has become more democratic, civil society has invested more resources in the criminal-legal aspect of election monitoring. Beginning in 2014, the civil society group OPORA, the post-Orange descendant of *Pora*, increasingly worked to bring electoral crimes to the attention of the courts. This effort grew

to include nationwide police trainings (ultimately reaching over 70,000 officers), and a full training course for officers at Lviv University of Internal Affairs. Highlighting this shift at the inauguration of the university training course, the OPORA chair Olga Aivazovska said:

I would like to remind you that between 1991 and 2015 there was not a single conviction against persons who participated in or organized voter bribery. And I can say that those indictments that were handed over after 2015, those court decisions that imposed sanctions either in the form of restriction of liberty or imprisonment, or in the form of a fine...are a progressive consequence of this work (“ОПОРА спільно з Львівським університетом внутрішніх справ навчатиме правоохоронців на базі «Модельної виборчої дільниці»” n.d.).

In sum, local risks vary considerably across Ukraine by both party and region. The risk of exposure for pro-western agents is especially high in eastern regions where the political machine organized around the Party of Regions predominates, due to that party’s success in creating a subnational enclave prior to the Euromaidan crisis, Russian intervention, and civil war. However, the existence of competing pro-western parties and a robust civil society in many western regions makes electoral manipulation difficult to achieve undetected in those regions as well. These differences are largely structural, as described above; they rest on broad historical and social factors rather than on parties’ see-sawing electoral fortunes. As a result, the level of risk in a particular locality does not shift much over time in Ukraine. Instead, shifts in manipulation patterns over time are due largely to major changes occur in the consolidation of patronage during the period studied.

5.2 Hypotheses and other empirical tests

The regime-strength model of electoral manipulation claims that incumbents reduce agency loss among front-line agents to the extent that they are able to develop tools of social control that reduce agents’ level of risk. Where incumbents accomplish this goal, as in Russia, the model predicts high levels of manipulation, with falsification occurring in places where the regime is most consolidated and less efficient forms of manipulation occurring where risks are locally higher.

In Ukraine, agency loss is expected to be high. Uncertainty over which camp will control national executive over the medium term—and thus uncertainty over who will control the prosecutorial service and have influence over the judiciary should increase the expected cost of engaging in falsification. This risk of exposure is heightened by the widespread presence of partisan and civil-society observers in precinct and district election commissions. Greater political competitiveness increases the risk that agents of the out-of-power faction will face punishment in the courts (Popova 2012); that same competitiveness makes it difficult to know *a priori* which side will win the election.

It is thus expected that falsification will be rare and unsystematic in Ukraine, as it will be difficult for parties to recruit agents willing to take the risk of exposure and punishment.

Forensic measures of fraud should therefore be uncorrelated with parties' vote-shares. In other words, I expect that the null hypothesis will *not* be rejected in statistical tests of that correlation; consequently, I list this as an empirical implication of the theory, rather than a hypothesis.

5.2.1 Patronage consolidation

Instead, I expect that other forms of manipulation will predominate, as principals recruit agents for tasks further down the attribution ladder (see Chapter 2). When outright falsification is unavailable, incumbents with resources will seek to convert those resources into votes through ballot-stuffing, vote-buying, and voter-pressure. Nationwide, I expect pro-eastern manipulation to increase when the president has a pro-eastern orientation (these presidencies also coincide with the pro-presidential constitution), and when pro-Eastern parties dominate in the legislature.

H1a: Overall manipulation pro-Eastern manipulation will increase when a pro-Eastern president is in office.

H1b: Overall manipulation pro-Eastern manipulation will increase when pro-Eastern parties have greater representation in the Verkhovna Rada.

This expectation also yields hypotheses at the regional level, where it is possible to take into account the existence and orientation of oligarchic political machines. Where oligarchic political machines are well-established, pro-Eastern manipulation should increase when those oligarchs are supportive of the pro-Eastern party or candidate. In the Ukrainian context, these political machines are most well-developed in the areas of the country where Soviet industrial policy favored heavy industry and industrialization (Lankina & Libman 2019). This produces the following hypotheses:

H2a: Overall pro-Eastern manipulation will increase in regions where supportive oligarchs control significant assets.

H2b: The effect of supportive oligarchs on pro-Eastern manipulation will increase with urbanization.

5.2.2 Local risk

The theory expects that less attributable forms of electoral manipulation will increase in low-risk areas when patronage consolidation is high. In the Ukrainian case, I expect that pro-Eastern manipulation will increase in regions where pro-Eastern parties dominate (i.e. where risk of exposure is low), when a pro-Eastern president is in office. When a pro-Western president is in office, the reorientation of national-level patronage resources away from the pro-Eastern network should lead to a reduction in manipulation in those areas. Finally, overall pro-Eastern manipulation should remain low in regions where the risk of exposure for pro-Eastern agents is high, regardless of presidential control.

H3: Pro-Eastern manipulation should increase with pro-Eastern parties' regional control, but only when a pro-Eastern president is in office.

H4: Pro-Eastern manipulation should be lowest in regions that were not part of Soviet Ukraine before World War II.

5.3 Data and methods

To test these hypotheses, I draw on precinct-level results from nine elections in Ukraine from 2002 to 2014. This includes three presidential elections—the third round of the 2004 elections, along with both rounds of the 2010 and 2014 elections—and four legislative elections (2002, 2006, 2007, and 2012). Unfortunately, the dataset excludes the first two rounds of the 2004 presidential elections, for which precinct-level results are not publicly available. Each election-year includes data from approximately 30,000 to 35,000 precincts nested within Ukraine’s 27 regions. As a result of the annexation of Crimea and the conflict in eastern Ukraine, the legislative and presidential elections in 2014 draw on approximately 28,000 precincts within 23 regions: Crimea, Sevastopol, Donetsk, and Luhansk regions drop out of the data. This precinct-level data is used to conduct election-forensic estimates of falsification and overall evidence of electoral manipulation. Unlike in the Russian case, I am unable to estimate levels of vote-buying and related tactics, since Ukraine did not release precinct-level numbers of absentee or mobile-ballot-box voting until the 2014 elections. Explanatory and control variables are taken at the regional level.

5.3.1 Dependent variables

Two dependent variables are estimated for each region in each election year, using precinct-level data. First, an estimate of overall manipulation is calculated by regressing the absolute-vote share for the largest pro-Western and pro-Eastern parties (per election) on precinct-level turnout (Myagkov *et al.* 2009), using multilevel models with random slopes and intercepts.³ Such a test assumes that, in a clean election, a party’s absolute vote-share (the party’s number of votes divided by the number of registered voters) should increase consistently across precincts within a country, as precinct turnout increases. This approach assumes homogeneous precincts across the country, an assumption which is bolstered by testing precincts within regions or through the use of relevant socioeconomic control variables to weed out potentially confounding relationships (Deckert 2013). I employ both approaches here. Figures 5.1 and 5.2 show the distribution of coefficients for the major parties. Higher coefficients are more suspicious. While both party groups show some evidence of manipulation, there appear to be more large coefficients overall on the pro-Eastern side.

Second, election falsification is estimated by measuring the degree to which the ones-digit across a party’s vote totals deviate from the expected uniform distribution, by region and year. For each region in each election, I calculate a G-statistic, a derivation of a log-likelihood ratio test (Skovoroda & Lankina 2017). Whereas the analysis of the Russian case presented in Chapter 4 used a stricter measure—deviance in last-digit zero

³This allows for the turnout coefficient to vary freely by region, and accounts for varying ‘baseline’ support for each party in the region.

only—the analysis of Ukraine uses deviance across all digits. This is a more sensitive measure, intended to pose a tougher test of the implication that falsification in Ukraine will be rare and non-systematic. Because a large number of single- or double-digit results for a party can mechanically produce larger deviations from the expected uniform distribution of last digits, for each party I exclude such precincts from the estimation.

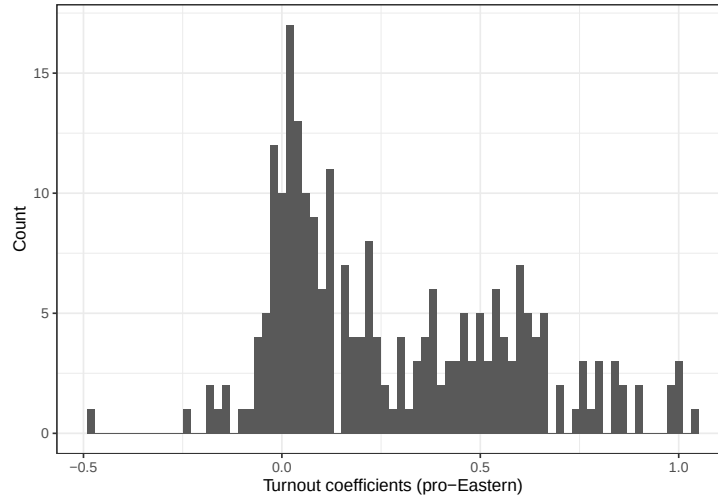


Figure 5.1: Histogram of turnout coefficients for major pro-East parties (2002-2014)

5.3.2 Explanatory variables

In places where pro-Western parties have thin networks and few supporters, it will be easier for pro-Eastern agents to operate without threat of exposure, and vice versa. Echoing the approach from Chapter 4, and of prior work (Harvey 2016), I operationalize this risk in part by using the regional legislative margin of victory between the largest parties in regional legislative elections and their largest political rival. This measure is lagged, so that it precedes the national elections that produce estimates of manipulation that serve as dependent variables. Despite Ukraine’s unitary system, elected regional legislatures do provide an opportunity for out-parties to place constraints on the governing party (Romanova 2013). Margins of victory in regional elections are also indicative of the underlying degree of contestation, which is undergirded by civil society activism, media coverage, oligarchic influence, and other elements of local risk to agents. The variable *Regional pro-East margin* is measured by subtracting the largest pro-Western party’s vote-share from the largest pro-Eastern party’s vote-share. Larger, positive numbers indicate a more dominant pro-Eastern party, while larger negative values indicate more dominant Western parties. This is a region-level measure.

I also measure local risk to agents using dummy variables that capture the historical differences in Ukraine’s regional political cultures. Several oblasts in western Ukraine experienced decades or centuries of Austro-Hungarian rule, which deliberately fostered a

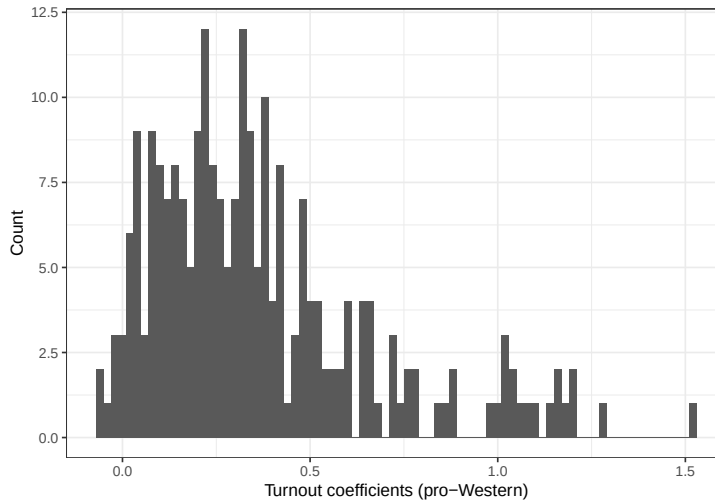


Figure 5.2: Histogram of turnout coefficients for major pro-West parties (2002-2014)

different political culture and Ukrainian identity than that developed in areas of Ukraine which remained under Russian imperial rule prior to the Revolution of 1917. These include the historical regions of Galicia, Bukovina, Volhynia. In addition to their Austro-Hungarian legacies, these regions were also not included in Soviet Ukraine until 1939 or later, sparing them from Stalin-era repressions in the 1930s. These *pre-war Western* regions include: Chernivitska, Ivano-Frankivska, Lvivska, Rivnenska, Ternopilska, Volinska, and Zakarpatska oblasts. It is expected that it will be especially difficult for falsification or pro-Eastern manipulation to occur in these regions.

Each Ukrainian president during the time period covered is coded as pro-Western (Yuschenko, Poroshenko) or *pro-Eastern* (Kuchma, Yanukovych).⁴ This is a nationwide, year-level measure.

Finally, since vote-buying and voter-pressure (and to a lesser extent, ballot-stuffing) are costly and prone to agency loss, requiring the distribution of resources to agents and voters who are difficult to monitor, such efforts are likely to intensify when one party has more consolidated control over patronage resources. These consolidation is measured in two ways, one regional and one nationwide. At the national level, patronage consolidation is measured using an indicator of the degree to which pro-Western or pro-Eastern coalitions predominate in the national legislature, the Verkhovna Rada. I develop this indicator by first building a a Herfindahl–Hirschman index of the parties in the current legislature for each election year.⁵ This is common measure of market concentration in economics and policy, and is a component of the better-known (to po-

⁴The period after Yanukovych's ouster in 2014 is coded as zero, given the pro-Western orientation of the acting presidential administration.

⁵The formula for this index is $HH = \sum_1^x s_i^2$, where s_i is the size of the i -th party as a percentage of the total number of seats in the legislature (expressed as a decimal).

litical scientists) measure of effective number of parties (Golosov 2010). I utilize the Herfindahl index itself, rather than ENP, because I am interested not in how many major parties are present in the legislature, but how concentrated voting blocs are. I then modify the H-H index to capture the political orientation of the governing coalition. If the prime minister comes from a pro-Eastern party, the H-H index is multiplied by 1; if the prime minister hails from a pro-Western party, the H-H index is multiplied by -1. The resulting variable, *Pro-eastern Rada concentration*, takes on larger positive values when a pro-Eastern majority controls a larger number of seats. It takes on larger, negative values when there is a larger pro-Western majority.

Lastly, I construct a region-level measure of oligarchs' influence, by combining two prior datasets. First, Lankina and Libman (2019) provide information on a set of Ukrainian oligarchs and the regions where their assets are concentrated. This dataset is used to calculate the total number of oligarchs with significant assets in each region. I combine this with Pleines' dataset on oligarchs (2020) to identify each oligarch's political orientation (pro-Eastern or pro-Western) per election year. The variable *pro-East oligarchs* is a count variable indicating the total number of oligarchs in each region-year who are supportive of the major pro-Eastern party. This is, admittedly, a somewhat coarse measure; it cannot capture the intensity of an oligarch's political efforts, for instance. However, it does provide an indicator of the degree to which each region is susceptible to patronage-driven efforts to mobilize voters.

5.3.3 Control variables

A set of control variables are included to help account for other possible explanations for manipulation, or for innocent voting patterns that could appear suspicious using the election forensic tools described above. Several of these are region-level controls. They include the percentage of the population in *government employment*, the percentage of the population *over sixty* years of age, the *average wage* in the region, the *population size (log)*, and the percentage of the population claiming *Ukrainian language* as their primary language. All of these variables are taken from the Ukrainian State Statistical Service. In addition, the models also control for the election-year variable *presidential approval rating*, taken as the three-month average approval rating prior to the election. This variable is collected from data published by the Ukrainian survey firm Rating Group. For models that take the g-statistic as a dependent variable, it is essential to control for the number of precincts used in estimating that statistic; larger sample sizes will mechanically result in larger G-statistics, and will be more likely to produce statistically significant deviations from the uniform.⁶ Consequently, in those models, I control for the number of precincts used to calculate the statistic (i.e. the number of precincts where votes for the party exceeded 99).

⁶See Skovoroda and Lankina (2017) for a discussion of this dynamic.

5.4 Results

Table 5.1 reports the results of the election-forensic models. It shows that the indicator of overall pro-Eastern manipulation is positively correlated with pro-Eastern vote-share (as expected). Model 1, which does not control for pro-Western parties' turnout coefficients, shows a positive and statistically significant effect. The effect remains more or less constant once pro-Western turnout coefficient is included as a control in Model 2. In either case, the effect size is substantial: a one standard deviation increase in pro-Eastern turnout coefficient is associated with a 6-point increase in the pro-Eastern party's margin of victory. In other words, in an otherwise tied election, increasing the pro-Eastern party's turnout coefficient by one standard deviation would change the outcome of the election to 53 - 47 in their favor.

Model 3 shows that there is no significant effect for deviance from the uniform distribution of last-digits for pro-East parties. This suggests that outright falsification of the type captured by this measure is rare in Ukraine across the elections covered in the dataset, at least for major pro-Eastern parties. There is one caveat to this conclusion; following best practice (Beber & Scacco 2012), I excluded precincts from the deviance calculations where fewer than 100 votes were counted in that party's favor. A high proportion of precincts with double-digit vote totals will increase the deviance from the uniform distribution naturally, even if the votes are fair. This proportion is extremely high in some of Ukraine's more western regions. For instance, in the 2002 election in Ivano-Frankivska oblast', all but 24 out of 958 precincts are excluded for having fewer than 100 votes for the pro-Eastern party. In 2014, all 914 precincts in Ivano-Frankivska are dropped, as are all precincts in L'vivska, Ternopilska, Vinnitska, Ternopilska, and Cherkaska oblasts. When the total number of available precincts falls below 50 for the reason, I exclude the region from analysis. This results in a smaller number of observations for the G-statistic models, and highlights the difficulty of conducting this sort of analysis in Ukraine's highly polarized and frequently crisis-driven politics under the period of study.

As an additional check, I also utilize a dummy variable to indicate regions where the g-statistic indicator of fraud is statistically significant, with results presented in Model 4. The results show that a statistically significant pro-Eastern G-statistic is unrelated to pro-Eastern vote-share. This suggests that deviation from the uniform distribution is largely random, a possibility which is bolstered by the fact that deviations are statistically significant at the five percent level in only 11 of 235 cases—in other words, in roughly five percent of cases. All told, this supports the expectation that falsification is uncommon, and allows us to interpret the 'overall manipulation' turnout coefficient as primarily reflective of dispersed forms of election manipulation.

Table 5.2 shows the results of models that take pro-Eastern turnout coefficients (Models 5 through 7) as the dependent variable. Model 5 tests the interaction of region-level partisan control and the presence of a pro-Eastern president. As the table and Figure 5.3 show, there is a statistically significant interaction for overall manipulation. This is in line with expectations—it is in the most heavily pro-Eastern regions where patronage networks are most fully developed, owing to the region's Soviet heritage and

Table 5.1: Table 1: OLS models of pro-Eastern party vote-share

	Model 1	Model 2	Model 3	Model 4
(Intercept)	0.586 (0.427)	0.607 (0.426)	1.954*** (0.445)	1.976*** (0.445)
Pro-Eastern turnout coefficient	0.296*** (0.055)	0.245*** (0.064)		
Pro-Western turnout coefficient		−0.102 (0.066)		
Pro-East party last-digit deviance			−0.002 (0.004)	
Pro-East last-digit deviance (binary)				−0.024 (0.068)
Presidential approval rating	0.062 (0.228)	0.069 (0.227)	−0.040 (0.214)	−0.041 (0.215)
Pro-Eastern margin in regional election	0.165* (0.078)	0.147+ (0.078)	0.272** (0.084)	0.270** (0.084)
Gov. employees	−8.144* (3.737)	−7.161+ (3.779)	−5.443 (3.714)	−5.530 (3.725)
Over-sixty pop. share	−0.253 (0.770)	−0.210 (0.768)	−0.385 (0.773)	−0.457 (0.760)
Population	−0.000 07 (0.054)	0.008 (0.054)	−0.234*** (0.060)	−0.239*** (0.059)
Pct. Ukrainian language	−0.970*** (0.104)	−1.002*** (0.106)	−0.608*** (0.109)	−0.607*** (0.109)
N. precincts > 99 pro-East votes			0.0004*** (0.000 06)	0.0004*** (0.000 06)
Num.Obs.	222	222	185	185
R2	0.677	0.681	0.745	0.745
R2 Adj.	0.665	0.667	0.732	0.732
AIC	−2.5	−3.0	−36.5	−36.3
BIC	31.5	34.4	−1.1	−0.9
Log.Lik.	11.264	12.513	29.268	29.160
F	55.798	50.191	56.856	56.767
RMSE	0.23	0.23	0.21	0.21

+ $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

post-Soviet accumulation of politically active oligarchs. When a pro-Eastern candidate occupies the presidency, the resources of the central state can be used to kick regional networks into higher gear. Where the risk of exposure is high, however, having a supportive president in office does not yield additional manipulation. This supports H3.

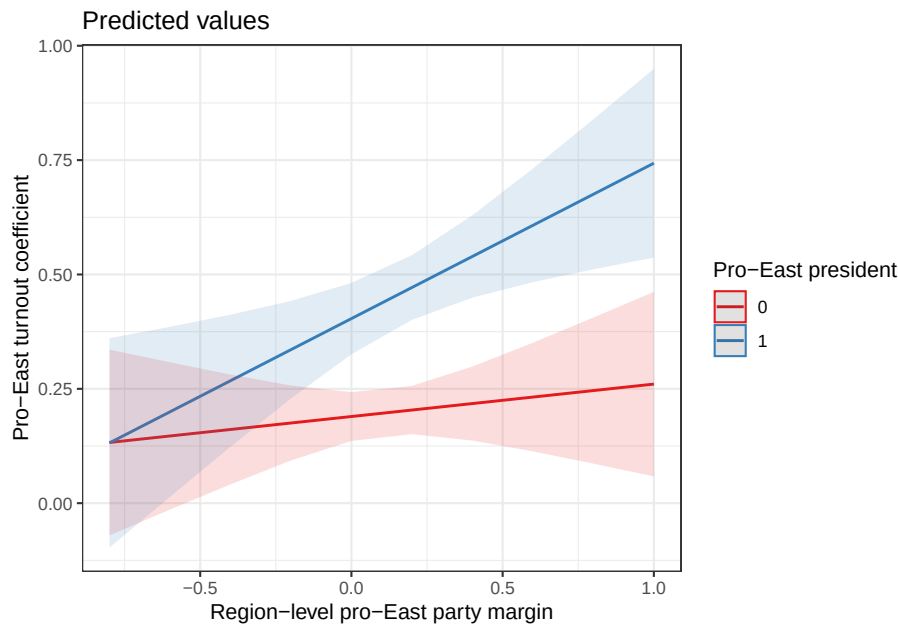


Figure 5.3: Overall pro-eastern manipulation and patronage consolidation

The same pattern is observed for pro-Eastern consolidation of the legislature (Model 6) and for the pre-war West dummy variable (Models 7). Pro-Eastern consolidation in the Rada is associated with increased turnout coefficients in subsequent elections. Likewise, regions in the pre-War west show reduced turnout coefficients for Eastern parties. This supports H1b and H4. In all models, manipulation appears to increase when a pro-Eastern president is in office, supporting H1a.

Next, Table 5.3 reports the results of models that include measures of oligarchic influence. Figure 5.4 shows the interaction effect from Model 8. Consistent with the prior results, these models show that pro-Eastern overall manipulation is improved by patronage consolidation: when more oligarchs are supporting the pro-Eastern party in more urbanized regions, the party's turnout coefficient improves. As Figure 5.4 shows, this effect is most substantial in regions with a high concentration of politically active oligarchs and a very high degree of urbanization. The effect size for such regions is large; turnout coefficients practically double in highly urban regions when oligarchs get involved. The results support H2a and H2b.

Table 5.2: Models of pro-Eastern election manipulation (turnout coefficient)

	Model 5	Model 6	Model 7
(Intercept)	0.020 (0.449)	−0.276 (0.449)	0.634 (0.532)
Presidential approval rating	−1.173*** (0.446)	−0.789* (0.457)	−1.253*** (0.441)
Gov. employees	0.869 (3.122)	−1.517 (2.549)	−2.976 (2.804)
Over-sixty pop. share	0.096 (0.884)	1.262 (0.779)	−0.595 (1.059)
Average wage	−0.000 09*** (0.000 03)	−0.000 02 (0.000 03)	−0.000 07** (0.000 03)
Population	0.103** (0.047)	0.084* (0.045)	0.068 (0.048)
Pct. Ukrainian language	0.099 (0.121)	−0.058 (0.076)	−0.008 (0.080)
Pro-Eastern margin in regional election	0.071 (0.111)		
Pro-East Rada consolidation		0.430*** (0.125)	
Pre-war West			−0.128** (0.062)
Pro-East president	0.214*** (0.049)	0.250*** (0.045)	0.269*** (0.046)
Regional margin : Pro-East pres.	0.269** (0.111)		
Num.Obs.	222	226	226
R2	0.206	0.216	0.189
R2 Adj.	0.172	0.187	0.159

* $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table 5.3: Regression Results

	Pro-East turnout coef.
	Model 8
(Intercept)	1.689*** (0.511)
Presidential approval rating	−1.478*** (0.420)
Gov. employees	−10.691*** (3.656)
Over-sixty pop. share	−0.940 (0.803)
Average wage	−0.0001*** (0.000 03)
Population	−0.135** (0.061)
Pct. Ukrainian language	0.232** (0.090)
Urban pop. share	0.960*** (0.249)
Pro-Eastern oligarch count	−0.370** (0.178)
Pro-East oligarchs : Urban pct.	0.553** (0.222)
Num.Obs.	226
R2	0.298
R2 Adj.	0.265

* $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

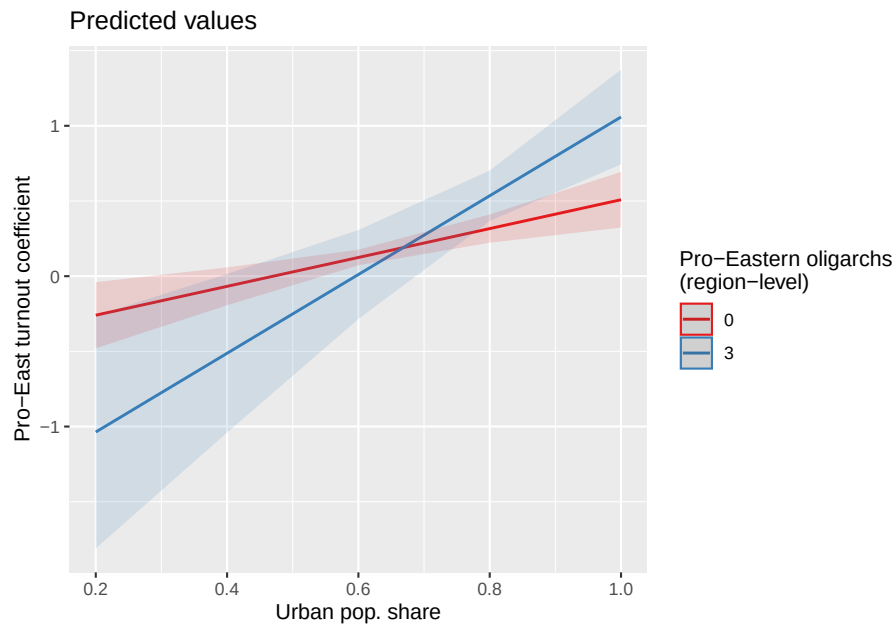


Figure 5.4: Pro-eastern manipulation by urban vote-share and number of supportive oligarchs

5.5 Discussion and conclusion

Despite the difficulties of the case, Ukraine presents an important opportunity to test the implications of the model, especially in comparison with Russia. Russia shares many institutional and historical features with Ukraine (particularly in eastern parts of the country) as a result of a shared imperial and Soviet experience. However, patterns of patronage consolidation and local constraints vary considerably between the two states. Patronage consolidation has consistently been much lower in Ukraine than in Russia during the period of analysis. A single party of power largely dominates in Russia, while the party system in Ukraine is much more fragmented and fluid. Oligarchic interests were largely tamed during the early years of the first Putin administration; rival oligarchic clans continue to clash behind the scenes in Ukraine. The period in which Ukraine's parliamentary-presidential constitution was in force helped establish a two-pyramid structure of patronage, in Hale's (2014) terminology, while Russia continues to operate within a more consolidated vertical of power.

As a result, we should expect to see different patterns of manipulation occur in the two cases. First, while the direct comparison is not statistically tested here, widespread falsification does appear to be considerably less common in Ukraine than in Russia. In the Russian case, suspicious results were captured by the digits test in 24 percent of region-years, whereas in Ukraine the same figure is approximately five percent—

roughly what would be expected due to random chance alone.⁷

One peculiar feature of election management in Ukraine is an apparent emphasis on deflationary tactics; that is, efforts to reduce one's opponents vote-share rather than (or in addition to) inflating one's own. Ukrainian parties have attempted to influence election results by using manufactured parties and candidates to drain votes away from rivals and to gain additional influence on election commissions. Ukrainian elections have often been characterized by an abundance of so-called 'technical parties,' small parties artificially created by main parties in order to divert votes away from their opponents. One such technical party, which voiced strong opposition to Yanukovich and the Party of Regions and whose leader was reminiscent of former Orange-Revolution hero Yulia Tymoshenko, diverted as much as 300,000 votes from the nationalist party UDAR, depriving it of six to eight seats in parliament (Kovalov 2014).

The specifics of the Ukrainian case—robust but fragmented patronage networks combined with a high risk of exposure for illegal manipulation—may help explain this phenomenon. The high risk of exposure makes it difficult to recruit agents for attributable, but cost-effective, election fraud. Widespread voter mobilization and voter pressure campaigns can make up for this, in part, but are costly and unreliable tools not available to all patrons; they require large patronage networks and carry principal-agent risks. By contrast, cheaper deflationary tactics like clone candidates may offer a more predictable return on investment, without requiring anyone to expose themselves to legal risk.

However, the main benefit of the case in the present study is derived from the rapid fluctuation in patronage consolidation over time. Unlike the Mexican case (where patronage networks are deconsolidating during the period of study) or the Russian case (where they remain highly consolidated), Ukraine shifts from a fragmented patronage system after the Orange Revolution, to one with considerable consolidation around the Party of Regions under President Yanukovich, and subsequently back to a fragmented system after the 2014 crisis. The results shown here indicate that the consolidation and constraint model is better suited to explaining electoral manipulation in this kind of setting than is the local-information model; that is, while local conditions certainly matter for explaining electoral manipulation, those conditions are also informed by the overall distribution of patronage resources backing one party or another.

In particular, the election-forensic analysis conducted here shows that overall deflationary manipulation targeting the Party of Regions became less severe during the Yanukovich presidency, but only in regions where constraints on pro-western agents were high. It also found a corresponding increase in deflationary manipulation in pro-eastern regions when the Party of Regions patronage network collapsed. Analysis of the models using the vote-share test results as a dependent variable, while only measuring one type of manipulation, provide further support for the principal-agent model based on patronage and risk. In those models, higher patronage consolidation around the Party of Regions led to a steep reduction in the number of suspicious precincts in pro-western regions; the subsequent breakdown resulted in increased fraud across the

⁷Note that the digits test results differ from those of the vote-share test presented here; the mean number of suspicious precincts per region using the vote-share test is approximately 10 percent.

board (with especially steep increases in the east).

In sum, election-forensic analysis shows that overall electoral manipulation and specific signatures of fraud both respond to shifts in local risks and national patronage consolidation in ways predicted by the model. The Ukrainian case allows for a test of the theory when patterns of patronage consolidation shift, while risk of agent exposure varies cross-nationally while remaining relatively fixed over time. Both cases demonstrate that the two factors can move independently, and interactive effect the level of election manipulation that parties can achieve.

Chapter 6

Crime and punishment: Courts and election manipulation in Russia

After the 2012 presidential election in Russia, legal records indicate, an election observer in Kemerovo Oblast¹ noted that election commissioners in three precincts had engaged in falsification of the election results, a violation of Article 142.1 of the Russian criminal code. To bring these matters to the attention of the authorities, the observer made a complaint to the regional investigative committee. Instead of opening a criminal investigation as required, the investigator subsequently forwarded the observer's complaint to the head of the Territorial Election Commission—an individual directly involved in the alleged falsification. After a period of months, the observer filed a civil suit against the investigative committee, seeking the initiation of a criminal investigation and monetary damages for 'moral harm'—physical and mental suffering as a result of the government's inaction. In a decision that came several years later, the court acknowledged that the observer's rights had been violated, and awarded him 1,000 rubles from the state treasury as compensation. It did not order that criminal proceedings against the election commissioners resume.¹

The above case is unusual in that the court agreed with the plaintiff and awarded damages—paltry as they may be.² However, it was typical in other ways. Civil suits against election commissions on the grounds of alleged falsification almost always fail; there is no record of even a single precinct's results being annulled in the dataset considered in this chapter. This is true despite the presence of observers in the polling place, whether the complainants are registered candidates and parties in the election, and even when election officials in those precincts have been convicted of

¹Decision in case No. 2-1946/2015 of the Central District Court of Novokuznetsk.

²1000 rubles was worth approximately \$20 at the time.

criminal falsification. When individuals are found criminally liable for election fraud, investigations go no further up the chain; individuals charged are often found to have been worked at the behest of “a group of unknown persons” or in pursuit of “a personal interest.” In other words, the Putin-era Russian judicial system works generally works to protect the ruling party’s interest with regard to elections.

This will come as no surprise to even the most casual of Russia watchers. However, the ruling party’s interest does not always align with the interests of its lowest-level agents. At times, precinct-level election commissioners—often teachers or other individuals subject to state pressure (Forrat 2018)—are charged with election-related crimes by the state prosecutor. As with other defendants in the Russian legal system (Solomon 2015a), these individuals are almost invariably found guilty. For some, the repercussions are minimal: a small fine and an end to the proceedings. For others, the consequences are very significant. In 2013, for example, a defendant was fined two hundred thousand rubles, equivalent to more than six months of the average national wage.³ Others are sentenced to jail time, though in the cases examined here such sentences are always converted to a period of probation (a status that nonetheless carries restrictions on the defendant’s liberty).

Does such ‘successful’ operation of the judicial system have an effect on the workings of Russia’s machinery of electoral manipulation? Election-manipulation efforts are characterized by principal-agent dynamics, in which party leaders and candidates enjoy the electoral benefit while low-level agents bear the risks (Harvey 2019; Rundlett & Svolik 2016). While most election-manipulation agents are clearly shielded from negative legal consequences—only 86 criminal cases for falsification appear in this dataset, which covers more than ten years—the very rarity of successful prosecutions may serve to amplify their effect among nearby agents.

To answer this question, this paper examines an original dataset of over 7,500 legal decisions in Russia, ranging from 2010 to 2021, that concern alleged administrative or criminal violations of electoral law. The text of these decisions was scraped from a Russian legal repository, SudAct.ru. The descriptive analysis shows that Russian courts regularly handle allegations of manipulation, even well into Vladimir Putin’s third and fourth terms as president: hundreds of administrative cases arise each year, in addition to dozens of criminal cases. Moreover, significant punishment of those accused is not uncommon—the mean size of fine imposed by the court is approximately 90,000 rubles, an amount equivalent to several months’ average income.

When combined with election-forensic data, a statistical analysis shows that court decisions are correlated with subsequent changes in election manipulation locally. Significant penalties for election-manipulating agents are followed by reductions in election fraud in the next election, while light penalties appear weakly associated with *increases* in subsequent fraud. This pattern suggests that local agents learn from both types of judicial outcomes; they are deterred when a judicial outcome shows significant negative consequences for lawbreaking, but appear emboldened when the courts appear to

³The average monthly wage in 2013 was approximately 29,800 according to the Russian State Statistical Service.

protect their compatriots. These patterns in the national data are also demonstrated in an analysis of court rulings and election forensic data from the Republic of Dagestan. Dagestan is an influential case because it is one of Russia's ethnic republics, which can be counted on to deliver fantastic results for the ruling party at election time. However, among that group of regions, Dagestan is also unusually diverse internally, raising the risk of exposure for agents. Taken together, this chapter provides qualitative and quantitative evidence in support of the agent-risk mechanism at work in the regime-strength model of election manipulation.

6.1 Literature review: Courts and election manipulation in non-democracies

Researchers have increasingly come to recognize the important roles that independently functioning courts can play in authoritarian systems. Courts that can, at times, act to restrain the government or to impartially resolve disputes among citizens serve an important legitimization function. Such judicial systems help bolster claims to rule of law, whatever other democratic shortcomings may be present (Moustafa 2008; Whiting 2017). In the Russian case, for example, the low-level justice-of-the-peace courts regularly rule against the state in cases with little political salience (Hendley 2017), and there is a general perception among both users and non-users of the judicial system that the courts are fair (Hendley 2016). More independent courts can also rein in low-level agents of the state, creating accountability for excesses when needed (Ginsburg 2008), and can help the regime collect information and monitor discontent (Ríos-Figueroa & Aguilar 2018). Owing to these and other benefits (Ma 2017; Sievert 2018), many non-democratic regimes have instituted reforms that improve courts' *de jure* independence (Staton *et al.* 2020).

Nevertheless, it would be naively optimistic to assume that even *de jure* independent courts are always *de facto* independent in non-democracies. Governments and ruling parties have many tools with which they can intervene in specific cases to ensure favorable outcomes. At a formal level, ruling parties may split the judicial system into a more independent channel for mundane cases, and more a dependent channel for politically charged cases (Toharia 1974). Such visible, constitutional structures are not always necessary however. Informal techniques—social pressure, physical threats and violence, or bribes—can be used to selectively influence judges' decisions (Ledeneva 2008; Llanos *et al.* 2016; Popova 2012; Solomon 2010; Taylor 2014; Wang 2020).

The product of these two elements—a generally independent court system for most cases combined with sometimes-unpredictable informal intervention by authorities—has many benefits for the political elite. However, it does mean that low-level agents are sometimes entangled in judicial proceedings for following the orders of their political superiors (or for doing what many other agents do in order to advance in the system). If these agents have broken the law, they may find themselves subject to conviction, fines, probation, or even prison time. These outcomes can occur due to the routine operation of the judicial system absent explicit pressure from outside, or due to strategic decisions

by elites to allow some agents to face punishment in order to improve the regime's legitimacy. In other words, a system designed to improve stability for the regime as a whole carries risks for individual low-level agents on whom the regime relies.

These risks are exacerbated by the fact that the existence of a semi-independent judiciary creates an arena of contestation for opposition groups to engage the ruling party. Opposition groups, candidates, and citizens with electoral grievances have several possible incentives for taking an election-related case to court, even if they think of the odds of success as dim. Court cases can be used to bargain for concessions with the ruling party (Chernykh 2014), to raise publicity around an issue [Dotan & Hofnung (2005);], or to lodge a protest against the authorities through a 'legitimate' channel (Dor & Hofnung 2006). Merely taking the case to court can send a signal that the litigant—for example, a defeated candidate—has credible evidence of electoral malpractice (Kerr & Wahman 2021). As a result, there is the potential that a variety of actors may seek to observe electoral violations, bring them to the attention of the legal authorities, and push for a case in court. For example, in the legal records studied here, there are several examples of defeated candidates, losing parties, and concerned citizens bringing civil suits before the courts, demanding that the local investigative committee open criminal investigations into alleged instances of election malfeasance.

Indeed, courts regularly address electoral violations (Birch & Van Ham 2017). There are often multiple ways that the legal system as a whole can address alleged electoral violations, and as such, multiple avenues through which opposition actors or civil society groups may attempt to redress their grievances (Orozco-Henríquez *et al.* 2010). Civil courts can order recounts or nullify contested election results (Chernykh 2014), administrative courts may impose penalties on representatives of the state (i.e. election commissioners) for failures to follow procedures, while criminal courts may impose the most serious penalties for criminal violations of the law.

In most non-democracies, which typically rely on civil codes rather than common law, the ordinary courts' jurisdiction over electoral issues covers violations of the law rather than the constitutionality of the law itself. As a result, this study is concerned with courts' role in policing illegal forms of electoral manipulation—in particular, the falsification of election results. Other forms of manipulation that courts may consider include ballot-stuffing, voter pressure, or intimidation—which are always illegal—or legal techniques improperly applied, such as selective enforcement of ballot-access rules (Bækken 2015; Popova 2012). This project does not investigate what role non-democratic courts may play, if any, in regulating the formal rules of electoral competition (e.g. electoral district boundaries).

Generally speaking, there are three schools of thought concerning the effect that independent courts may have on the integrity of elections in non-democracies. The first of these argues that court cases themselves reveal information about the fairness of elections, raising the risk of post-election protest. Fearing these protests, ruling parties in countries with more independent courts are less able to manipulate freely (Chernykh & Svolik 2015). A second approach considers that ruling parties are more likely to apply pressure to courts around competitive elections, helping to enable election manipulation in those circumstances (Popova 2012). Finally, a third approach argues that the

judicial system creates risks for election-manipulating agents on the front lines (Harvey 2022a), which intensifies principal-agent problems inherent in the effort to rig elections (Rundlett & Svolik 2016) and limits manipulation.

Most of these prior studies share a key limitation, however: they are studies of macro-level measures, with little insight into specific court cases or their effects. Popova's (2012) work is an exception, drawing as it does on case-level data. However, the data used in her studies are drawn from civil cases on ballot access (i.e. candidate registration or de-registration), rather than the criminal forms of manipulation, and are not used to study the impact of court rulings on subsequent election performance. This paper begins to address this limitation; in doing so, it helps evaluate the competing claims of the protest-centric vs. principal-agent focused theories of courts and electoral manipulation.

6.2 Criminal justice in the Russian legal system

While there have been some significant reforms to the judicial system in Russia since 2000, the general structure has remained mostly consistent. The lowest-level courts in Russia are the justice of the peace (JP) courts (*mirovye sudy*). Created in 2001 to address the least serious cases and to help relieve the case burden on the district courts, by 2007 the justice of the peace courts were hearing nearly half of all initial criminal cases and nearly 95 percent of all initial administrative cases (Hendley 2012). JP judges, like district court judges, hold life tenures. District courts are the first court of ordinary jurisdiction, and handle more complex cases at the first instance; they may also hear appeals from the JP courts. District court rulings may be heard by regional courts; the Supreme Court of the Russian Federation is the court of last resort in most matters. In 2019, an additional layer was introduced to this structure, with new appellate courts and cassation courts⁴ of general jurisdiction inserted between the regional courts and the Supreme Court.

The Russian criminal legal system is largely a 'neo-inquisitorial' one. Unlike the adversarial system utilized in common law countries, where the prosecution and the defense seek to establish the facts of the case before a judge or jury, much of the official fact-finding is carried out in a pre-trial phase. An officer of the state—such as a police officer, and investigator, or a judge—is meant to carry out an impartial examination of the facts of the case and to produce a written case file. The role of the trial judge is to confirm the facts in the file and to ensure that the proper legal procedures are followed. Reforms over the course of the 1990s and 2000s introduced some adversarial components, such as the presumption of innocence and the possibility of trial by jury, but the system remains largely inquisitorial and produces systematic accusatorial bias (Solomon Jr. 2015).

Reforms to the criminal code in 2001 allowed two new ways in which the accused could avoid a full trial: termination of the case (*prekrashchenie*) following a reconciliation between the parties, and a form of plea bargaining called 'special procedures' (*osobyi*

⁴Decisions of the appellate court may be appealed to the court of cassation, which reviews procedure, not evidence.

poriadok) (Hendley & Jr 2023). Under ‘special procedures,’ the defendant accepts guilt and waives the right of appeal, in exchange for the guarantee that his sentence will not be the harshest available in law. These processes have come to dominate the Russian criminal justice system. By 2013, only 8 percent of criminal defendants had full trials under ordinary procedure (Hendley & Jr 2023 p. 29). Since 2016, a third mechanism for terminating trials has been in place, in the form of the ‘judicial fine’ (*sudebnyi shtraf*), which can be applied in some non-violent crimes (Hendley & Jr 2023 p. 137).

Individuals can encounter two kinds of legal jeopardy in the Russian system. Crimes *per se* are defined in the Criminal Code (*ugolovnyi kodeks*) of the Russian Federation. Offences listed as crimes tend to be the most serious, and to carry the most severe penalties upon conviction. Individuals may also be accused of administrative offenses, which are defined in the Code of Administrative Offenses (*KoAP*). The penalty for administrative offenses is typically a fine, but can extend to 15 days imprisonment. Administrative offenses do not create a criminal record. Those convicted of a criminal offense face fines or imprisonment, though prison sentences are regularly converted into a ‘suspended sentence.’ Like parole elsewhere, the suspended sentence comes with conditions—such as regular check-ins with the police—that can result in the imposition of the real sentence if violated (Hendley & Jr 2023).

Criminal conviction can carry significant political, social, and economic penalties—even if the accused was not required to serve time in prison. These consequences, which can be lifelong, arise from other laws and regulations at the federal or regional level which place restrictions on those who have criminal records (Габдрахманов 2012). Those with criminal records can be barred from certain forms of state employment, especially those connected to national security, law enforcement, and finance. Of particular interest in the Russian case, where many front-line agents are low-level employees of the state—those with criminal records are prohibited from working in the fields of education or social services (Габдрахманов 2012).⁵ Those with criminal records may not serve as legal guardians, foster parents, or adoptive parents. Perhaps ironically, a criminal conviction also precludes one from serving as an election commissioner (Габдрахманов 2012). Those with current criminal records also face the likelihood of harsher sentencing should they be convicted of a subsequent crime.

Three articles of the criminal code relate to electoral malfeasance. Article 141 covers interference with a citizen’s right to vote, the secrecy of the ballot, or the work of an election commission. Article 142 covers falsification of election documents generally, while Article 142.1 covers a variety of tactics for falsifying the election result in particular (e.g. falsifying the count, ballot-stuffing, etc.). On the administrative side, Article 5 of the KoAP lays out 14 violations of electoral procedure that do not rise to the level of a crime. Notably, bribery of voters is included in this category (KoAP article 5.16).

⁵For some crimes, including many electoral crimes, even being subject to criminal investigation is enough to trigger this prohibition.

6.2.1 History and judicial independence

Russian courts are normally able to function independently, with judges reaching conclusions and assigning penalties in accordance with the facts and the law. However, there are important vulnerabilities in the system that can enable outside interests to tip the scales (Hendley & Jr 2023; Sakwa 2010). As Hendley and Solomon succinctly put it, the system of managing judges in Russia “encourages them to handle cases quickly, to anticipate the views of judges on higher courts (and sometime to consult them), and to do the chairman’s bidding” (Hendley & Jr 2023 p. 51). These points of weakness to outside pressure are in part legacies of the Soviet past and in part a feature of Putin-era reforms.

Newly independent Russia inherited a judicial system in which the autonomy of the courts had been minimal. For much of the Soviet period, judicial appointments required the approval of Party officials, with five-year terms of office. Courts’ financing was drawn largely from local budgets, meaning judges had strong incentives to stay on good terms with local Party officials. Judges’ role was to follow political expediency as needed, while maintaining a facade of neutrality (Solomon 2008). The procuracy, responsible for prosecutions and legal supervision of local and provincial governments, answered to the central government (Solomon 1996). In turn, criminal investigators were subordinate to the procuracy (Solomon 1996). Local party bosses could use their influence and control over local resources, however, to put pressure on courts and procurators to target some local actors with prosecution while protecting others (Solomon 1996 p. 290).

Efforts to strengthen judicial independence began in the late 1980s, when terms of office were extended to 10 years and the creation of judicial qualification commissions (made up solely of judges) to screen judicial candidates and review cases of rule on cases of judicial termination (Solomon 2008). Early in its independence, Russia extended life tenure to judges while retaining the judicial qualifying commissions (Solomon 2008). These commissions continue to have important roles in screening candidates for judicial office, as well as for promotion to higher courts. New judges are largely recruited from within the courts themselves, having served as court secretaries or judicial assistants. As a result, and due to the preliminary role of the judicial qualifying commissions in appointing judges, judges tend to be very familiar with the operation of the courts and the norms by which they operate (Hendley & Jr 2023).

Another legacy of the Soviet system is the powerful position of the chair of a district court. Soviet-era court presidents were appointed by the district soviet, and were empowered to assign cases to judges of the court and to direct the administrative work of the court (Berman 1972 p. 341). Since Soviet judges’ careers were influenced by individual statistics—the speed with which they closed cases and the size of their case backlog among them (Solomon 1996 p. 282)—the district court president could exercise considerable influence over his fellows. Even in post-Soviet Russia, the court chairman was responsible for distributing benefits to judges—not just allocation of vacation time, but also access to an apartment and social services (Solomon & Foglesong 2000). Higher courts exercise considerable influence over judges on lower courts as

well, through evaluations and rankings that can be tied to promotions and bonuses (Solomon & Foglesong 2000).

In Putin-era Russia, the district court chair remains influential; in addition to the ‘carrots’ court chairs have always wielded, they are also empowered to request the judicial qualifying commission impose disciplinary measures on judges within their courts (Hendley & Jr 2023). Disciplinary measures, whether imposed by a court chair in a regular court or alleged by the president of a member of a high court, can be brought up on vague or pretextual charges. In one well-known instance, a Moscow court chairman initiated disciplinary proceedings against a prominent court reformer and judge after the latter failed to complete the writing a verdict before leaving the court to attend a lecture (Hendley & Jr 2023 p. 53). In turn, court chairs’ terms were reduced from a *de facto* life appointment to two six-year terms (Hendley & Jr 2023), giving them professional incentives to respond to pressure from higher authorities. All told, the court chair remains a central node in outside efforts to put pressure on judges (Ledeneva 2008).

While the court chairs have tools to influence their courts, individual judges are also exposed to direct influence from the Supreme Court and the Presidential Administration (Hendley & Jr 2023). Reforms between 2009 and 2013—including a *de facto* purge of members of the Russian Supreme Court—brought the higher echelons of the judiciary more directly under the influence of the presidential administration (Hendley & Jr 2023). This shift to presidential control intensified with the constitutional reforms of 2020, which empowered the president to remove any judge on the Supreme and Constitutional Courts and on any of the appeals and cassation courts, subject only to the approval of the Federation Council⁶ The judiciary’s former role in policing itself, via the Supreme Court and High Judicial Qualifying Commission, was removed (Hendley & Jr 2023 pp. 36–37).

6.2.2 Authoritarian incentives and implications for electoral crimes

Police, investigators, prosecutors, and judges all face career incentive to ‘solve’ crimes quickly. At each step in the process, the authorities evaluate the relevant actor based on a set of statistics, which include the number of cases handled and their clearance rate: the proportion of cases successfully passed on to the next actor in the chain. Each can also be punished for ‘failures’—instances in which their decision on a case is overturned. This creates a system whereby the individuals at each stage of this ‘assembly line’ have incentives to process the case in a way that suits the next actor’s interests (Paneyakh 2014). As a result, each type of actor tends to rely on the same set of strategies: selecting easy cases, faking documents, and cutting procedural corners to save time (Paneyakh 2014).

An informal backward induction reveals the sorts of cases that are likely to come before a court as a result. Judges want to clear cases quickly and to avoid their decisions

⁶The upper house of Russia’s legislature, its members are selected by the regional governments. Since these regional governments are themselves mostly in the hands of the ruling party, the Federation Council is a highly pliant legislative body (Noble & Chaisty 2022).

being overturned. Consequently, they welcome clear-cut cases. At the previous step, the investigator has the discretion to accept a case compiled by the police or not. If accepted, however, the case must eventually go before a judge. To avoid having the case returned—or worse, an acquittal—the investigator will only accept cases from the police that will pass muster with the judge (e.g. where the evidence is clear, where the facts of the case fit a standard profile, etc.). Knowing this, the police have strong incentives only to *generate* such cases. That is, they will avoid opening cases where the perpetrator is unknown and a thorough investigation will be costly in time and resources (Paneyakh 2014). More complicated cases are likely to stay on the police department's books; a demerit at evaluation time. "Absent a suspect who can be accused of a crime, in practice police do not open a case unless there is a...vocal complainant" (Solomon 2015b p. 21). Paneyakh's (2014) qualitative research suggests only a third to one-tenth of the criminal complaints referred to police by citizens are formally registered.

Once ensnared in the criminal justice system, defendants' likelihood of emerging unscathed is low. By 2008, less than one percent of criminal cases ended in functional acquittals—0.2 percent of cases ending in true acquittal, and 0.5 percent of cases terminated by reconciliation (Solomon 2015b). Even acquittal by the court, a very rare outcome, is limited protection; in 2008, roughly a quarter of acquittals were overturned or changed (Paneyakh 2014).

In sum, the criminal-legal system in Russia is such that it exposes some perpetrators of election crimes to significant risk. Specifically, those that are perpetrated by known individuals, can be observed at the moment they occur, and are easily legible to the court represent easy targets for the system. Police who observe or are shown evidence of such behavior have positive incentives to pursue the case; investigators have incentives to present the case to the court; judges have incentives to convict. These are the kind of 'highly attributable' behaviors discussed in Chapter 2; in general, they encompass blatant manipulation by election officials (e.g. falsification, ballot stuffing). Other kinds of perpetrators will be systematically overlooked by the criminal-legal system. The organizers of vote-buying, voter pressure, and multiple voting-rings for instance, do not meet the criteria that police, investigators, and judges are looking for. Some activities, like vote-buying and multiple-voting, occur at various places and times, organized by unknown or pseudonymous individuals. Others, like voter pressure by employers, involve known individuals but require significant investigative resources to make legible as crimes for the court (and run the risk of being overturned).

At the same time, aspects of the system that reduce judicial independence create opportunities for more highly placed members of the election-manipulating network to avoid negative consequences. The business interests participating in voter pressure schemes may, if needed, be able to lean on the court chairman to make their preference in the case known. The city councilor or mid-ranking member of the ruling party who disburses the funds for vote-buying will likewise have allies who can help ensure the operation of 'telephone law.' More likely, however, cases against such individuals are never initiated by police and investigators who know that they will likely face negative repercussions from their superiors and from the next actor in the criminal justice process. At the highest level, the principals at the top of the network benefit from this

system, which a) maintains the integrity of all but the lowest rungs of the network, and b) bolsters the domestic credibility of the election by demonstrating that the criminal justice system ‘appropriately’ handles electoral misdeeds when they do occur. Thus the people who are most exposed to the risks of election manipulation are the very people the regime relies on to carry it out; at times, it will be difficult to recruit individuals willing to undertake that risk.

[Note to add: As Popova documents, incumbents in less competitive settings may allow more independent operation of the courts on political issues. As a result—though agents may be less likely to be *exposed* in uncompetitive environments—the probability of conviction conditional on exposure may actually increase as political competitiveness declines.]

6.3 Theory: Criminal risk of election manipulation

When a ruling party seeks to manipulate an election using illegal techniques, it must recruit large numbers of front-line agents to carry out the work of falsifying the count, stuffing the ballot boxes, or applying pressure to voters. As identified by Rundlett and Svolik (2016) these efforts combine the challenges of a principal-agent relationship with a coordination problem. The political leaders at the top of the system derive a direct benefit from the manipulated vote totals, in the form of padded margins of victory and/or signals of organizational strength that can secure compliance for other actors in the system (Magaloni 2006; Simpser 2013). Their low-level agents, on the other hand, derive an indirect benefit in the form of patronage rewards for fulfilling their assigned tasks. However, agents’ actions to inflate the ruling party’s vote are likely to be covert and difficult for their patrons to accurately evaluate. This fact, combined with the risks of exposure that may be attendant with breaking the law, create incentives for agents to shirk—accepting patronage rewards while applying minimal effort to manipulating the vote. In areas where the risk of exposure is sufficiently high, agents will be unwilling to engage in the most detectable forms of fraud, and instead shift to less detectable techniques like vote-buying (Harvey 2019). Unfortunately for ruling parties, such techniques are even more prone to diversion of resources by agents (Szwarcberg 2014).

Agents’ expectations of patronage benefits become more secure the more confident they are that their political patron will win the election (Hale 2014), an estimation that depends in part on the actions of other election-manipulating agents (Rundlett & Svolik 2016). If agents believe that others like them are likely to be deterred from engaging in manipulation, they are likely to hold back themselves—a self-reinforcing cycle. Legal risks can be part of this calculation (Harvey 2022a). A more independent judiciary creates incentives for opposition actors and citizens to monitor elections and attempt to hold election manipulators to account. If agents fear prosecution and conviction, they may be more likely to shirk or otherwise avoid tampering with the election; expecting this, other agents in turn become more reluctant to engage in manipulation. The consequence, as Harvey (2022a) finds using macro-level data, is an improvement in election integrity.

Table 6.1: Criminal election violations

Criminal code	Description
141	Obstruction of electoral rights or the work of the electoral commission
141.1	Financial violations
142	Falsification of election documents
142.1	Falsification of results
142.2	Unlawful giving or receiving of ballots

Here, I focus on the effect that convictions in election-related cases can have on election fraud in the area under the court’s jurisdiction. A conviction for election fraud may influence election-manipulating agents’ cost-benefit calculation in several ways. First, such a conviction may send a signal to opposition actors that a vigorous prosecution of election crimes is possible in the region, increasing the incentive for those actors to monitor polling places and record evidence of possible crimes with the intention of going to court. The heightened risk of prosecution due to a more optimistic opposition should reduce agents’ incentives to participate in manipulation efforts. Second, a conviction sends a signal directly to agents that the ruling party is unable or unwilling to provide blanket protection for them in the area. This may be due to the regime’s desire to improve its rule-of-law based legitimacy, or due to fragmentation within the local elite. In any event, it heightens the risk of participation for the agent, which should similarly lead to reduced manipulation.

There is an important caveat to this expectation, however. When convicted election manipulators receive a very light penalty (or the accused are simply acquitted), the opposite signal is sent to opposition actors and agents. Acquittals or ‘slaps on the wrist’ indicate that even when agents face the worst outcome—being compelled to appear before a court to answer for their alleged actions—the ruling party and the legal system will protect them. Such an outcome should reduce opposition groups’ incentive to go to court (though not eliminate it), and reduce agents’ perception of legal risk. As a result, light penalties and acquittals should have the effect of *increasing* fraud in the subsequent election. There are thus two hypotheses for this study:

H1: The application of a severe penalty for convicted election manipulators should be associated with reduced election fraud in the court’s region in the subsequent election.

H2: The application of a light penalty for convicted election manipulators should be associated with increased election fraud in the court’s region in the subsequent election.

6.4 Data and methods

The source of the data collected for this project is the online database SudAct (<https://sudact.ru>), which claims to include ‘all published judicial documents’ from ‘all courts included in the Russian judicial system.’ To collect the dataset, the author conducted au-

Table 6.2: Administrative election violations

Administrative code	Description
5.1	Violation of citizens' right to inspect electoral documents
5.11	Campaigning by prohibited persons
5.12	Illegal production or distribution of campaign materials
5.14	Destruction of property related to elections
5.16	Bribery of voters
5.17	Failure to provide financial reports
5.18	Illegal use of funds for a campaign
5.19	Illegal material support for a campaign
5.2	Failure to comply with directions of the electoral commission
5.21	Untimely transfer of funds to election commissions
5.22	Illegal issuance or receipt of ballots
5.23	Concealment of excess ballots
5.24	Violation of the procedure for counting votes and determining results
5.25	Failure to provide information about results
5.3	Failure to comply with decision of the EC
5.4	Violation of submitting information about voters etc
5.5	Violation of mass media procedures
5.6	Violation of the rights of an EC member
5.7	Refusal to grant leave to vote
5.8	Other media issues
5.9	Advertising
5.10	Campaigning violations
5.20	Illegal financing of a campaign or candidate

tomated webscraping of SudAct’s online search interface, after specifying the particular legal codes listed in Tables 1 and 2. The text of judicial decisions was only collected if there were more than 10 rulings under a given legal code over the period studied. There are limitations to this approach; most importantly, the SudAct database only contains cases going back to 2010. As a result, we cannot examine the behavior of the Russian court system during the consolidation of the Putin system in the early 2000s. Instead, the data allows for a study of judicial outcomes from a period of relative ‘thaw’ (the last year of the Medvedev presidency) through the harshening authoritarian consolidation of Vladimir Putin’s third and fourth terms. It is also not possible to know which cases, if any, were concluded by courts without being published (and thus unavailable to SudAct). Nevertheless, this first-of-its-kind dataset does provide insight into the general distribution of cases, as well as considerable qualitative detail concerning how these cases are decided.

As Figure 6.1 shows, criminal cases (legal codes 141, 142, and 142.1, at the top of the bars) make up a small proportion of election integrity cases that come before the courts. The vast majority are administrative cases. In most years, the most common administrative violation comes under Article 5.12 of the Code of Administrative Violations, (illegal production or distribution of campaign materials), Article 5.10 (campaigning outside the campaign period or in illegal places), and Article 5.17 (failure to provide campaign finance documents). It is also plain to see that administrative cases have steadily declined after the year 2016; criminal cases continue at roughly the same pace, as shown in Figure 6.2. Most cases in the dataset involve a single defendant, but in some cases multiple individuals are tried together. The total number of criminal defendants tried under Article 142.1, the focus here, is 82; a further 135 respondents were brought to court under the civil or administrative code.

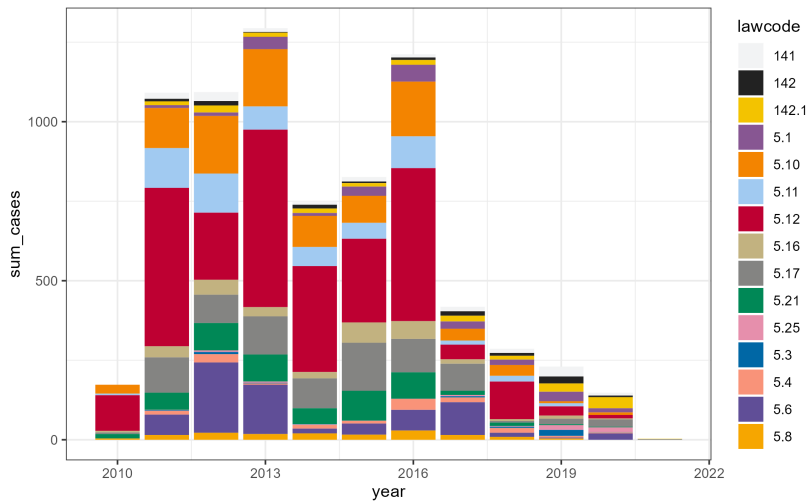


Figure 6.1: All cases by year

In this paper, I focus on the relationship between conviction and punishment for the

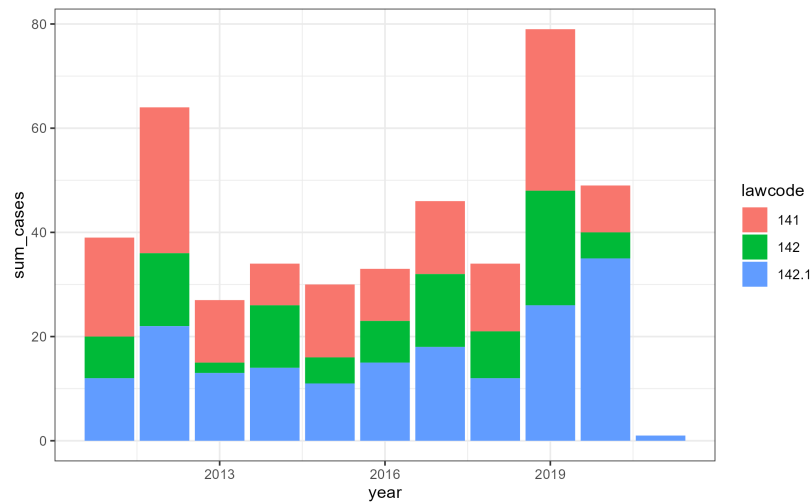


Figure 6.2: Criminal cases by year

criminal violation of falsifying results (Article 142.1) and subsequent levels of election fraud. To conduct the study, I hand-coded the 225 cases adjudicated under Article 142.1 for the outcome of the case (among other factors). Despite the absence of any acquittals in the dataset, outcomes do vary. Out of 101 criminal cases in the dataset⁷, 66 end in fines for the defendant. Defendants were sentenced to jail time in 15 cases, though in all 15 the sentence was suspended (analogous to probation in the US system). In four cases, defendants were amnestied in honor of the 70th anniversary of Soviet victory in World War II. Other criminal cases were at an intermediate stage; for example, a court might rule that a lower court should take up the case a second time. As Figure 6.3 shows, the most common fine was a small one—on the order of a few thousand rubles. Despite this, the mean fine was approximately 90,000 rubles, driven by a substantial number of much larger fines.

I construct a small number of measures of the severity of a penalty, in an attempt to capture this disparity. All are binary variables. First, I code any fine greater than 50,000 rubles as a significant fine, and any value below that threshold as a minor fine. This threshold is selected as it amounts to about one month's average salary by the end of the data collection period. Second, I create an additional dummy variable for cases where the defendant was sentenced to prison time. Lastly, I create dummy variables for 'major penalties' which takes on a value of one if a sentence of either a major fine or jail time was handed down, and 'minor penalties,' which takes on a value of one for small fines and amnesties.

Region-years are considered to have been 'treated' under any of these coding rules if such a sentence was applied in the period prior to a given election. That is, if an

⁷The remaining cases were civil suits brought, often seeking the annulment of elections following incidents of falsification

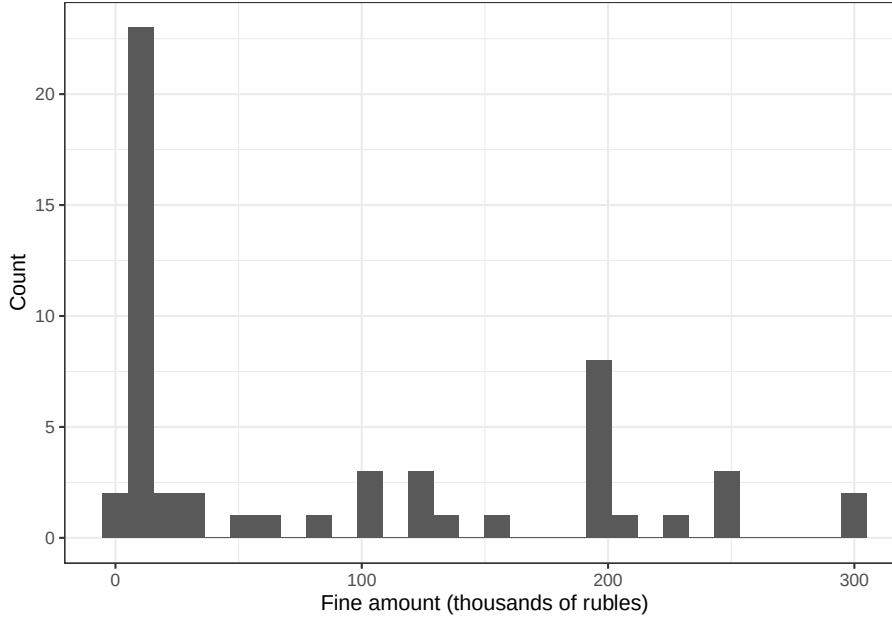


Figure 6.3: Distribution of fine amounts

individual in Moscow region has been sentenced to a large fine in 2013, Moscow region would be considered treated for the 2016 election, but not the 2012 or 2018 elections. I do not allow ‘treatment’ to carry beyond the next election on the assumption that once a new election happens, agents will update their understanding of risk based on the presence or absence of any large penalties following the new election. This binary ‘treatment’ variable based on large fines in the region prior to a given election serves as the main explanatory variable.

The dependent variable for this study is an election-forensic variable adopted from work by Skovoroda & Lankina (2017), who use a statistical measure of deviance in the distribution of last digits in precinct-level election results to estimate election fraud by region. In particular, I focus here on deviance in the number of precincts where the results for the ruling party (United Russia in legislative elections and Vladimir Putin in presidential ones) end in zero. The deviance formula is

$$Deviance_{0,i} = 2(O_{i0} \log(\frac{O_{i0}}{0.1n_i}) + (n_i - O_{i0}) \log(\frac{(n_i - O_{i0})}{.9n_i}))$$

where $Deviance_{0,i}$ refers to the region-level deviance in last-digit zeroes, O_{i0} indicates the total number of zeroes in the region, and n_i refers to the number of polling places in the region. The deviance variable increases as the number of last-digits zeroes in the region deviates from the expected value of ten percent (zero is one of ten possible values the trailing digit can take). It will be important to control for the number of precincts in the region in the regression models, since increasing the sample size may

increase deviance simply due to the increased statistical power of the test (Skovoroda & Lankina 2017). In the regression models below, I use both the raw measure of deviance and its log, due to the non-normal distribution of the raw variable. The models are standard OLS models, with two-way fixed effects for election-year and region. This adjusts for any time-invariant confounders by region (such as each region's status as an ordinary region or an often less-competitive titular republic), as well as for nationwide shifts in political competitiveness over time.

In addition, as a placebo treatment test (Eggers *et al.* 2023), I also test for the impact of convictions for a separate electoral crime—Article 5.16 of the administrative code, which prohibits vote-buying—on fraud. There should be no expectation of an effect for administrative vote-buying convictions on evidence of fraud for at least three reasons. First, vote-buying agents are typically drawn from different networks than those tasked with falsification. The latter are typically public employees, such as teachers, who have been pressed into service as precinct election commissioners. The former, in the Russian case, tend to either be individuals in supervisory roles who can dole out negative inducements (Frye *et al.* 2018) or individuals handing out small positive inducements (e.g. cash, vodka, small gifts) on the street. Anecdotally, it is this second type of individual who appears in the courts, with little indication in the legal record of where their resources or sense of initiative came from. It is less likely that convictions for such individuals will inform decision-making by the largely professional civil-service class associated with low-level falsification.

Second, vote-buying remains a somewhat stochastic process: the number of bought votes that end up counting in the sponsor's column will vary according to many of the same factors that affect the distribution of un-bought votes, including weather, illness, and so on. Moreover, once in the privacy of the voting booth, many vote-sellers renege on their bargain and vote their conscience (Nichter 2008). As a result, the success or failure of vote-buying efforts should not meaningfully affect the distribution of trailing digits in ways that the deviance measure will detect. Third and finally, the penalty for violating Article 5.16 on vote-buying is relatively low; most defendants receive a fine of 20,000 rubles. Consequently, there is good reason to expect a null result for recent convictions for vote-buying on subsequent estimations of fraud. A significant correlation, on the other hand, would undermine confidence in any significant findings for convictions under Article 142.1 by suggesting that other factors—perhaps correlated with the general functioning of the legal system—were at work.

6.5 Qualitative and quantitative results

Some general qualitative findings are discussed below, followed by the results of the statistical models.

6.5.1 General qualitative findings

Some general qualitative data can also be extracted from the coded cases. First, and perhaps most importantly for the continued smooth functioning of the machinery of

electoral manipulation, organizers and higher-level perpetrators of election fraud are never called to criminal account in the cases examined here. Defendants are universally members of precinct electoral commissions, the lowest level of election administration in Russia and the ones with direct contact with voters. There are no members of higher level electoral commissions charged, despite their frequent presence in observers' reports. For example, a search for "Territorial election commission" on the crowdsourced election observation website <https://www.kartanarusheniy.org/>, a project of Russia's only major independent election monitoring civil society group, yields over 1300 complaints. Yet when the regional and territorial election commissions appear in the legal records examined here, they appear only as oblique references rather than as defendants. In one typical instance⁸, for example, the chairperson of a precinct election commission charged with falsification is accused of having acted

... out of greed and other personal interest, with a view to obtaining additional material payments by giving the [Territorial Election Commission] leadership a favorable impression of her organization and conduct of the elections, to ensure a high voter turnout on the day of his election, and to increase the results of voting for a party to which she is more sympathetic...

How the defendant may have come to the conclusion that she would be rewarded financially for improving turnout and the vote-share for a particular party is left, by the judge, as an exercise for the reader. This kind of phrasing is not unusual in cases where any kind of motive is ascribed to the defendants. In other cases, no motive at all is ascribed. In this way, the judicial system serves to protect the more central nodes in the election manipulation process. Successful prosecution of such higher-level individuals would likely result in much more severe breakdown in the manipulation process, as they are responsible for assigning targets to lower-level actors, monitoring their performance, and at times engaging in direct, wholesale manipulation themselves.

In addition to protecting higher-level individuals, it appears anecdotally that prosecution is more likely in low-level elections than in high-profile federal ones. While cases in the dataset deal with violations during presidential or State Duma elections, a larger number are concerned with regional or local elections. For example, a large number of cases in the dataset—18 out of 225—were generated by a local referendum in a small town in Kirovskaya Oblast'. The question at hand was whether the city would impose a small tax duty—300 rubles per person—to fund infrastructure improvements. The convicted individuals, some of whom were found to have forged ballots in favor of the proposal and some against, were generally sentenced to small fines.⁹ This pattern may indicate that the exposure of a large number of individuals came as a result of divisions among local elites. Given the likelihood that national elections are subject to greater manipulative pressure due to their higher stakes, and the greater degree of patronage centralization at higher levels, it is reasonable to suspect that the system goes to greater efforts to protect agents in federal elections than in local ones.

⁸Case number 1-146/2016, Chelyabinskaya Oblast'

⁹Excluding this large cluster of cases from the main analysis does not meaningfully change the results in Tables 3 and 4.

These general impressions could be considered supportive of the broader claim that, while the judicial system does generate risk for election-manipulating agents, the ruling party takes measures to protect it agents where it is able and willing to do so. Intermediate and high-level agents in the chain of actors needed to manipulate elections appear to be shielded even from prosecution, much less conviction. And it appears that agents in local and regional elections are more at risk than agents acting in national elections. Nevertheless, individual agents cannot be fully certain that they will be protected, should opposition candidates or civil society groups seek to make a judicial case out of their illegal actions.

6.5.2 Statistical model results

The results of these regression models are shown in Tables 6.3 and 6.4, which present the results for raw and log deviance, respectively. Both sets of models include fixed effects for regions as well as for years, although the former are not presented in order to keep the tables legible. The results offer some cautious support for both hypotheses, with greater support for H1 on the negative effect of strong penalties. Models 1 and 2 show that court cases which end in large fines for defendants are associated with statistically significant reduction in falsification in the subsequent election. The size of this effect is quite significant substantively—about half the size of one standard deviation of the fraud measure. Model 3 shows that the ‘major penalty’ measure, which combines large fines and jail time, is also associated with a sizable and statistically significant decrease in fraud. The coefficient for small fines, shown in Model 2, has the predicted, positive sign but falls short of the conventional threshold for statistical significance.

The results in Table 3 should be interpreted cautiously, however, since the non-normal distribution of the raw dependent variables makes the models susceptible to the influence of outliers. In particular, the Dagestani case is highly influential, as it exhibits extremely high levels of deviance in some years and is one of the ‘treated’ regions. Transforming the dependent variable by taking its logarithm allows for a more normal distribution better suited linear regression models. Table 4 presents these results, which are more muted. In these models, small fines do not show a statistically significant relationship with subsequent fraud. Large fines retain their negative coefficient, but the effect size is far smaller and not statistically significant. In these models, however, prison sentences have a significant and negative effect. The size of the effect of a prison sentence in Model 5 is substantively significant, at roughly the size of one standard deviation of the logged dependent variable. The coefficient for major penalties, while negative, is not statistically significant at the conventional level.

Lastly, the placebo tests in Models 4 and 8 indicate that the significant findings in the other models can be interpreted with greater confidence. As expected, convictions and fines for vote-buying offenses appear to have no correlation with subsequent election fraud. This suggests that only convictions related to falsification influence future fraud, helping support the theory of deterrence outlined here.

Table 6.3: OLS models of last-digit deviance with country-fixed effects

	Model 1	Model 2	Model 3	Model 4
Number of precincts	−0.0004 (0.002)	−0.0006 (0.002)	−0.0005 (0.002)	−0.0008 (0.002)
Jail time		−1.784 (1.139)		
Large fine	−1.686* (0.731)	−1.790* (0.788)		
Small fine		1.562+ (0.860)		
Number of defendants	0.044 (0.166)	0.160 (0.227)	0.228 (0.200)	
Major penalty			−1.911* (0.755)	
Fine (vote-buying)				−0.685 (0.577)
N. of defendants (vote-buying)				−0.045 (0.106)
2012	−0.322 (0.385)	−0.365 (0.385)	−0.387 (0.385)	−0.340 (0.386)
2016	0.684+ (0.392)	0.699+ (0.390)	0.617 (0.388)	0.755+ (0.407)
2018	−0.464 (0.386)	−0.440 (0.384)	−0.465 (0.385)	−0.483 (0.387)
2020	−0.097 (0.387)	−0.165 (0.387)	−0.151 (0.384)	−0.263 (0.385)
2021	0.0002 (0.385)	0.025 (0.384)	−0.028 (0.384)	−0.032 (0.386)
Num.Obs.	510	510	510	510
R2	0.525	0.531	0.526	0.522
R2 Adj.	0.416	0.421	0.417	0.412

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Table 6.4: OLS models of logged last-digit deviance with country-fixed effects

	Model 5	Model 6	Model 7	Model 8
Number of precincts	−0.0004 (0.002)	−0.0005 (0.002)	−0.0005 (0.002)	−0.0007 (0.002)
Jail time		−2.378* (0.965)		
Large fine	−0.559 (0.620)	−1.129+ (0.668)		
Small fine		−0.181 (0.729)		
Number of defendants	−0.109 (0.141)	0.205 (0.192)	0.054 (0.169)	
Major penalty			−1.243+ (0.639)	
Fine (vote-buying)				−0.455 (0.488)
N. of defendants (vote-buying)				0.068 (0.090)
2012	−0.050 (0.326)	−0.133 (0.326)	−0.093 (0.326)	−0.056 (0.327)
2016	0.214 (0.332)	0.200 (0.331)	0.212 (0.328)	0.189 (0.344)
2018	−0.531 (0.327)	−0.536 (0.326)	−0.514 (0.326)	−0.559+ (0.327)
2020	0.185 (0.328)	0.130 (0.328)	0.187 (0.325)	0.108 (0.326)
2021	0.562+ (0.326)	0.529 (0.325)	0.548+ (0.325)	0.561+ (0.327)
Num.Obs.	510	510	510	510
R2	0.273	0.284	0.278	0.271
R2 Adj.	0.106	0.115	0.113	0.104

+ $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

6.6 The case of Dagestan

Dagestan is an influential case in the statistical analysis, but is this influence a statistical anomaly or is it plausibly a result of the causal process considered here? While the evidence is circumstantial, a close reading of the relevant court cases and an examination of the district involved are broadly supportive of the theory. Dagestan reports a very large change in its overall deviance from the expected last-digit distribution between the 2016 parliamentary election and the 2018 presidential election: from 49.6 to 9.2.¹⁰ In between those elections, a precinct election commission chairman (who is unnamed in the court documents) was convicted of falsifying election returns in his precinct by a district court and sentenced to a large fine—200,000 rubles. This is a very substantial sentence in a region where the average monthly salary in 2017 was under 18,000 rubles.¹¹ After being convicted by the district court, the precinct chairman twice appealed his case to the Supreme Court of Dagestan, which upheld his conviction and sentence in both cases.

Dagestan is one of Russia's 21 titular republics, regions which nominally hold significant autonomy from the center due to historical legacies of ethnic politics, but in practice are tightly integrated under the Kremlin's 'power vertical' (White & Saikkonen 2017). As a titular republic in the Caucasus region, Dagestan is often considered together with highly centralized regions like neighboring Chechnya and Ingushetia, and while all these regions typically deliver overwhelming victories for the ruling party in national elections, their internal politics are quite different. Where Chechnya, for example, is a relatively homogeneous region that has been ruled as a near personal fiefdom under Ramzan Kadyrov (Tolstrup & Souleimanov 2022), Dagestan is extremely ethnically diverse and politically more pluralist. Dagestan is home to more than thirty officially recognized ethnic groups; about thirty percent of the population belong to the largest single ethnic group, the Avars. Ethnic Dargins, the second largest group, account for another sixteen percent of the population, followed by Kumiks (15.6%) and Lezgins (13.1%). Numerous, smaller ethnic groups account for the remaining quarter of the population.¹² This complex social environment is further complicated by the region's mountainous terrain, which contributes to geographic fragmentation among these ethnic groups.

Dagestanis have managed this complexity, both in pre- and post-Soviet times, in part through the institution of the *djamaat*: a community of historically connected villages which is headed by a council of local elders drawn from the various extended family groupings in the area. Djamaat leaders exercise authority within their communities, resolve cross-community disputes, and form political alliances with out-group leaders. This structure was the informal basis for Dagestan's first post-Soviet constitution, which had explicit consociational features (Ware & Kisriev 2001). This consociational system was dismantled through constitutional reforms at the behest of the Putin government, along with its ethnicity-based regional parties. Local elites now depend on the federal state for their political survival and to accomplish their aims, rather than on conso-

¹⁰This is still quite high—the average deviance across the whole dataset is 1.5.

¹¹Data taken from the Russian State Statistical Service's data portal at <https://showdata.gks.ru/finder/>.

¹²Ethnic data taken from the 2020 Russian census: <https://rosstat.gov.ru/vpn/2020>.

ciational bargaining (Ware & Kisriev 2014). United Russia is the dominant regional political party, typically capturing three-quarters of the vote in regional elections. As a result, much intra- and inter-ethnic competition is relegated to behind-the-scenes conflicts to win the right to represent United Russia (or the state more broadly) from higher level authorities (Kapustina 2016; Ware 2005).

Case number 1-35/2017 of the Kaytagskii district court, decided on September 4, 2017, took place in this context of behind-the-scenes competition. The names of all the figures in the case are redacted, which makes a precise accounting of the events difficult to reconstruct, but the general contours are these. During the 2016 election for the Dagestan regional legislature, the defendant served as chairman of a precinct election commission. The regional branch of the state prosecutor brought charges of falsification against the chairman on behalf of a losing candidate in that election. The court found the following facts to be true. First, three members of the five-member commission were not present on election day, yet when the election protocol was submitted to the territorial election commission, all five signatures were present. An expert handwriting analyst claimed that the three missing members' signatures were forged by the precinct chairman. The analyst testified that the person who wrote the words for the vote totals (i.e. "ninety-five") was someone other than the precinct chair, and the person who wrote the numerals for the results (i.e. "95") could not be determined. An examination of the ballots from the precinct showed that the vote totals had been altered, with United Russia's vote-total being inflated by forty-eight votes. Finally, the court found that the facility where the territorial election commission was tabulating precinct protocols had been secured by the police, and that only TEC members at other authorized personnel were present.

The court found that since the precinct chair was the responsible individual for submitting correct results to the TEC, and since the evidence suggested he had forged the other members' signatures, that he was guilty of falsifying the return. His motives for doing so were "of no legal consequence." Reading between the lines, however, suggests a not-uncommon sequence of events: the precinct chair forged the other members' signatures so that the protocol would be valid, but left the results blank when submitting it to the TEC. The TEC, upon collecting multiple blank (but signed) protocols, is then able to allocate whatever results are needed across various precincts to ensure the desired outcome in the election the area under their purview. The defendant in fact argues this point in his appeal, according to the court's conclusion, saying that:

...by giving false instructions, the members of the territorial election commission, headed by the chairman, contributed to the very possibility of falsification and forgery of documents... According to the testimony of the victim Radzhabov M.R. the elections were falsified in 30 polling stations, so falsification of this scale could not have been committed if the members of the territorial election commission had accepted the protocols from the PECs in accordance with the legislative procedure.¹³

Neither the district court nor the high court appear interested in pursuing this line of

¹³Appeal Resolution No. 22-22/2020 22-2609/2019 of the Supreme Court of the Republic of Dagestan.

investigation. Even when laying out the facts of the case which clearly comport with this version of events—in which the real forgery is completed by the TEC—these higher-level functionaries are protected by the court. There is no curiosity about their role in the case. When questioned at a hearing, the members of the TEC “could not explain any significant information about the circumstances of the incident, saying that basically, on voting day, [they] dealt with the organization of elections, advising the PEC chairmen, and resolving urgent issues. As a consequence, none of them accepted the PEC voting results protocols.”¹⁴ The court does not, so far as the record shows, inquire further about this peculiarity.

The actions of the precinct chairman in this case resulted in the addition of a few dozen votes to United Russia, inflating the ruling party’s vote total from forty-seven to ninety-five. This is far from enough to be decisive in the outcome of even a regional legislative election. So what accounts for this case being brought to trial? The ‘victim’ in this case was a high-ranking regime insider from the Communist Party of the Russian Federation (KPRF). The KPRF is part of Russia’s so-called systemic opposition; while it takes opposition positions from time to time and can be locally active in opposition in some areas, it has largely been co-opted into a ‘loyal’ opposition through the distribution of offices and rents to its leadership (Reuter & Robertson 2015). The victim in question was a member of the republican legislature in the previous two convocations, and was a candidate in the election at hand. He was a member of the Public Council of the Republic of Dagestan—a consultative, para-state organization that links social groups with regional and federal level authorities. The alleged victim is, as a result, an influential member of the elite.

The defendant’s conviction and sentence was appealed to the republican Supreme Court. The high court, in agreement with the state prosecutor, upheld both. While we cannot know the precise motive which led the KPRF lawmaker to file his complaint, winning office does not seem to be the motive. The particular case involves a small number of votes. A personal grudge or community-level dispute could be at work. But it is also possible that the case outcome sprang from a bargaining failure between the ruling party and the co-opted opposition, in which the ruling party overstepped whatever tacit agreement exists about the distribution of resources in the legislature. It is perhaps worth noting that in the previous regional legislative election, United Russia won 62 out of 90 seats; in the 2016 election which figures in the court case, it won 72. So it is at least plausible that KPRF elites in Dagestan utilized the court system to penalize a United Russia agent for engaging in excessive fraud. Doing so sends a message to other precinct election workers that they cannot count on being protected the way that TEC members are. Dagestan is a plausible region for these events to occur; it is a high-fraud region dominated at the regional level by United Russia, but these features are undergirded by local diversity and elite pluralism. These are ripe conditions for legal mobilization against election fraud.

Comparing the estimated deviance in Kaitagskii district between 2012 and 2018 (the presidential elections before and after the sentencing of the precinct chair) shows that precinct-level deviance for last-digit zero declined considerably: from 15.11 to 3.47.

¹⁴Sentence No. 1-35/2017 dated September 4, 2017 in case No. 1-35/2017, Kaitagskii District Court.

This reduction in estimated fraud, a decline of 13.8, is the third largest in Dagestan. Three of the four rural regions that adjoin Kaitagskii district also saw relative declines in deviance. A neighboring urban district, however, saw a large increase in deviance.

Figure 6.4 shows a map of Dagestan with its administrative divisions. The districts on the map have been divided into three bins based on the size and direction of the change in last-digit deviance between the two presidential elections. The variable has been centered and scaled for easier visualization. Large negative changes (the bottom quartile) have been coded in light red; large positive changes (the upper quartile) have been coded in dark blue. Changes in the middle of the distribution, close to zero, have been coded in light blue. Kaytagskii district, where the court case was first heard, has been marked with a solid triangle.

The patterns revealed in Figure 6.4 point toward a possible mechanism for the transmission of information about legal risk. As the map illustrates, some of the largest declines in estimated fraud occur in districts that neighbor Kaitagskii, and are similarly mountainous and rural. The neighboring dark blue regions, where fraud seemingly increased substantially, are qualitatively different—coastal, more urban, and home to different ethnic groups. This is consistent with a version of events in which a ‘signal’ about the cost of committing fraud is received by front-line election workers within a similar milieu and similar social networks as the defendant in the court case. Information about the case, and the legal risk it demonstrates, can be spread through social and professional networks of similarly situated agents. In practice in Russia, these individuals are often schoolteachers (Forrat 2018). While it is also possible that this signal is received by higher level agents, leading a voluntary shift of resources by the ruling party, the impunity for TEC members across the corpus of cases (not just in Dagestan) makes this interpretation less likely.

6.7 Discussion and conclusion

These results support the idea that even a judicial system operating in highly authoritarian systems can have a restraining effect on electoral manipulation. A qualitative analysis of the text of the 225 cases on election fraud also shows that, throughout the late Medvedev and second Putin presidencies, the criminal justice system has acted to shield higher-ups from responsibility for even confirmed instances of election fraud; front-line agents occasionally take the fall, while the system itself continues to operate. The tension between the needs of the overall system—to continue to control electoral outcomes, to allow a modest level of judicial independence, and to legitimize the regime itself through apparent rule of law—and the risks faced by the weakest agents of the ruling party is apparent here.

A brief case study of Dagestan, an influential set of observations in the statistical analysis, also supports the general claims made above. The district where a severe penalty for election fraud was handed down by the court showed a significant decline in evidence of election fraud after the verdict. Similarly situated regions experienced a similar decline, while qualitatively different regions—perhaps home to agents from different patronage

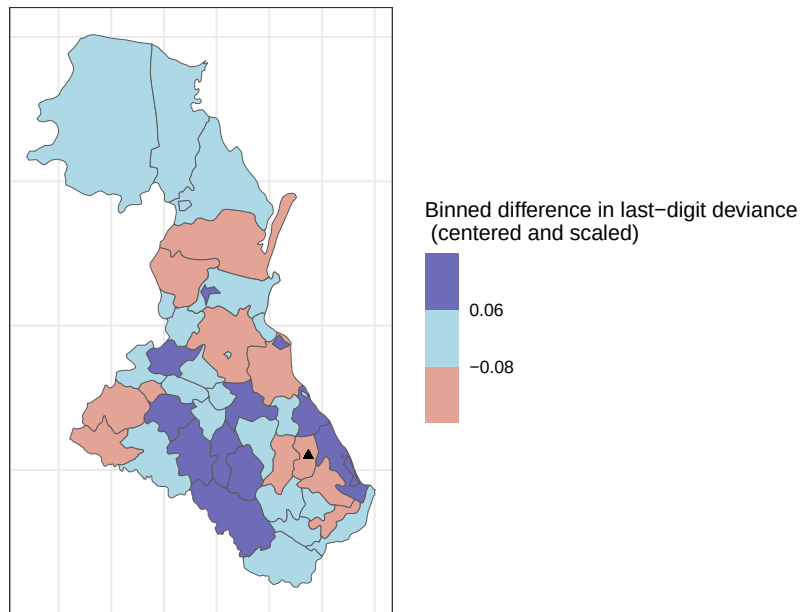


Figure 6.4: Dagestan: Change in estimated fraud by administrative division (2012-2018)

networks—show an increase in fraud. This result is in keeping with a model in which front-line agents, rather than higher-level decision makers, are a constraining factor in the delivery of election manipulation. Most importantly, it supports the claim that these agents take legal risk into account, even in a highly authoritarian and pro-regime region.

Chapter 7

Conclusions

In August 2020, the Central Election Commission of Belarus declared that incumbent president Alexander Lukashenko had won the presidential contest with 81 percent of the vote; with turnout at 84 percent, this was purportedly a landslide endorsement of the five-term president amid the covid-19 pandemic. Almost immediately, mass protests sprang up across the country; the protest movement persisted for months against a harsh campaign of repression (Onuch & Sasse 2022). At one point, as much as fifteen percent of the population was in the streets in protest, on par with Ukraine’s Orange Revolution (Gerasimov 2020) and far in excess of the 3.5 percent that stands a ‘rule of thumb’ for successful mobilization efforts (Chenoweth 2021). The size and scale of the protest movement proved a significant challenge to the regime (Way & Tolvin 2023). There was ample evidence in the pre-election period that a protest movement would emerge after a rigged election (Mateo 2022). In light of classic models of electoral manipulation, it is worth wondering why Lukashenko made such “mistaken decisions with regard to candidate registration [and] committing massive fraud...” (Styckow 2023 p. 815) rather than manipulate less blatantly or even step down.

Of course, many answers to that question can be advanced with regard to a single case. In light of the evidence presented in this book, however, it is likely that one answer can be found in the nature of election manipulation efforts. The same mechanisms which the Lukashenko regime relied on to ensure lopsided electoral victory—a large and politicized state sector, a well-resourced and loyal security apparatus, and a pliant judiciary—could be relied on to help the government outlast the protest movement (Deikalo 2025; Way & Tolvin 2023). Lukashenko could also rely on economic and security assistance from Russia to bolster his position. In the framework articulated by Levontolu et al (2025), Lukashenko may have been unpopular, but his regime was nevertheless a strong one. Severely manipulated elections and survival in the face of mass protest are both hallmarks of that strength.

Chapter 3 in this volume presents quantitative, cross-national evidence in favor of this interpretation. The results show that, among authoritarian regimes and electoral democ-

racies, the governments that manipulate *more* defeat protest movements more quickly. Moreover, the results show that authoritarian governments appear to manipulate *more extensively* when they face a greater risk of post-election protest. These results contradict a long-standing view in political science that greater reliance on election manipulation indicates deeper political weakness. In so doing, they indicate that a deterrent model—in which the risk of protest deters incumbents from manipulation—is misconceived.

Why are good manipulators also strong? Why is election manipulation not ‘cheap talk’ that signals little about the medium-term survivability of the regime? Exposing the machinery of manipulation—the role of the front-line agents who carry out the work of rigging elections—provides an answer. Front-line agents’ incentives differ from those of their bosses. Political principals want to win the election and win big (Simpser 2013). Agents, however, want to reap the benefits of belonging to the principal’s patronage network while avoiding any negative consequences. Unfortunately for both parties, electoral manipulation of the kind examined here requires that front-line agents break the law. This tension creates a principal-agent problem.

Authoritarian incumbents have incentives to allow for partially independent courts, especially when they rule on low-level issues. When courts can operate independently (to a degree), they improve the long-term survival of the regime by helping bolster legitimacy, resolve elite disputes, and protect investments. In the electoral context specifically, permitting a few lawbreakers to be punished helps demonstrate the incumbent’s impartiality and good faith to his supporters. As a result, the principal cannot credibly commit to protect each and every agent from criminal-legal risks.

Furthermore, the incumbent cannot perfectly monitor all of his agents. Agents are often selected for their local knowledge, and the secrecy of the ballot makes it difficult for incumbents to track how many manipulated votes a particular agent delivers. A risk-averse agent may be able to minimally tamper with the election (if at all), and hope that she is still rewarded by her patron. How are the agents’ political supervisors to know what proportion of the votes on the election return are manufactured by the agent? This problem cannot be easily solved even for the most direct forms of falsification; requiring agents to keep two sets of election returns (clean and doctored) further exposes them to legal risk if caught.

To mitigate these principal-agent problems and achieve widespread, illicit electoral manipulation, an incumbent must be able to promise patronage rewards and legal protection with high probability. As the risk of exposure grows, it becomes increasingly costly for principals to recruit agents who are willing to perform personally risky types of manipulation. Risky techniques are those which are easily *attributable* to the individual who commits the violation. Violations committed by election officials, being publicly known and easily monitored individuals, are those most likely to be eschewed as risk of exposure grows.

Chapter 4 tests this prediction in the Russian case. Using election forensic techniques, I estimate the degree of (highly attributable) falsification in each region, along with the degree of (less attributable) dispersed techniques like voter pressure and multiple

voting. The results confirm that falsification declines as regional competitiveness increases. And, as predicted here but contrary to classical expectations, elections do not become cleaner in those regions; rather, the evidence shows that dispersed forms of manipulation increase as fraud declines.

Similar techniques are employed in Chapter 5, to test these dynamics in the more competitive case of Ukraine. There, the lack of a single, dominant patronage network exposes agents to more uncertainty. As a result, falsification is rare and unsystematic. Other forms of manipulation, however, are common. Moreover, these dispersed forms of manipulation are most extensive in low-risk regions when a favorable president is in power. That is, manipulation is most severe when patronage consolidation is high and local risks are low. Further evidence of the importance of patronage resources is provided by demonstrating that consolidated oligarchic support in a region is also associated with a higher degree of manipulation.

Chapter 6 demonstrates the causal mechanism directly. Using an original dataset of Russian court cases related to electoral crimes, I show that the Russian legal system processes such cases even in a period of increasing authoritarianism. More than that, it is capable of imposing significant penalties on convicted agents, to include large fines and suspended prison sentences. I discuss why agents are likely to be apprehensive about their illicit behavior being exposed; once caught in the Russian legal process (itself a kind of machinery), it is difficult for individuals to emerge unscathed. Police, investigators, prosecutors, and judges all have incentives to successfully convict individuals caught committing an easily attributable crime like falsification. However, by the same token, they have incentives to avoid more difficult cases of vote-buying and voter pressure.

The descriptive data support the microfoundations of the theory, and quantitative analysis confirms the relationship. In regions where an agent is convicted of an electoral crime and given a harsh penalty, election-forensic analysis shows that falsification drops in the next election. By contrast, when convicted agents receive the proverbial slap on the wrist, evidence of fraud appears to increase in the next election. Finally, an analysis of the relationship between judicial punishments and election manipulation in Dagestan shows this relationship holds on a sub-regional level. Criminal punishment of illicit electoral malpractice throws a wrench in the machinery of manipulation by highlighting the risk to future agents. Permissive courts, however, help oil the machinery by showing agents they are more likely to be protected if exposed.

Where does this leave scholars and proponents of liberal democracy? The regime-strength / principal-agent model of manipulation helps us better understand authoritarian behaviors in the electoral sphere. In recent years, for example, Russia has experimented with online voting—a system so transparently ripe for abuse that pluralities of citizens object to it in polls. The legitimacy cost of such a system is high, but it solves the principal-agent problem. Electronic voting removes the publicly known, low-level election official from the act of falsification. It also removes the act from the polling place, both in time and in space. When election results can be generated by an algorithm, no one is at risk and shirking ceases to be a problem. Moves like this are more intelligible under the framework discussed in this book, than one in which manipulation

is always cheap talk.

We should also be attentive to the implications of this theory for democratic backsliding. As incumbents in democratic societies seek to aggrandize power, this framework suggests we should be especially concerned about efforts to (re)build patronage networks and to increase legal impunity for agents. In the American context, at the time of writing, the incumbent president is seeking to politicize the civil service, to change the rules for voter registration and voter ID, to subordinate the courts, and to pardon (or secure state pardons) for individuals convicted of election schemes in 2020. These are not only a scattered array of undemocratic behaviors; rather they are a set of reforms that would increase the incentives for front-line agents to manipulate elections on the incumbent's behalf.

I wish to emphasize that nothing in this book should be read to suggest that protesting against a rigged election is wrongheaded, useless, or unwise. There are many reasons to protest authoritarianism: to express grievances, to demonstrate solidarity, to build momentum and organizational capacity, and to issue a challenge to those in power (among others). Doing so under the threat of harsh physical repression takes great courage and often great moral clarity. Protest movements really can contribute to political openings in authoritarian regimes, and they really can help plant the seeds for future democratic movements.

What this book *does* claim is this: the risk of protest cannot be counted on to prevent electoral manipulation or to reduce its severity. The capacities an authoritarian government must marshal in order to rig an election are in many cases the very same capacities it must cultivate in order to survive protest movements. Put another way, governments that are well-equipped to rig elections tend also to be well-equipped to defeat protesters.

Instead, those of us who study electoral manipulation and authoritarian politics—and those of us who wish to see governments be more fully accountable to their citizens—should look more closely at the principal-agent logic of electoral manipulation to find ways to deter manipulation. What institutions, norms, or other conditions tie agents more closely to their principals? Under what conditions do those ties fray, as principal-agent problems worsen? Exposure of illicit manipulation and associated criminal-legal risk are the main factors at work in breaking those links in this study. If the courts, rather than the streets, are where the machinery of manipulation is most vulnerable, then the study of judicial independence and legal accountability deserves a more central place in the literature on authoritarian resilience—and in the practical work of democratic reform.

Chapter 8

Appendix I: Measuring electoral manipulation

Personal electoral manipulation, like falsification or vote-buying, is often clandestine and almost always illegal; as a result, accurate measurement of electoral manipulation has posed a significant challenge for social scientists and practitioners. This challenge has, however, led to considerable methodological innovation. Scholars have developed several techniques for estimating the severity of electoral manipulation, each with advantages and disadvantages.

Historians and social scientists first began to address this problem through archival methods. Allegations of electoral manipulation could be found in the archives of those institutions charged with resolving such disputes: courts, legislatures, and other election management bodies. O’Gorman (1989) examines allegations of manipulation in the House of Commons in Hanoverian England, while a pioneering study by Lehoucq and Molina (2002) investigates more than 1,300 allegations of manipulation heard by the Costa Rican Congress and provincial electoral councils in the first half of the twentieth century. Similarly, Ziblatt (2009) examines electoral disputes submitted to the German Reichstag between the onset of universal male suffrage in 1871 and 1912. Others have turned to reports of manipulation in newspaper archives (Cox & Kousser 1981).

This approach has the considerable advantage of unearthing rich qualitative detail about the methods of manipulation allegedly applied, and the conditions under which they were used. For instance, Ziblatt draws on historical details from his dataset of electoral disputes, in combination with other historical records, to demonstrate how local state capture by elites led to greater alleged electoral manipulation in areas where local landowners were most powerful (Ziblatt 2009 pp. 15–18). Research into historical manipulation efforts has provided a wealth of details about the mechanisms by which party agents tampered with elections (Argersinger 1985; Reynolds 1993). They can also provide colorful details; anticipating this book’s argument about legal risks to election-manipulating agents, Reynolds reports one election official defending his conduct be-

fore a state senate panel by noting “I ain’t no writing expert” (1993 p. 245).[^][Another colorful anecdote comes from Summers’ study of patronage and corruption in 1800s America. He reports that the 1853 election in New Orleans reported record numbers of voters in Democratic precincts, despite a pre-election plague of yellow fever that took 20,000 lives. Summers writes, “Splendid was Divine providence, jeered the New Orleans *Bee*, to show such selectivity! Strangers should learn from this to register [as Democrats] the moment they entered New Orleans” (Summers 1987 p. 54).

However, it also has the possible disadvantage of considerable selection bias, particularly when used in statistical analysis. As Lehoucq and Molina (2002) themselves note, there is a longstanding concern that the use of formal allegations of manipulation as a measure of electoral manipulation is likely to be biased by the strategic incentives and local organizational constraints of the complaining party. In a region where one party dominates, though it may manipulate the election extensively, the minority party may have little incentive to bring an allegation before what may be a compliant judge, electoral commission, or regional legislature. Moreover, the minority party may have little in the way of volunteers, activists, or employees in the region capable of monitoring the election and reporting on any irregularities. On the other hand, in hotly contested regions, the losing party has a strong incentive to report on any misdeeds by the winning party, perhaps even exaggerating them (and downplaying any excessive zeal on the part of its own activists). As one historian of American politics in the 1800s writes, “Indeed, to cry ‘fraud’ was the regular pastime of whichever party lost an election, and the historian must treat the clamor with caution” (Summers 1987).

Election monitoring by professional organizations, domestic and international, provide another source of information about the quality of elections, as defined by international standards (Elklit & Svensson 1997). In the years following the Cold War, states increasingly permitted international monitors to observe their national elections—even when they did not intend to hold fully free and fair contests (Kelley 2008). This development, over time, created a large corpus of election observation mission reports from intergovernmental organizations (e.g. the OSCE) and non-governmental organizations (e.g. the Carter Center), which scholars could draw on the study election integrity cross-nationally (Hyde 2011b; Hyde & Marinov 2014a; Kelley 2012). As with archival sources, election monitoring reports can provide useful qualitative details on the methods by which election integrity was undermined. At best, their analyses are disinterested and should not suffer from the competitiveness-induced selection biases in archival data. Yet election monitors may be far from disinterested—so-called ‘zombie’ monitors may be invited specifically to paper over electoral malpractice in their reports (Bush *et al.* 2024). Furthermore, even legitimate observation missions may downplay their allegations in order to maintain good relations with the host government (Judith Kelley 2010; Mochtak *et al.* 2022).

Beyond such strategic calculations, election monitoring reports are limited in other ways. First, in most cases they are aggregated to the national level; it is typically not possible for analysts to use election monitors’ reports to study heterogeneous electoral manipulation in different regions of a country. Second, international monitors are highly constrained in the degree of access they have to the host’s electoral process.

The size of a typical observation mission ranges from a few dozen to roughly one hundred long-term observers, plus a small number of professional staff (“Observation Mission Models” n.d.). There is often an insurmountable disparity between the number of precincts that a mission can monitor and the total number in the country. For example, during the 2012 presidential election in Russia, the OSCE fielded an observation mission consisting of 15 professional experts, 40 long-term observers, and 160 short-term observers. These 215 observers were tasked with reporting on an election that was conducted across 95,000 precincts. Of course, Russia’s size makes it an extreme example. Nevertheless, observation missions always face a significant gap between the number of personnel they can field and the scope of their task. As such, observation missions monitor a small fraction of possible precincts. In part to make up for this limitation, observers often travel from precinct to precinct during election day; they may observe the opening of the polling place in one location, the process of voting at another, and counting at a third. Political parties can exploit this variation by shifting manipulation tactics and location in order to avoid detection (Asunka *et al.* 2017; Leeffer & Vicente 2019; Sjoberg 2013). Election monitors may thus mis-estimate the degree to which an election has been tainted, and the locations in which electoral integrity was most compromised.

(Read more of this one: (Leeffer & Vicente 2019) for competitiveness and effect of monitoring on manipulation

These limitations contributed to the development of a new set of techniques for estimating the severity of electoral manipulation in the absence of any monitors: election forensic analysis. Election forensic analysis encompasses a “diverse set of statistical tools...to analyze numerical electoral data and detect where patterns deviate from” the patterns a clean electoral process is assumed to generate (Hicken & Mebane Jr. 2015). Election forensics have compelling advantages. They rely on ‘objective’ data; that is, they utilize the same results that election officials present as the election outcome. Forensic analysis can be conducted even for elections where no monitors were permitted. Selection bias is limited, if not avoided entirely, since data is drawn from all available precincts. It allows for subnational comparisons of election integrity across regions of a country. However, election forensic approaches also have drawbacks. It requires fine-grained election results, which many authoritarian countries do not publish. It can generate false positives, especially when analysis is not well grounded in forensic theory (Eggers *et al.* 2021a) or local case context (Deckert 2013). And, of course, it provides little in the way of qualitative detail.

Methodologists have developed a variety of electoral forensic techniques. Some of the earliest efforts in this area emerged in Russia in the early 1990s, notably by Sobyenin and Sukhovolsky (Sobyenin & Sukhovolsky, 1993; Buzin, 2019). Methods that compare precinct-level turnout to party vote-share, or that analyze the ‘flow of votes’ across parties between elections were likewise developed in the post-communist context (Myagkov *et al.* 2009). These techniques focus on overall votes, and thus estimate manipulation overall; they do not distinguish between specific techniques. More recent methods in the same vein include the ‘fingerprints’ method (Klimek *et al.*, 2012; Jimenez *et al.*, 2017) and mixture models that classify polling stations based on

the likely degree of manipulation (Kalinin, 2019).

Other types of forensic tools attempt to discriminate among the types of manipulation employed. A widely cited example, popularized by Beber and Scacco (2012), involves analyzing the distribution of the final digits in vote counts. In a fair election, these digits should appear uniformly: each digit (0 through 9) should occur with roughly equal frequency. Human beings tend to be poor random-number generators, and as such, distributions that deviate from the uniform may signal human tampering (Harvey, 2016; Skovoroda & Lankina, 2016; undlett & Svolik, 2016). This kind of analysis only detects a specific kind of fraud—human falsification of results—since other tactics may still result in randomly distributed ones-digits. On the other hand, Harvey (Harvey, 2016) has adapted the turnout-based measure (Myagkov *et al.* 2009) to identify some types of manipulation that result in actual ballots being cast (e.g. ballot-stuffing, multiple-voting, and vote-buying).

These tools are only as reliable as the assumptions on which they are based. While they should not be used in isolation to assess the overall integrity of an election, they offer valuable insights when combined with qualitative data like observer reports. A further challenge facing these tools is the possibility that authoritarian regimes may adapt their electoral process to evade detection. To take a recent example, ruling parties may introduce technologies like electronic voting to limit forensic scrutiny (Rothrock, 2021). Some scholars suggest that governments might even intentionally insert statistical anomalies into falsified results—either as a covert signal to superiors or a subtle provocation to analysts (Kalinin & Mebane, 2017). Election forensics remains a dynamic field, with ongoing innovation, including the incorporation of machine learning techniques (Cantú, 2019; Cantú & Saiegh, 2011; Zhang *et al.*, 2019).

Finally, expert surveys are used to evaluate election integrity at the national level. Such surveys, the best of which draw on in-country experts, should in theory aggregate a variety of sources of information; national experts take into account their own local, contextual knowledge in addition to relevant research on election integrity in their case. The Varities of Democracy project takes this approach; it aims to have at least five scholars or professionals “with deep knowledge of a country and a particular institution,” with preference for citizens / residents of the country (Coppedge *et al.* 2025a p. 29). Expert ratings thus have the advantage of possibly incorporating several sources of knowledge in each expert’s overall assessment. They are limited, however, in that they typically only apply at the national level, and can be subject to experts’ biases (Levick & Olavarria-Gambi 2020; Little & Meng 2024).¹

This book draws on all of these sources of information about election integrity, but relies most heavily on election forensic analysis (Chapters 4, 5, and 6), expert ratings (Chapter 3), and election observation reports (used throughout). This allows for an analysis that draws on the strengths of each method, while also compensating for their limitations.

¹Though others have found more sanguine evidence for expert reliability (Bergeron-Boutin *et al.* 2024).

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